STRATEGY TOOLKIT

AUGUST 2011

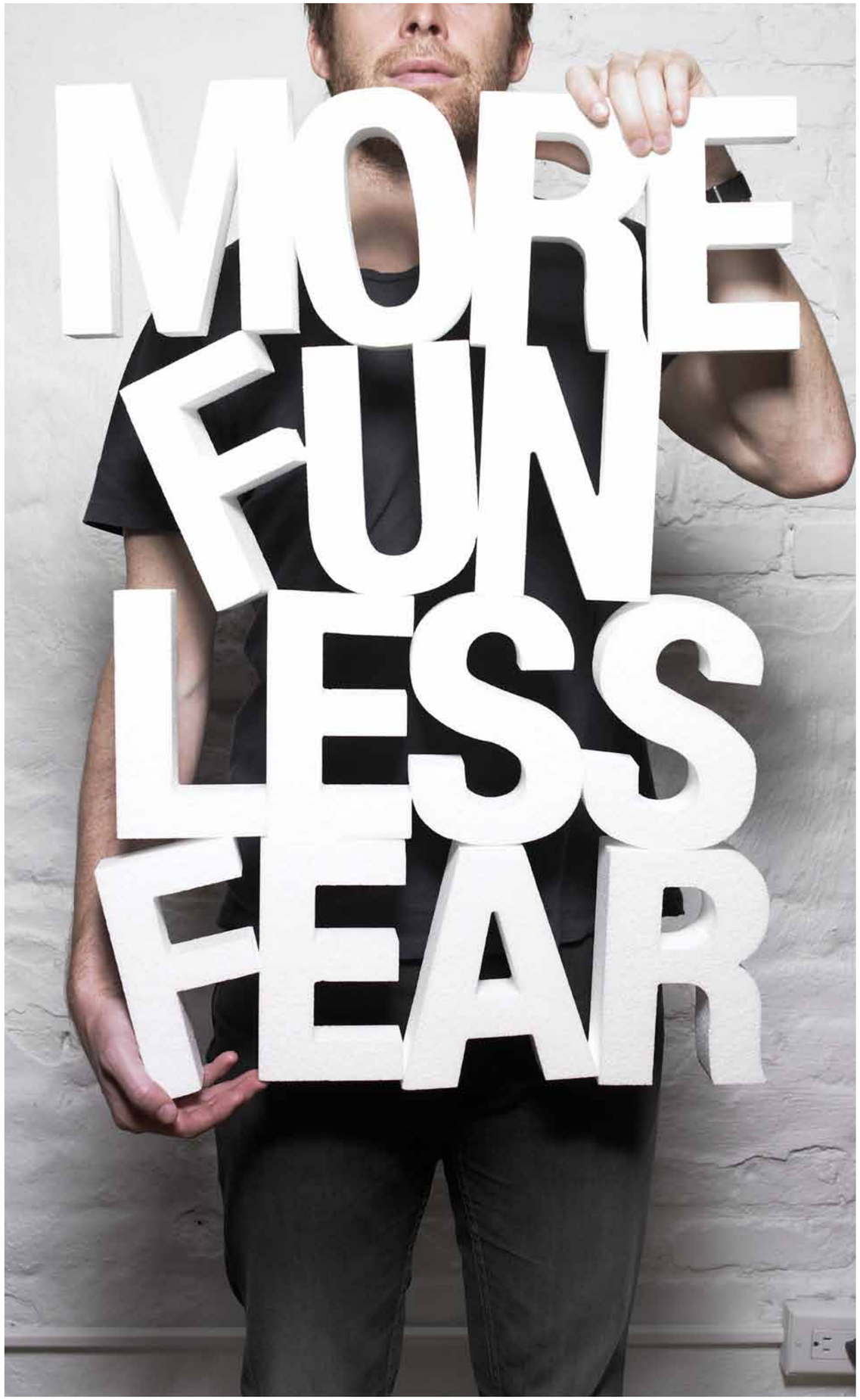
CONTENTS

4 INTRODUCTION
6 TEAM
8 HOW TO USE THE TOOLS
10 WHEN TO USE THE TOOLS
12 TOOLS AND EXAMPLES
124 KEEP IT COMING

A KIT TO CREATE GAME CHANGING STRATEGY

THE WOLFF OLINS STRATEGY TOOLKIT WAS CREATED TO HELP YOU LEARN AND APPLY THE TOOLS FOR DEVELOPING GAME CHANGING BRAND STRATEGIES. IT EQUIPS YOU WITH THE KNOW-HOW TO USE THE TOOLS ON YOUR OWN, COMING FROM THE EXPERIENCE OF YOUR FELLOW STRATEGISTS. VIEW THE TOOLKIT AS A SOURCE OF INSPIRATION, RATHER THAN A PRESCRIPTIVE LIST OF RULES.

THIS TOOLKIT IS A LIVING DOCUMENT THAT NEEDS YOUR INPUT AND ADDITIONS TO BE HELPFUL AND STAY RELEVANT. SEE IT AS A PLATFORM TO SHARE YOUR KNOWLEDGE, PROJECTS, EXPERIENCES, TIPS AND TRICKS ABOUT EXISTING TOOLS AND ADD NEW TOOLS YOU'VE WORKED WITH ALONG THE WAY.



WOLFF OLINS NEW YORK STRATEGY TEAM



AMARIS SINGER
Strategist

Amaris brings diverse experience from the strategic and creative realms to Wolff Olins New York. She has worked across a broad range of industries both in management consulting and brand strategy, working on everything from luxury retail expansion strategies to public health challenges in Tanzania. Her experience spans business, government and non-profits. Prior to joining Wolff Olins, Amaris worked at Interbrand and McKinsey & Company, both in New York.

Amaris is passionate about the stories brands tell and how they live up to them. She believes that strategic thinking and rigor are essential, but that there's no substitute for the unmitigated magic of gut instinct, good taste and thoughtfulness.

Amaris received her B.A. from Yale University with a double major in Ethics, Politics and Economics (EP&E), and International Studies. She has also studied at the London School of Economics and the Fashion Institute of Technology.



ANGIE RILEY
Strategy Director

Angie recently joined Wolff Olins from a strategic planning consultancy where she developed highly collaborative methodologies to help generate breakthrough strategic plans and winning brands. She is comfortable working with global and diverse leadership teams, and gaining consensus in complex decision-making processes.

Angie has worked with large corporate clients as varied as Johnson & Johnson, Liz Claiborne, MTV Networks and Cablevision, and a range of non-profit organizations. She also has experience in brand strategy for numerous consumer brands from Unilever and Frito Lay.

She has broad international experience having lived and worked in the UK, South America, Asia-Pacific and for the last 10 years in the US.



DAN ZUZUNAGA
Senior Strategist

Dan is a skilled strategist who possesses a valuable combination of strategic design experience and ten years of operational brand execution. He has proven expertise in brand development across a variety of platforms, including product, multimedia, environment and print design. He has led, built and partnered with multidisciplinary teams that approach brand invention from new perspectives and unique business models.

Prior to joining Wolff Olins, Dan worked as the Director of Design Strategy for Arnell's Innovation Lab. He crafted growth strategies dealing with critical issues of brand development, brand evolution, brand portfolio management and identifying new opportunities for a number of clients including Pepsico, Gucci, The Home Depot and GNC. Dan also worked at the Guggenheim Museum where he developed a methodology for expanding the Guggenheim brand through a network of the multinational institutions.

Dan holds a Master's degree from Columbia University's School of Architecture and a Bachelor of Arts from the University of Wisconsin, Madison.



JACOB COHEN
Senior Technology Strategist

Jacob Cohen brings 12 years of digital and brand knowledge to the strategy team at Wolff Olins. Well versed in a blend of knowing and doing, he's developed strategy, designed user experience, and managed the development of hundred of web experiences across sectors from industrial to fashion.

Jacob joined Wolff Olins from the integrated agency, Syrup. In his time at Syrup he played a central role in the building of the company from a four-person shop to a globally recognized, 60-person agency. His role during this time varied between managing the operations of the business, to overseeing account services to defining digital strategy and user experience for core clients.

His main client during this time was GE where he worked with an interdisciplinary team of agencies to define and execute the digital strategy for GE's ecomagination program. This four-year strategy included video and photography production on five continents, the development of first Flash site to render as HTML in mobile and localization of the product to eight markets. Ecomagination went on to win over 37 internationally recognized awards and continues today in the hands of a variety of digital agencies.

Jacob brings a unique outlook on integrating technology, design and user experience to develop new channels of connection with our world. He looks at how we use, and can use, technology to interact with our daily lives through web, mobile and gaming. He is a graduate of Emerson College and attended New School University for a Masters in International Affairs.

Past clients include: Activision, David Yurman, GE, Google, Issey Miyake, Lycra, Nike, Samsung, Starwood, Sony, and Victoria's Secret.

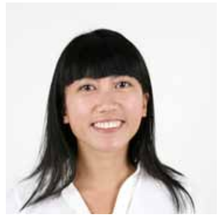


MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
Head of Strategy

Mary Ellen has over 20 years of experience in brand-building, both within Fortune 100 companies and at nationally recognized agencies.
A creative thinker who challenges the status quo, she leads teams to develop strategic insights that open the door to new, unexplored possibilities for clients and their brands.

Joining Wolff Olins after ten years at Target, where she successfully developed integrated brand-building and sales-driving strategies, her past experience includes developing strategy for high-profile brands such as McDonald's, Marshall Field's and Conde Nast Portfolio. She brings her retail and brand expertise to Wolff Olins, working with a variety of clients such as Belkin, Target, Living Proof, and PacSun.

Mary Ellen is a graduate of Miami University and received a master's degree from the University of Minnesota.



MELISSA ANDRADA
Associate Strategist

Melissa is a creative strategist bringing a diversity of experiences to the New York City office. As a strategist at Wolff Olins, she has worked on brand strategy, naming, messaging, and research for a wide range of clients, including Current TV, AOL, Activision, and the Smithsonian. Before joining Wolff Olins, Melissa worked at Big Spaceship where she helped develop and implement digital, mobile and social media strategies for General Electric and Wrigleys. Prior to that, Melissa worked in content production and archive for Idealist.org, StoryCorps, Couchsurfing.org and other nonprofit organizations.
Melissa graduated magna cum laude with a bachelor of arts in Comparative History of Ideas from the University of Washington and holds a master of science in Cultural Studies from the University of Edinburgh.



MARISSA VOSPER
Strategist

Marissa brings an analytic background, a strong sense of style and a passion for marketing to the New York City office. She has worked on well-known brands across industries including entertainment/leisure, destinations, food/beverage, financial services, technology and healthcare.

As a strategist at Wolff Olins, Marissa has worked on brand strategy, brand architecture / portfolio strategy, brand-led innovation, naming, messaging, activation, brand training and visual identity projects for a diverse array of clients including Tandberg, Microsoft, WaMu, PacSun, Citibank, Target, Pitney Bowes and PG&E. She has also worked extensively on trend research, both on macro and micro levels.

Prior to Wolff Olins, Marissa worked as a senior analyst at FutureBrand, where she worked in the brand consulting group on such accounts as the Museum of Science and Industry, the National Association of Home Builders, Intel, MasterCard, Johnson & Johnson and BlueCross BlueShield. Marissa also worked as an associate at Strategic Group where she developed sales and events strategies for clients including Coca-Cola/Studio Red, Sprite, Bridgehampton Polo and the Video Music Awards.

Marissa is fluent in Spanish, with academic and professional work experience in the language. She holds a BA in Political Science and Spanish Language from the University of Pennsylvania and also studied at the Universitat Pompeu Fabra in Barcelona.



NICK O'FLAHERTY
Strategy Director

Nick joined Wolff Olins New York after working in brand consulting in Spain, the UK and South Africa. In Madrid, he headed up the strategy team for Enterprise IG Spain, where his clients included Vodafone, BBVA, Motorola, the Rioja wine region and GSK.

Nick's insight development and brand positioning work lay the foundation for defining a brand idea. His work on operationalizing a brand helps bring the brand idea to life. Apart from the clients mentioned above, he led strategy programs for Ministry of Sound, SABMiller, Correos and Sanitas (Bupa). Nick started his career as a strategy consultant for Accenture working with Unilever, HSBC, JP Morgan and Standard Bank.

Nick graduated with an MSc in international marketing from the University of Strathclyde, Glasgow.



SAM WILSON
Managing Director, New York

Sam is the managing director of Wolff Olins New York and she has spent her entire career at the 'School of Wolff Olins,' building brands that both stand for something and stand out. Her formative years in the London office involved working with industries and markets as diverse as Tata in India, Hutchison Whampoa in Hong Kong and China, Merita bank in Finland and Indesit in Italy. Her work for UK clients such as Orange and Tesco delivered both business results and category-defining brands.

Since moving to the US, Sam has inspired clients such as Unicef, (RED), OshKosh, McDonald's and Target to think big and do differently. Sam firmly believes that by making great brands happen, businesses will become a force for positive change.

HOW TO USE THE TOOLS



STARTING A CONVERSATION
This category is all about new beginnings–building content for pitches, RFP's and initial conversations. Most of the tools here are used in streamlined ways to build a foundation for initial analysis and to better understand a potential client's challenges and opportunities.

TOOLS	PAGE
Industry Scan	14
Competitive Audit	18
–Competitor Audit Map	24
Macro Trends	42
Best Practices	36
Social Media Audit	30
Customer Journey	52
–Visitor Journey	58
Brand Butterfly	106



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS
The tools in this category help us understand the client and their business. By looking at the industry, the competition, the stakeholders and the customer experience, we gain valuable insight that helps inform and refine the project.

Industry Scan	14
In-Depth Interviews	46
Competitive Audit	18
–Competitor Audit Map	24
Semiotics	88
Customer Journey	52
–Visitor Journey	58
Customer Personas	62
–Ethnographic Research	68
–Focus Groups	74
Value Proposition Workshop	90
–Value Curve	94
–Choice Spectrum	98
Business Model Workshop	102



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS
This category is about building the right foundation for successful brand strategy development. These tools help uncover deep insights about the customer and the broader context in which they operate.

Industry Scan	14
Macro Trends	42
Competitive Audit	18
–Competitor Audit Map	24
Social Media Audit	30
Best Practices	36
Customer Journey	52
–Visitor Journey	58
Customer Personas	62
–Ethnographic Research	68
–Focus Groups	74
Expert Panel	80
–Super Panel	84



BRINGING THE CUSTOMER TO LIFE
The tools in this category help us walk in the customer's shoes. By bringing the customer to life, we are not only more empathetic about their needs, but also more focused on how the brand strategy can help fulfill them.

TOOLS	PAGE
Customer Personas	62
–Ethnographic Research	68
–Focus Groups	74
Customer Journey	52
–Visitor Journey	58



DEVELOPING A STRATEGIC SOLUTION
At this point, we take everything we've learned and synthesize it. Then we develop and test-drive potential brand strategies, using workshops with the client to co-create (and refine) the answer.

Brand Distiller	106
Brand Impact Quadrant	112
Brand Worlds	118
Value Proposition Workshop	90
–Value Curve	94
–Choice Spectrum	98
Business Model Workshop	102



MAKING THE STRATEGY REAL*
Once a strategy is agreed upon, we help the client to make it real with detailed implementation plans that bring the strategy to life across all touch points.

*Note:
We have developed tools to bring the strategy to life but have not yet documented them in this toolkit.



MEASURING SUCCESS*
After a project, we measure the impact of our work on the client, their customers and the outside world. Measurement provides perspective to the client and to us on the success of the work and can help the client track its progress over time.

*Note:
We currently don't have tools that measure the impact of our work, but plan to develop them in the future.

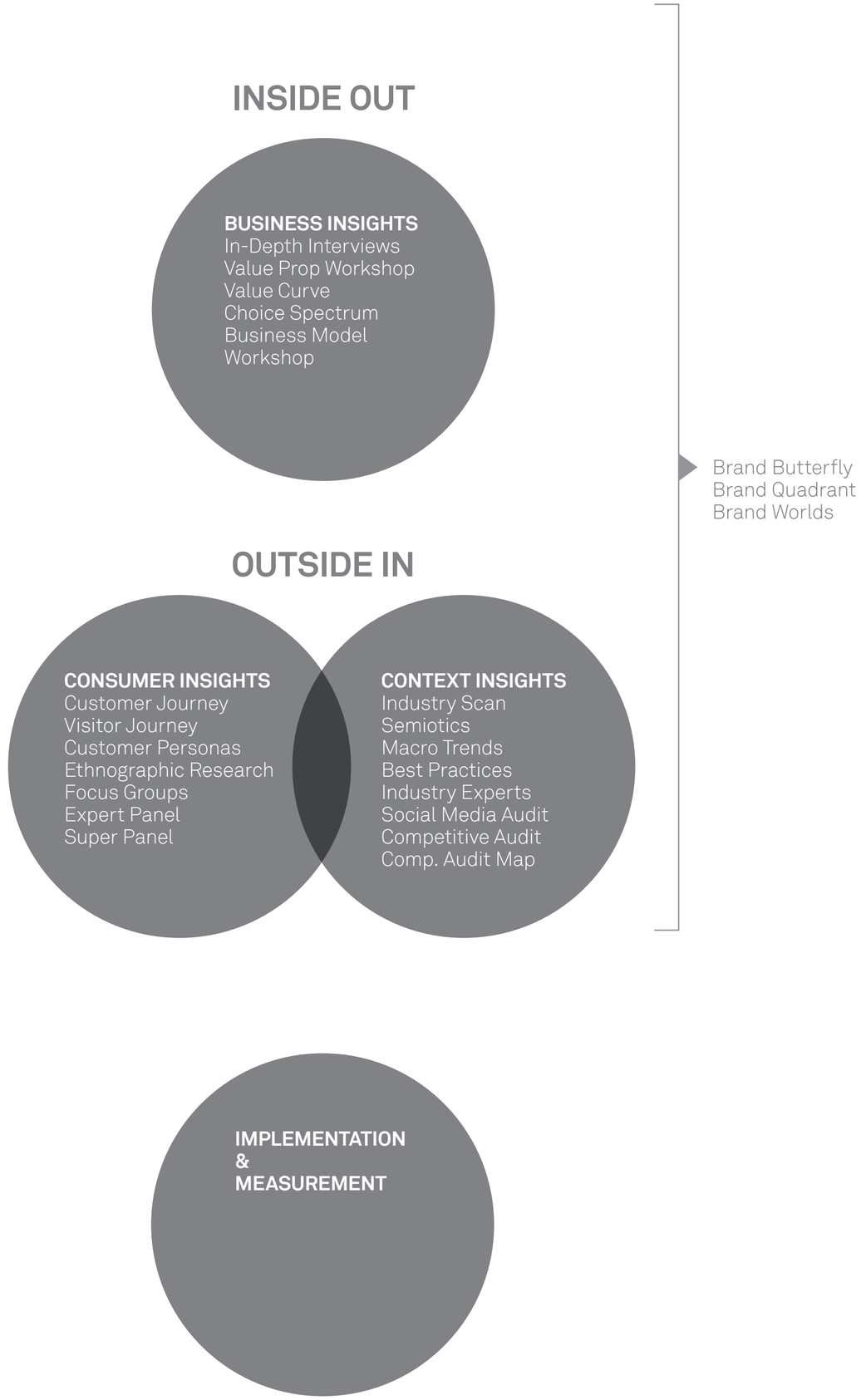
WHEN TO USE THE TOOLS

WHEN TO USE THE TOOL
We usually start out by looking at a client's business problem from the inside out, getting to know the business model, goals, data and markets to understand their realities, no matter how complex they may be.

Driven by curiosity we look from the outside in, in search of the most compelling consumer insight, the most fascinating macro trend, and the earliest signs of the next big wave.

All these inputs inform the brand butterfly, brand impact quadrant and brand worlds, followed by the implementation and measurement of the developed brand strategy.

Note: All original files of the visuals in this document can be found on the server (WO_Brand_StrategyTools_StrategyToolkit).



TOOLS AND EXAMPLES

INDUSTRY SCAN

HELP US GET NEW BUSINESS



STARTING A CONVERSATION



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
Background Research is a quick and dirty way of getting to know a new business prospect and functions as the base to start a conversation.

WHY
The purpose of background research is to provide the new business team with adequate information to start an insightful conversation with a potential new client and ask the right questions. It is meant to present the state of a company in a condensed and clear way highlighting potential opportunities, challenges and an overall point of view.

WHO
–Potential new client for WO

WHEN
–Often used to start an initial conversation in the pitch phase

WITH
–Competitive Audit
–The New Biz Get Smart Guide on the following page gives a detailed overview of what to include into the industry scan for new business

HOW
COMPANY BASICS
Sources: Company site / corporate site, Facebook page, Wikipedia, business publications
–Name of the company
–Size of the company (# employees and $$ revenue – if available)
–Basic business model (how they make money and from where)
–Company headquarters and other locations around the world
–Leadership team (names and brief bios – CEO, CMO, etc.)
–Brief history of the business
–Relative position in the market (e.g., industry leader, new entrant, founding player, etc.)

"I THINK IT WOULD BE GREAT TO HAVE AN EASILY ACCESSIBLE INTERNAL ONLINE ARCHIVE OF ALL THE RESEARCH WE DO WITHIN THE COMPANY. A LOT OF THE PROJECTS WE DO OVERLAP IN SOME WAY AND WE COULD TAKE ADVANTAGE OF THAT."
Melissa Andrada

COMPANY BRAND ARCHITECTURE AND ORGANIZATION
Sources: Company site / corporate site, sub-brand / product sites, annual reports
–High-level list of brands, sub-brands, etc. (basic brand architecture)
–Brief descriptions of how all the pieces work together

COMPANY STRATEGY / POSITIONING
Sources: Company site / corporate site, Facebook page, annual reports, press releases, interviews with company leadership
–Mission, vision, values, etc.
–Near and long-term ambitions of the business (stated or implied – e.g., grow the market, reach new demographics, expand internationally, launch new products or services, etc.)
–List of key competitors
–Optional: Brief SWOT analysis (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats)
–Optional: Summaries of recent ad/communications campaigns and list of key agencies

RELEVANT NEWS
Sources: Company site / corporate site, Facebook page, Twitter, press releases, stock performance, news publications, trade publications, Google news searches
–Recent changes in business performance? Stock price performance?
–New leadership or management? Other pertinent new hires?
–Recent changes in market dynamics? New entrants in the market? New relevant legislation?
–Any other relevant information

OPPORTUNITY FOR WOLFF OLINS
Sources: Analysis of all of the above research
–What's the game-changing opportunity? Re-invent the brand? Re-think the category? Build something entirely new?
–What are the key issues? What's at the root of the desire for change?
–What's the Wolff Olins angle? Why would we be a good fit?
–Why now? What's pressing about the situation that would make what we do valuable?

INDUSTRY SCAN
EXAMPLE: MEDEX

Project Description
Medex is a fast-growing urgent care provider with the ambition to expand their business across America. We sent a proposal to them in August 2011. They came to us looking for help applying their internal brand to their physical appearance. Because they don't have a strong mission and story, we thought their real opportunity was around developing cut-through brand. Our proposal was focused on this opportunity.

Timing

2 DAYS

Team

SAM WILSON
MELISSA ANDRADA

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
To provide a quick and dirty background on Medex's history, identity, competitive landscape, challenges and opportunities. This was used to develop an informed discussion for our call with the client and a point of view for our proposal.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
The beginning.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
Once I had a clear brief from the strategy lead, I began doing the research. I first started by visiting Medex's site – particularly their about section, news section and press releases. I then looked at competitors by doing searches on the New York Times, Wall Street Journal, Harvard Business, Google and Yahoo Finance to gain a better sense of the urgent care category. We used our call to gather more information on their history, ambitions, challenges and competitors. I built on the original research by looking at the competitors they had listed during the call, competitors in adjacent spaces (e.g. walk-in clinics), successful brands in health and the urgent care category abroad. This research was used to show the client that we have an understanding of their company and industry and develop a point of view for the proposal.

How much time did it take?
2 days

What resources did you use?
This research project was pulled off with one strategist and two interns.

How much did it cost?
The cost of the research is depending on the hourly rate of the strategist.

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
The background research consisted of a quick competitive audit and best practices.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Using the right keywords to find competitors in an emerging category – especially one that not many people know about

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
Our phone call was productive. We are still waiting to see the response from the client on our proposal.

Write-up by Melissa Andrada

Internal Research Presentation

CONVENIENT CARE CLINICS (CCC) OR WALK-IN CLINICS ARE FILLING THE SAME NEED AS URGENT CARE CENTERS, BUT DO NOT SAY THEY ARE FILLING THE GAP BETWEEN EMERGENCY CARE AND PRIMARY CARE.

CONVENIENT CARE CLINICS ARE MORE WELL KNOWN THAN URGENT CARE CENTERS.

GROWING PHENONMENON BECAUSE OF SOARING HEALTHCARE COSTS AND NEW LEGISLATION

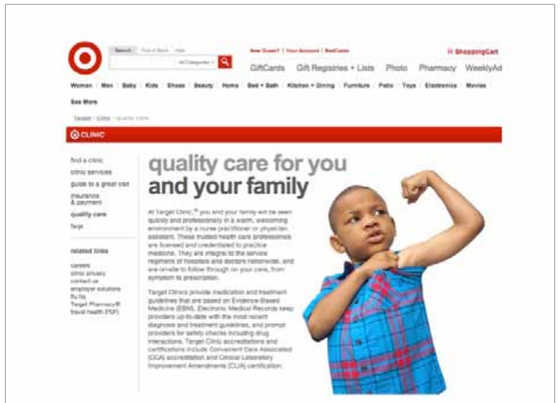
SIMILIARITIES	DIFFERENCES
CONVENIENCE	NO DOCTORS INHOUSE, USUALLY NURSE PRACTITIONERS + PHYSICAN ASSISTANTS
EFFICIENCY	CONNECTION TO MAJOR PHARMACY BRAND
NO APPOINTMENTS NEEDED	BROADER REACH
COST	
STORE FRONT	

TARGET

CLINICS ARE CURRENTLY IN FLORIDA, ILLINOIS, MARYLAND AND MINNESOTA

TAGLINE
QUALITY CARE WITH WALK-IN CONVENIENCE

PROMISE
TARGET CLINIC OFFERS TRUSTWORTHY TREATMENT AT AN AFFORDABLE PRICE FOR YOUR HEALTH CONCERNS



COMPETITIVE AUDIT

GET TO KNOW A BRAND'S COMPETITORS



STARTING A CONVERSATION



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
The Competitive Audit provides us with a deep understanding of the competitive space surrounding a brand. It helps us to discover opportunities and challenges within a category by looking at competitors.

WHY
The Competitive Audit helps us develop an understanding of companies in the same and adjacent spaces. It shows a brand's positioning in relation to its perceived and actual competitors, highlighting potential opportunities and challenges. It provides insights on where need lies within a certain category and how a brand can position itself or change to stand out.

HOW
We start the process by getting the client's perspective on who they perceive as their competitors. We then build on this list by looking at the whole category and beyond. The audit can be combined with a best practice analysis, focusing on companies who stand above the competition. Once we have completed the research, we put a story around our findings and develop a hypothesis based on our audit that defines potential challenges and opportunities.

WHO
–Brands in emerging categories, unaware of who their competitors are
–Clients with a 'tunnel vision' that don't see how the world around them is changing

WHEN
–Often used in a simplified form during the pitch process
–An in-depth analysis can be conducted in the insights-phase

WITH
–Customer Journey, brings the competitive audit to life, when walking through the process and experiencing who the competitors really are
–Competitor Audit Map
–Best Practices
–Semiotics
–Social Media Audit

"LESS IS MORE. IT IS IMPORTANT TO GO DEEP AND WIDE WHEN DOING THE INITIAL RESEARCH, BUT WHEN PRESENTING THE INFORMATION TO THE CLIENT JUST SHOW ENOUGH TO SUPPORT YOUR HYPOTHESIS. DON'T OVERWHELM THEM WITH UNNECESSARY INFORMATION."
Melissa Andrada

COMPETITIVE AUDIT
EXAMPLE: ASA

Project Description
American Student Assistance (ASA) is a nonprofit organization whose business model was based on guaranteeing federal loans. Their business model effectively ended with the termination of the Federally Funded Education Loan Program. They asked us to help them develop a brand for their new product, a student membership organization, which would resonate with schools, sponsors and most importantly students. We developed a brand around the idea of Money Coach — incenting young people to be financially savvy. We also convinced them to create a new name for their product — Salt.

Because they were so pleased with our process and team, this has led to new streams of work – so far, a campus campaign and architecture workshop, and potentially a brand refresh and employee engagement strategy.

Timing

2 –3 DAYS

Team

SAM WILSON
JACOB COHEN
MELISSA ANDRADA
DANIELLE HORANIEH
EXTERNAL PARTNERS: HUGE, KEN ALLARD

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We used this tool in a value proposition workshop to illustrate the following:
- Provide evidence that almost all brands in the student financial space are not speaking in the language of the student. They are either dry and boring or cheesy and literal.
- Show how generic their name (ASA: American Student Assistance) was and inspire them to change it
- Demonstrate where the biggest opportunities were
- Inspire them to think differently by showing examples of people in the student financial space who are doing it well

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
The beginning. We did a quick and dirty competitive audit for the pitching process, then did a more in-depth audit during the insights phase. We presented the audit during the value proposition workshop.

How was it used?
What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required? Using the student journey as my guide, I looked at who was present during each step of the process – from high school to college to real life. I focused on four camps: government and schools; nonprofit organizations; private organizations and banks. I used the list of competitors ASA had compiled and their pilot school hit list to begin my audit. I went in with a hypothesis that no one in this space is really speaking in the language of students; everyone looks and acts the same.

Once I felt like I had a strong representation of the competitive landscape, I took a hard look at my original hypothesis. There were a few exceptions, but for the most part, no one was speaking the language of students. I then narrowed down the competitors to support my hypothesis and show a few best practice examples.

I then created a quick sketch for production to create a board for the value proposition workshop. Sam, our freelance production designer Emma and I re-hashed the board a few times. This was a very fast and iterative process.

How much time did it take?
Two-three days to do the research and create a story and a couple of hours to design.

What resources did you use?
Competitor lists + target school hit lists from ASA and production help to design a board for the value proposition workshop

How much did it cost?
Approximately $6,000 (including time for research, analysis and design)

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
We used the student journey as a way of framing the competitive landscape – bringing it to life

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Simplifying and choosing the most poignant examples to communicate your argument is perhaps the most challenging aspect

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
It was useful in showing how dry, cheesy, literal and generic most brands in their space are, and the opportunity to do something really different

Write-up by Melissa Andrada

Competitor Audit Scroll as part of value proposition workshop

Your competition

Jargon
Complex
Vast
Text heavy
Boring
Cheesy
Literal

ASA AES ASC MEFA
FAME NEFE TG DOE
MOHELA FAO DOE DL
FFELP NSLDS NACE
PEAC SLMA ECMC
FAFSA NOVA WISS
HESAA SAT ACT

Pre college

Saturated college prep market

Ignorance around options paying for college



During college

Mountain of information from FAO + Government

Few Speak in language of students



Post college

Confusion around loan repayment options

Abundant job search ressources



The exceptions

Personal
Student-to-student
Simple



COMPETITIVE AUDIT
EXAMPLE: PAC SUN

Project Description
Wolff Olins had been working with PacSun for about a year, creating short-term seasonal sales promotions as well as defining longer-term brand evolution. At that point, a new CEO joined, who had a very clear vision around making PacSun a "branded house of brands" destination for fashion-focused teens. This competitive analysis was done to inform an overall brand idea to express that ambition.

Timing

3 WEEKS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
GEORGE CRICHLOW

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
For Wolff Olins to gain in-depth understanding of the category and competitive landscape and to support our strategic recommendation for PacSun's potential brand positioning. And for PacSun to get a concise overview of the category and help them see their opportunity to own a unique territory.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used this when we were presenting a brand idea and identity recommendation.

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
We analyzed the action sports category and compiled our own list of the competitive landscape, then checked this against our client's perception of their competitors. A junior strategist owned this analysis —he did desk research on all the brands, and created the template to consistently capture the branded aspects most relevant to positioning and identity.

How much time did it take?
Approximately 3 weeks

What resources did you use?
Junior strategist and the world wide web

How much did it cost?
N/A

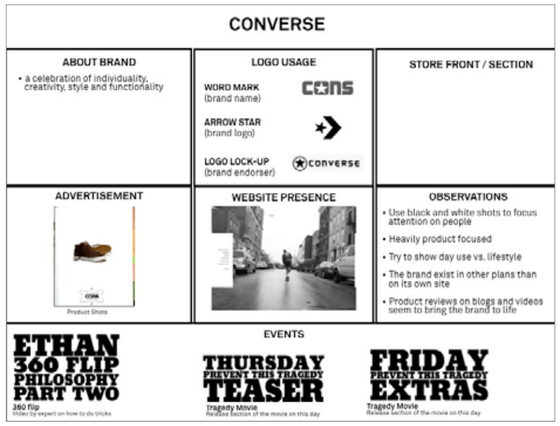
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
This tool provided context and support for our overall strategic recommendation, in combination with a consumer trend POV. Helped us ground and connect our brand objectives to business strategy and audience insights.

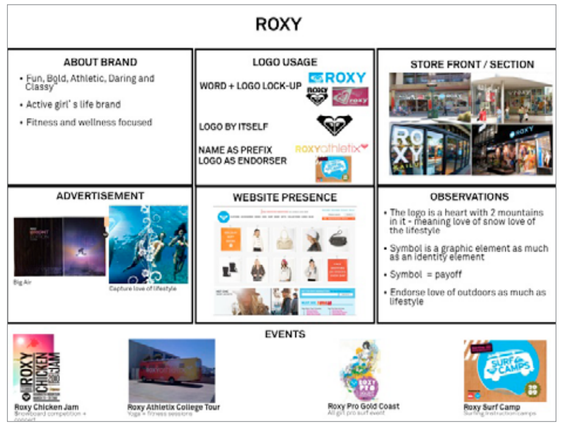
Which challenges did you face along the process?
We were limited by our access to the actual brand experiences because we did all of our research online. It would've been helpful to do more store visits to see the brands at retail, and ideally even some primary research to understand consumer perceptions of the brands.

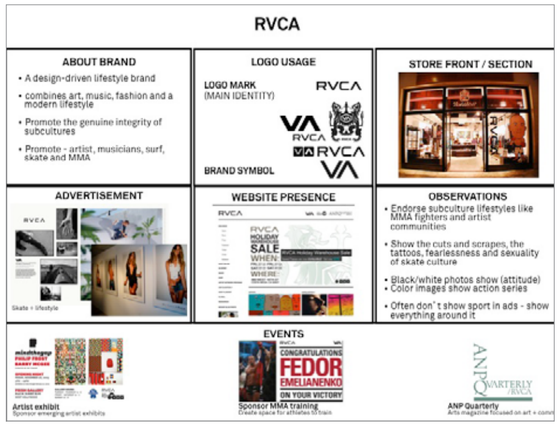
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
A well-crafted overview of the industry and competitive positioning, expression and experience. Showed the client that we did our homework and really understood the landscape in which they were playing. Gave them a complete picture of their category, and allowed them to see how our recommendation would be aligned with category conventions yet differentiate from the competitors.

Write-up by Mary Ellen Muckerman

Competitor Audit as part of brand idea and identity reccommendation









COMPETITOR AUDIT MAP

FIND NEW OPPORTUNITIES BY LOOKING AT AN INDUSTRY FROM A BIRD'S-EYE PERSPECTIVE



STARTING A CONVERSATION



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
The Competitor Audit Map is a tool used to visually map a brand's competitive landscape on defined axes, bringing perspective to competitors' positioning and opportunity areas for clients.

WHY
This tool helps us to understand the actual state of the market and builds a foundation for the brand idea development. By understanding the competitor's positioning "me-too" products can be avoided, while new areas of opportunity can be defined. It delivers contextual understanding, but does not give a definite answer. We use this tool to gain perspective, but then look beyond the map to go further and create the special sauce that will make a brand successful and unique.

HOW
To get a holistic view of the industry we conduct direct and indirect competitor research, focusing on areas such as corporate strategy, positioning, new innovations and communications. The different axes are then defined depending on the needs of the project. Positioning opportunities can be identified after mapping the different competitors on the relevant axes.

WHO
–Companies that need to find differentiation among their competitors
–Product that needs to be introduced or repositioned within a market

WHEN
–Very helpful in the discovery-phase of a project
–Can be revisited once customer archetypes have been defined to analyze overlaps in potential customer needs and positioning opportunities

WITH
Especially powerful in combination with Semiotics

"IT IS IMPORTANT TO REMEMBER THAT WOLFF OLINS DOES NOT DEFINE A BRAND BY WHAT IT CAN'T BE – DON'T LET THE COMPETITOR AUDIT MAP CONSTRAIN YOUR VIEW, USE IT TO GAIN PERSPECTIVE AND LOOK BEYOND THE MAP TO GO EVEN FURTHER."
Nick O'Flaherty

COMPETITOR AUDIT MAP
EXAMPLE: ASIAN ART MUSEUM

Project Description
The Asian Art Museum of San Francisco is one of the largest and most respected museums in the Western world devoted exclusively to Asian art – but for years it has remained one of San Francisco's best kept secrets. Despite being positioned as a geographic and cultural authority on Asian art and culture in the US, the museum still struggled to capture awareness and fully connect with visitors beyond their niche audience. In 2009, however, they appointed a new director with a ground-breaking vision and revitalized ambition to become the world's most dynamic Asian art and cultural museum.

Timing

4 WEEKS

Team

NICK O'FLAHERTY
ALICIANNE RAND
JORDAN CRANE

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We used the map to determine the current positioning of the AAM within its local and global competitive context. It helped get alignment from the staff and board where the museum currently was – and where they needed to go

At what point in the process did you use the tool and how was it used?
We used it in our insights phase – and we used it to gather consensus on where the museum needed to move from, and to. Additionally we overlaid their 4 key visitor segments on the map to help with decision making

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
Competitor research, board and staff interviews, trend and desk research, customer research

How much time did it take?
3 weeks to collect data (although there was an extraordinarily large amount of interviewees!), 1 week to analyze

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 1 account manager

How much did it cost?
Roughly $5,500

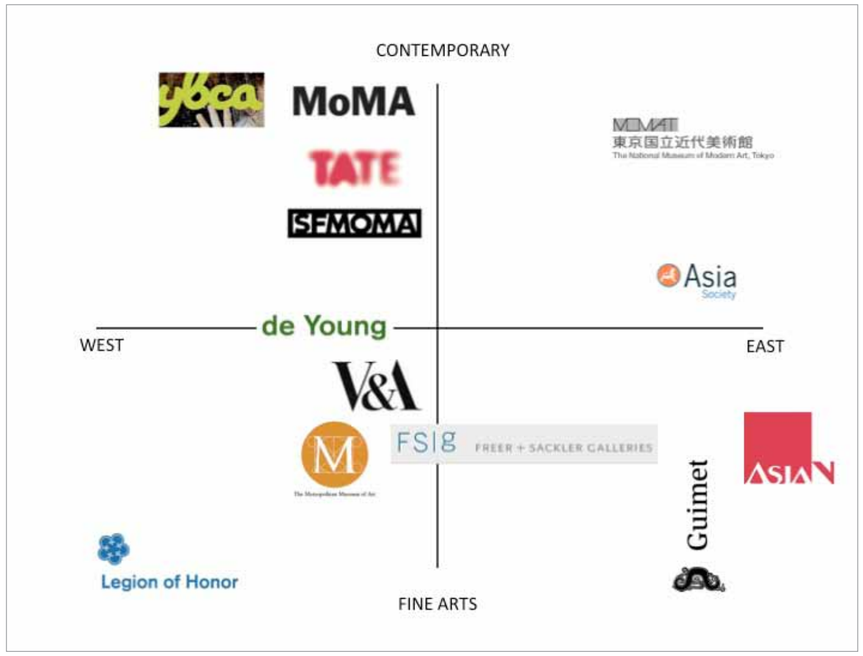
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Overall trend research, best practice museum research, competitor research, internal interviews, customer research (segmentation and ethnographies)

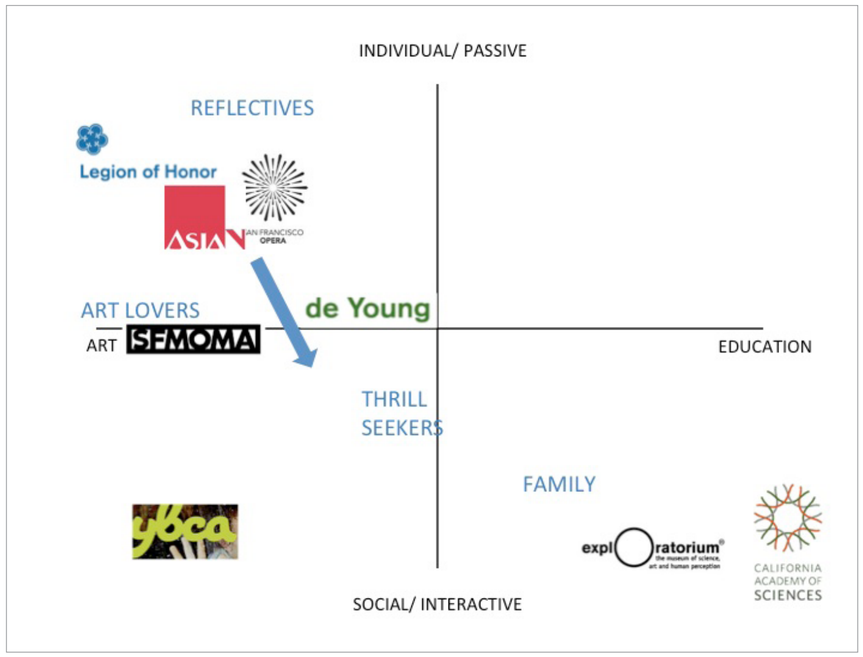
Which challenges did you face along the process?
Agreement where competitor museum brands sat

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
It helped align the client team around where the museum was currently positioned – and where they needed to go. It effectively formed part of the brief for us in developing brand worlds (ie. Creating brands that would help them occupy their desired position on the competitor map)

Write-up by Nick O'Flaherty

Competitor Audit Map as part of insights presentation





COMPETITOR AUDIT MAP
EXAMPLE: THE RITZ-CARLTON

Project Description
The Ritz-Carlton came to Wolff Olins in 2011 with the challenge of building out their rewards program. The original program (The Ritz-Carlton Rewards) had been launched rather quickly in the fall of 2010, and was based around the idea of Access to the Extraordinary. The Ritz-Carlton asked Wolff Olins to take that positioning and expound on it. The main ambition of the project was to create a rewards proposition that lived up to The Ritz-Carlton brand – one that was differentiated and truly extraordinary in the market, one that helped The Ritz-Carlton more deeply engage with their best customers, provided a clear filter for potential partnerships, and one that pushed The Ritz-Carlton to a more technologically-forward, more innovative space in the minds of their target audience.

Timing

5–7 DAYS

Team

MARISSA VOSPER
DAN ZUZUNAGA
EMILY SEGAL
JESSE DAVIS

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We used the map to look at the current global and competitive context for hotel rewards programs alongside luxury loyalty/concierge services. The idea was to illustrate how there were plenty of programs that offered extraordinary, exotic experiences, and plenty that offered simple utility, but very few that offered both extraordinary benefits and an easy-to-use structure.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
During the insights/discovery phase.

How was it used?
We used the map internally to understand the competitive landscape and to identify potential white space / areas of opportunity for the new Ritz-Carlton Rewards brand. We also shared the map with our clients during our insights presentation to facilitate a discussion around 'owning' the simple-yet-extraordinary space.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
We spent some time doing desk research around the various competitors/players in the loyalty/rewards space, and more specifically, in the luxury/hospitality space. We looked at their rewards offers, their web presence, any articles written about their offers, consumer testimonials, etc. We then started to talk about key themes that were emerging from examining this landscape and began to understand different possible ways of dividing up the space. From there, we created a map to help visualize the key findings in a very simple way.

How much time did it take?
~5-7 days total – including competitor research, map visualization, and various edits/tweaks.

What resources did you use?
1 strategy intern, 1 strategist

How much did it cost?
Approximately $17,000

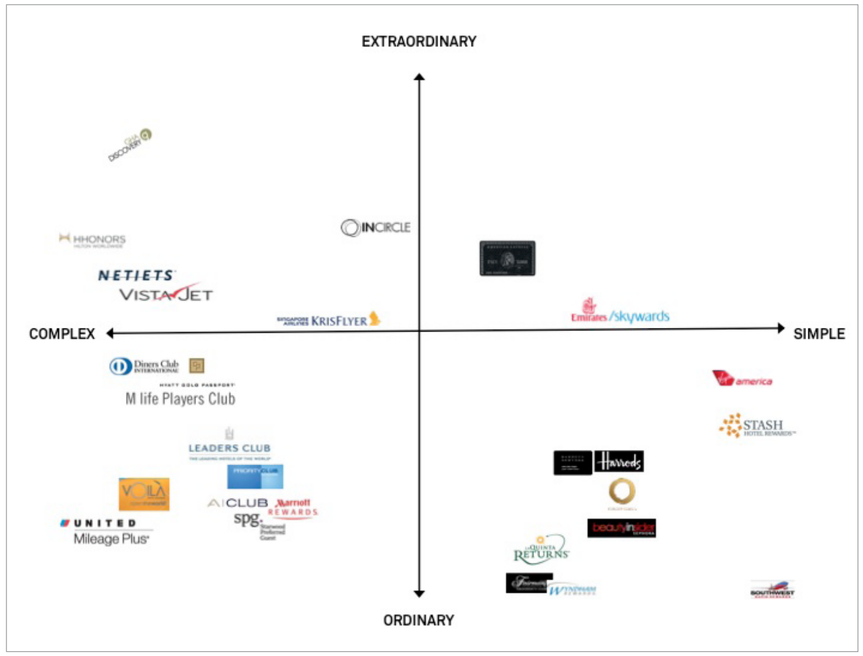
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes, we used competitive and trends/best practice research as the foundational content for our map, along with any insights from our internal stakeholder interviews about the competitive landscape.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
With competitive maps, it's always challenging to show the general trend/insight (i.e., there's an opportunity in the simple-yet-extraordinary space), while using specific examples, because it's easy for the client to focus on where you placed Marriott Rewards specifically (for example) versus looking at the overall trend/insight of the map. For this reason, it's always best to exaggerate the clustering of brands (and to shrink their logo-marks), so that it's not about Marriott being slightly left of Hilton, but rather about the overall insight that they're both on one side of the map, while the other side is empty.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The map was definitely helpful and really helped prove the point that owning 'simple' or 'effortless' for the customer experience would mean quite a bit more effort on the behalf of the Ritz-Carlton than what they might have previously thought.

Write-up by Marissa Vosper

Competitor Audit Map created during insights/discovery phase



SOCIAL MEDIA AUDIT

FIND OUT WHAT THE WORLD NEEDS
AND WHAT IS SPECIAL ABOUT A COMPANY
IN THE ONLINE SPACE



STARTING A
CONVERSATION



GETTING TO CONSUMER/
CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
The social media audit helps us to gain an in-depth understanding of how a brand is perceived in the online space and what customers are saying about it.

WHY
We analyze a brand's social media presence by looking at how it is engaging with customers online and what they are saying about the brand. We also look at the tone of voice they are using to communicate with customers and anaylze the brand in relation to its competitors. Instead of delivering numbers, we put gathered data into a valuable context.

HOW
One of the most important aspects of the social media audit lies in the tracking of sentiment – the positive, negative and neutral opinions. We look at how influential a brand is, who the people are it influences the most and the overall audience size. A customer service analysis provides us with insights on how the brand is communicating with its customers and the depth of engagement. Depending on the project we use a shifting list of tools, both free and paid, that helps us gain those insights (you can find a list of tools in the project examples).

WHO
–B-C clients
–Companies that are perceived as controversial

WHEN
– Often used in a simplified form during the pitch process
–An in-depth analysis can be conducted in the insights - phase

WITH
–Different tools – depending on the importance of the audit for the client, free tools can be supported by paid ones
–Paid tools tend to have better natural language processing, which means that their sentiment tracking ability is improved
–Competitive Audit – if focused on competitors

"WHEN CONDUCTING AN AUDIT BE AWARE THAT THE SENTIMENT TRACKING OF TOOLS IS NEVER ACCURATE. IT IS BEST TO HAVE THE TOOLS BUCKET THINGS FOR YOU INTO DIFFERENT GROUPS AND READ THROUGH EACH OF THE COMMENTS YOURSELF. UNFORTUNATELY THERE ARE NO QUICK TRICKS TO IT."
Jacob Cohen

SOCIAL MEDIA AUDIT
EXAMPLE: SMITHSONIAN

Project Description
The Smithsonian Institution was founded in 1846 with 'The increase and diffusion of knowledge' as their mission. After more than a century and a half of amazing success in America and the world, the Smithsonian realized it was time to think about the future. They began a strategic planning effort in 2009 and approached Wolff Olins in 2010 with the challenge of building a brand based on that strategic foundation. As our key client liked to say, the Smithsonian had become one of the world's most beloved brands 'by accident' and it was finally time to build a brand based on intent and ambition. The brief for Wolff Olins was to craft a brand strategy that would take the institution into the next decade: more modern, more relevant, more impactful, for more people, more often. With this brief we worked collaboratively with a large multi-disciplinary team from across the organization to define a powerful brand strategy and tagline that encapsulated their internal goals, but also pushed them to think outside of the box and live up to their potential as one of the world's greatest platforms for learning.

Timing

1 WEEK*

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
ALICIANNE RAND

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
What people say about a brand is a key part of our insights process. Social media allows us to gain a certain level of depth with regard to what people think about a brand and how they intend to interact with it. By reviewing and analyzing a brand through a social media audit we're better able to understand past, current and future perceptions of that brand among the people who are engaged enough to talk about them.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We completed a cursory social media audit during the proposal phase. The RFP from Smithsonian had called out a desire to be a more coherent brand online. We explored more of their social media perception during the insights phase. Some of this work was used in the persona work to identify target audience segments.

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
A social media audit focuses on the discovery of people's expectations of the brand and their resulting sentiment of their brand experiences. We begin by reviewing a current search of Twitter, Facebook and any relevant social media networks that may be industry specific. With Smithsonian we focused on Facebook and Twitter with some exploration in the scholastic world.

We first looked at the number of accounts and pages that Smithsonian had and began by organizing these pages by SI-owned and fan-owned. These pages and accounts were then sliced by sentiment of positive and negative themes.

Because social media networks generally remove content over time it's key to set up search patterns using social media tracking tools. (A complete list can be found on WOKI.) This allows the data to be stored and a more accurate view of the brand's sentiment can be captured. For SI we ran saved searches with automated alerts from the day the RFP was received until Brand Worlds began.

By collecting, storing, slicing and reviewing the sentiment data we're able to understand A) what people think about Smithsonian overall and related to specific events and B) how Smithsonian manages their brand communication online. Managing their communications involves examining the total number of properties and analyzing tone of voice in posts, regularity of posting, regularity and tone of voice in responding to users and understanding how feedback is or isn't integrated across the organization.

How much time did it take?
The initial review of their social media engagement took about one week and was constrained by the presentation of the proposal.

Further review could have taken another month or two to gather additional data and one-two weeks for review and analysis of data feedback.

What resources did you use?
–Socialmention.com
–Twitter sentiment tracking tools
–Ubervu.com
–Facebook search
–Twitter search
–Excel for slicing data pulled from these sources
–Additional social tracking tools are available but often require high monthly fees.

Since we did this social media audit new tools are available that could provide a faster review of sentiment and facilitate long-term tracking of the brand.

How much did it cost?
The cost for the Social Media Audit ranged between $28,000 – $42,000.

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
i.The social media audit was mostly used to back-up our perspective during the proposal phase. Its secondary purpose was to support the persona workshop.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Not having a clear set of tools means that social media audits require a lot of manual analysis of the data. While the data is the same and a human is better at analyzing sentiment, not having the most advanced tools at hand made analysis a slower process.

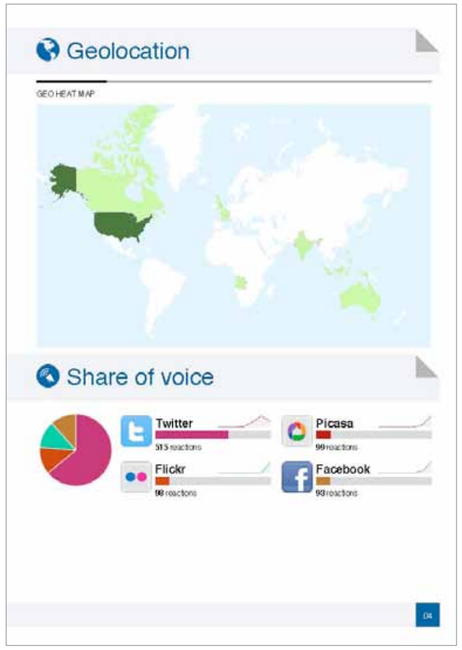
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
It helped us win the project by showing what people were saying about the Smithsonian.

Write-up by Jacob Cohen

UberVU metrics report









SOCIAL MEDIA AUDIT
EXAMPLE: MUSEUM OF CONTEMPORARY ART CHICAGO

Project Description
The Museum of Contemporary of Art in Chicago is relatively unknown in comparison to the MoCa, MoMA, and its other peers. We sent them a proposal in Spring 2011 to develop a new brand positioning to help them stand out amongst their competitors and expand their audiences.

Timing

1 DAY

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
AMARIS SINGER
MELISSA ANDRADA

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We used the social media audit to show how the museum is perceived online in comparison to its peers.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
The beginning – for a new business proposal.

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
Once we had identified a list of competitors, I began by comparing the metrics (e.g. followers, likes, etc) of the Museum of Contemporary Art to its competitors. I looked at the sentiment – the opinions of customers – by doing a Twitter search of #MCA Chicago and Twitter handle, seeing what people wrote on their FB wall, and doing a Google search of their name. I also used Ubervu and Social Mention to get another perspective on metrics and sentiment. I used GoogleTrends to get a sense of how actively people searched for the Museum of Contemporary Art in relation to its competitors.

How much time did it take?
1 day

What resources did you use?
UberVu, Social Mention, GoogleTrends

How much did it cost?
The cost of the research is depending on the hourly rate of the strategist.

Did you use the tool in combination with others?
No.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Measuring sentiment is always a challenge. There are no social media tools that adequately do this. You usually have to do a bespoke study through scanning and search.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
We are still waiting to hear back on the proposal.

Write-up by Melissa Andrada

Social media metrics summary

MCA Chicago
17,839 Likes on Facebook
3,869 Follows on Twitter
15,573 Channel Views, 63,651 Upload Views on Youtube

SF MOMA
47,328 Likes on Facebook
160,183 Follows on Twitter
13,714 Channel Views on Youtube

Walker Art Center
26,126 Likes on Facebook
153,737 Follows on Twitter
34,376 Channel Views on Youtube

MOCA LA
45,757 Likes on Facebook
16,695 Follows on Twitter
29,935 Channel Views, 334,547 Upload Views on Youtube
MCA has a solid social media presence, but in comparison to their peers, they could be stronger.

They seem to be effective in engaging with their current audience base.

People that do know about them seem to think highly of them [see Twitter + Facebook]. Public sentiment – particularly on Twitter and Facebook – is largely positive.

The opportunity is to generate more conversation outside their existing audiences.

BEST PRACTICES

GET INSPIRED BY THE SUCCESS OF OTHERS

STARTING A CONVERSATION

GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
Best Practices are used to identify relevant breakthrough thinking and practices from brands in the same or adjacent industries to inform a project with innovative ideas and to better understand change processes.

WHY
Borrowing best practices from other brands can help generate innovative thinking and motivate change. We look for insights and good ideas in unexpected places to counter myopia and reframe issues with an “out of industry” perspective. Seeing how certain innovations and best practices are applied and “made real” helps us understand the steps to create a successful path for your project.

HOW
First we start out by defining the few best businesses in the industry to really understand who is moving the bar. We then broaden our view and look at other players in- and outside of the sector focusing on the key elements shared between the subject and the client’s vision. Findings can also lead to further conversation or an in-depth insight study.

WHO
–Clients suffering from myopia who are only focused on their immediate surroundings and are in need of outside inspiration
–Sceptic clients that need a path to show them that it can be done

WHEN
–Very helpful in the insight-phase of a project to understand what is being done
–Can be revisited later on in the implementation-phase to find out how it could get executed

WITH
–Team brainstorming is a great way to come up with different subjects to be studied for the best practice analysis
–Can be used in combination with archetypes (psychographic segmentation), to see what different target groups are responding to

“BEST PRACTICES ARE A REALLY HELPFUL TOOL TO EASE THE CLIENT INTO MAKING A BIGGER LEAP. TELLING SUCCESSFUL CHANGE STORIES THEY CAN RELATE TO GIVES CONFIDENCE AND BELIEF THAT IT CAN BE DONE.”
Nick O’Flaherty

BEST PRACTICES
EXAMPLE: PG&E

Project Description
As one of the oldest utilities in the United States, Pacific Gas and Electric Company was struggling to find a balance between two increasingly conflicting priorities: focusing on the fundamentals providing reliable energy and service to customers, while also striving for innovation, leading the way in the fight against climate change.

PG&E enlisted Wolff Olins to create an on-purpose brand to unify their leadership around a powerful ambition, mobilize and inspire their employees and create a strong platform for growth the first since the company was founded 103 years ago.

Timing

3 DAYS

Team

NICK O'FLAHERTY
AMARIS SINGER
MELISSA ANDRADA

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
To offer the client inspiration on brands who have consumer-driven brand architectures.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
The beginning

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
Once I had a clear idea of the purpose of the presentation and a loose guide for beginning the research, I got started by looking at a hand-written list of potential 'best-practice' companies and a folder of screenshots Amaris had put together. I used this list as my base, but then veered off it by thinking about brands and industries that traditionally do not do a good job of connecting with consumers. When I felt like I had an adequate number of examples, I narrowed them down to form a story.

How much time did it take?
3 days

What resources did you use?
It took one strategist to craft the presentation, with input from the main project strategists. The presentation took the form of power point.

How much did it cost?
Approximately $6,000 - $10,000

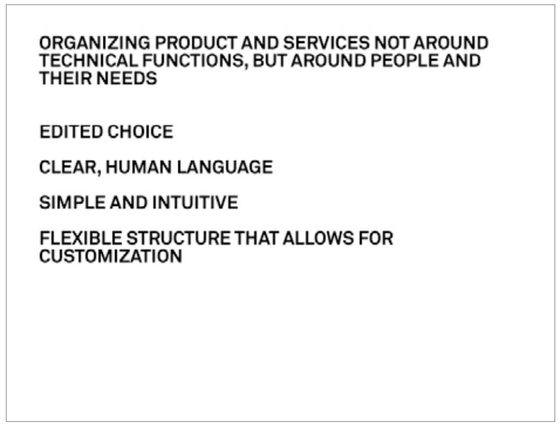
Did you use the tool in combination with others?
No.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Narrowing down the examples and creating a story around them is probably the biggest challenge.

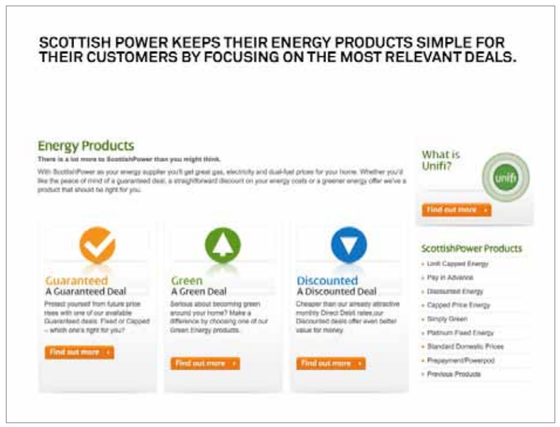
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
To my knowledge (I didn't present the work to the client), the client was pleased with the presentation.

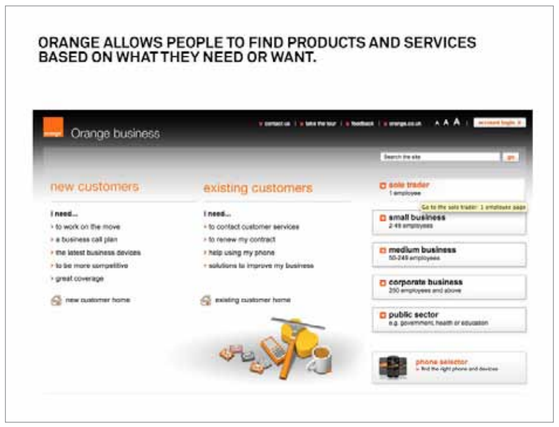
Write-up by Melissa Andrada

Examples of best practice analysis PowerPoint presentation











BEST PRACTICES
EXAMPLE: BELKIN

Project Description
Belkin came to Wolff Olins in need of a clarified, more focused brand purpose and visual identity. After many years of organic, somewhat haphazard-yet-successful growth, Belkin had grown out of the 'start-up stage,' but in many ways, still behaved like one. Wolff Olins helped Belkin position themselves for the next chapter of their business.

Timing

5 DAYS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
JORDAN CRANE
JESSE DAVIS
AMARIS SINGER

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
Best practice research is a great internal 'get smart' tool that we often use to help ground our thinking in what other, direct or indirect competitor/peer brands are doing in the world. In the case of Belkin, it was important to explore innovations in the retail space as well as consumer product companies to provide aspirational benchmarks for the new Belkin brand strategy and identity.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We did this research early on in the process – during the insights-gathering / discovery phase.

How was it used?
It was mainly used as an internal 'get smart' tool for the WO team. Some of our key insights from the research were later used in our insights presentation to the client, but not the entire research document.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
These best practices were entirely desk research-based. We basically spent about a week searching online (articles, trade publications, trend reports, brand media, etc.) for innovative examples in the retail and consumer products space and then organized our findings into a short PowerPoint deck to showcase the examples, sources and other relevant information we found.

How much time did it take?
~5 days

What resources did you use?
1 strategist

How much did it cost?
Approximately $11,000

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes, as part of our insights phase, we used best practices research along with competitive research, internal stakeholder interviews, semiotics and in-field research (store visits) to inform what eventually became our insights presentation.

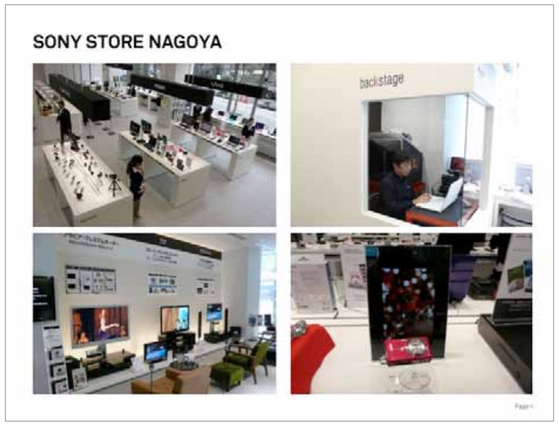
Which challenges did you face along the process?
This was pretty straightforward research – always can be made stronger with more input, but in a short period of time, it's just a matter of searching until you find something interesting.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
It was more useful to WO internally, but some of our findings were used to help demonstrate our understanding of the industry and to provide inspiration of innovative things happening in and outside of Belkin's direct competitive set.

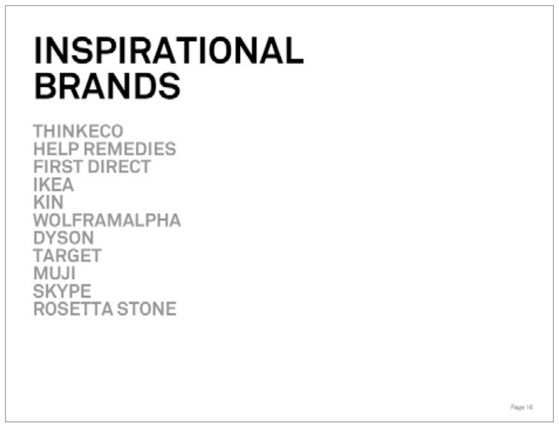
Write-up by Marissa Vosper

Best practice analysis created during insights-gathering/discovery phase

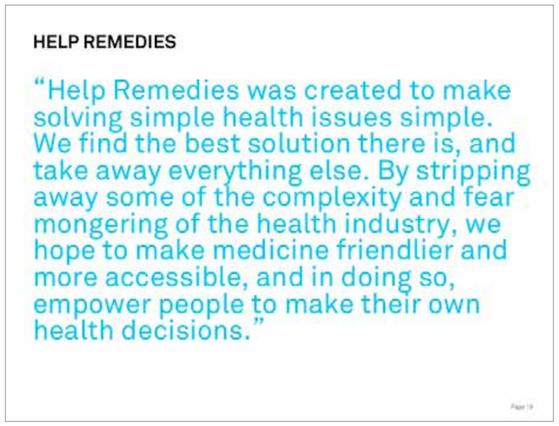












MACRO TRENDS

TAKE ADVANTAGE OF CULTURAL SHIFTS



STARTING A CONVERSATION



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
Macro Trends are universally shared developments in behavior that offer insight into how consumer needs will evolve and which business strategies are therefore more likely to be successful.

WHY
Macro Trends help us to understand how consumers live and what major cultural shifts can be taken advantage of. They function as a base to connect ideas to global patterns and create successful strategies around them. Identifying drivers at the right time can help us identify potential challenges, leverage momentum and trigger an opportunity for the client's business. It is especially useful as a soundboard to test the legitimacy of solutions.

HOW
Macro Trends can be discovered in a variety of ways, but are mostly based on desk research, brainstorms, and general observations. Shifts in demographics, economics, environment, society and technology can be indicators to relevant changes. To pinpoint bigger trends in the world, different movements, behavioral changes, new products and innovations are being grouped into various categories, which can define different trends. We look beyond the obvious and find thought-provoking examples that function as foundation for brand strategy development. Multimedia examples are a powerful way of demonstrating different trends in an engaging way.

WHO
–Clients who lack confidence and need to be motivated and inspired
–Companies that focus too much on their own world and don't think outside of it

WHEN
–Most effective at the insights stage of a project
–Can be revisited during the brand worlds-phase, to validate the thinking behind different directions

WITH
Best Practices

"I ALWAYS TRY TO AGGREGATE EXAMPLES CLIENTS CAN'T WAIT TO LOOK AT AFTER THE MEETING IS OVER. THINGS THAT PEOPLE REALLY WANT TO KNOW ABOUT, AND THAT ARE NOT EASILY FORGOTTEN."
Marissa Vosper

MACRO TRENDS
EXAMPLE: SMITHSONIAN

Project Description
The Smithsonian Institution was founded in 1846 with 'The increase and diffusion of knowledge' as their mission. After more than a century and a half of amazing success in America and the world, the Smithsonian realized it was time to think about the future. They began a strategic planning effort in 2009 and approached Wolff Olins in 2010 with the challenge of building a brand based on that strategic foundation. As our key client liked to say, the Smithsonian had become one of the world's most beloved brands 'by accident' and it was finally time to build a brand based on intent and ambition. The brief for Wolff Olins was to craft a brand strategy that would take the institution into the next decade: more modern, more relevant, more impactful, for more people, more often. With this brief we worked collaboratively with a large multi-disciplinary team from across the organization to define a powerful brand strategy and tagline that encapsulated their internal goals, but also pushed them to think outside of the box and live up to their potential as one of the world's greatest platforms for learning.

Timing

3+ WEEKS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
ALICIANNE RAND
MELISSA ANDRADA

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The Smithsonian was a very traditional, somewhat dated and not very innovative organization. They were falling behind the times and we needed to show them how much the world had changed and is changing. We did internal desk research exploring macro trends to help open their eyes to changes in the world now and in the future. a

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used our macro trends research during the discovery/ insights phase of our project.

How was it used?
We presented the work to them to level set and to provide additional input into the "What the world needs" piece of the brand butterfly.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
The majority of the work was based on desk research – articles related to innovations/ trends in culture and education, industry publications, searching for interesting examples / case studies among cultural institutions and educational organizations around the world, other trend reports, etc. We also referenced some large-scale quantitative research from our research partners – The Futures Company – that outlined their perspective on general macro trends in the world.

How much time did it take?
Part of our overall insights phase – around 3+ weeks

What resources did you use?
1-2 strategists to do the bulk of the research, 1 designer to help visualize our macro trends chart

How much did it cost?
The Smithsonian insights phase (including macro trends, interviews, desk research, ethnographic research prep, etc) cost $221,395.

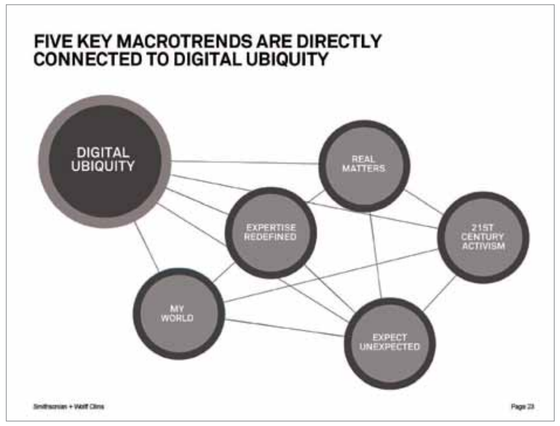
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes, these trends were used in combination with ethnographic research to provide a comprehensive view of people + the world, which created the content for our "What the world needs" piece of the brand butterfly.

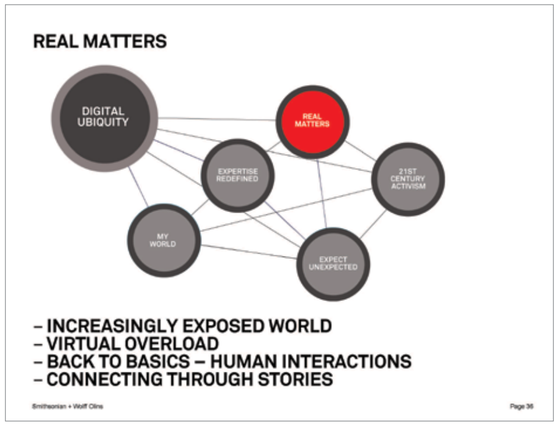
Which challenges did you face along the process?
Culling down huge amounts of research is always a challenge. It was good to have external eyes on the work (people who didn't do the actual research) to help edit down and tell a compelling, clear story.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The client really loved this work. It was eye-opening to some and validating to others. We found examples in the world that were really unique and interesting, but also relevant to the Smithsonian specifically – plenty of people left the meeting saying "I need to go google that!"

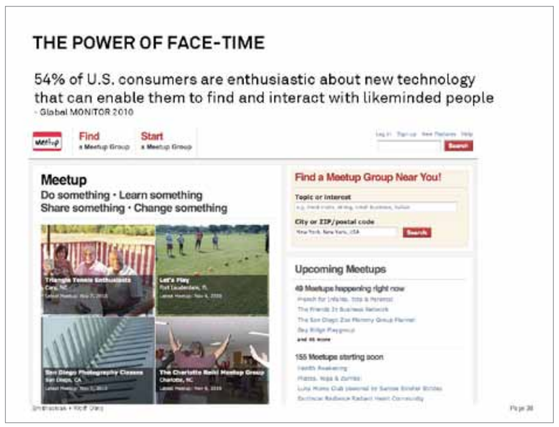
Write-up by Marissa Vosper

Macro Trend analysis as part of insights presentation













IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS

GET TO KNOW THE CLIENT
ON A DEEPER LEVEL

UNDERSTANDING THE
CLIENT'S BUSINESS

WHAT
The in-depth interview is an open-ended, discovery-oriented method used to explore the expertise, points of view and attitudes of a company's internal stakeholders.

WHY
A deep-dive into the internal side of a company is essential to help us understand its inner workings, organizational structure and the perspectives of those that know the business best. Conversations with stakeholders can help highlight potential roadblocks and address ways to move around them. In-depth interviews are the best way to get to know the client on a deeper level by understanding ambition, business imperatives, internal dynamics, external forces and definitions of success for the project.

HOW
Depending on the needs and scope of the project, an appropriate number of internal stakeholders will be selected as interviewees based on criteria we develop beforehand with the client. We then design a high-level discussion guide based around relevant issues for the project at hand. We tend to approach the interviews as flexible conversations versus rigid questionnaires, always allowing for the possibility of new areas of inquiry to arise during the interviews. The guide can be customized for each conversation depending on the position and area of expertise of each interviewee. We capture our conversations in notes and analyze them in aggregate to identify key themes. We often use direct (anonymous) quotes from the interviews to highlight an insight, support an argument or refute a previous assumption.

WHO
–Companies that want to make a big change to their brand, - e.g., business model, brand architecture, brand purpose projects

WHEN
Most effective during the beginning phase of the project

WITH
–Interviews can be conducted in person or on the phone
–Best done with one or two interviewers and one note-taker

"AT THE END OF THE INTERVIEW I ALWAYS LIKE TO ASK THE INTERVIEWEE IF THERE IS ANYTHING THEY WOULD LIKE TO SHARE, OR ANYTHING I FORGOT ABOUT. SOMETIMES PEOPLE KEEP THEIR THOUGHTS TO THEMSELVES, SO ASKING THEM DIRECTLY CAN LEAD TO INTERESTING INSIGHTS."
Dan Zuzunaga

IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS
EXAMPLE: ACTIVISION

Project Description
We were approached by Activision to help define the future of the highly successful Call of Duty franchise. As the single most successful entertainment property in history, Activision is highly invested in ongoing success of Call of Duty. The challenge that Activision faced was ensuring consistency and improving the decision making process. The Call of Duty brand needed to provide both flexibility to evolve each year and the rigidity to remain true to its roots. We were initially tasked with revising a set of brand equities that were created in-house to reverse engineer the Call of Duty magic. Our deliverable became a set of decision-making tools to help define the brand from development through advertising.

Timing

2 WEEKS

Team

FRANK STRIEFLER
JESSE DAVIS
PAUL WORTHINGTON
JACOB COHEN

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
Activision felt they didn't have a clear vision or set of tools to understand what made a great Call of Duty game. By conducting a series of in-depth stakeholder interviews we were able to gather knowledge from across the organization.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We conducted the interviews at the beginning of the project during the Insights Phase.

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
i.We began by working with the client to determine a list of key stakeholders throughout Activision who each held core responsibilities for the future of Call of Duty.
ii.We then wrote a set of questions used to identify what made the brand a success and where the interviewee saw the brand in the future.

How much time did it take?
i.The interview process took a total of two weeks with one week of intensive in-person interviews and a second week of phone interviews.

What resources did you use?
i.Brains! Used 'em all up.
ii.We developed a set of questions with the client designed to capture hidden knowledge of the brand and identify insights into its future.

How much did it cost?
i.The In-Depth Interviews overall cost about $113,000. The synthesis of the insights presentation (including all other types of research conducted) cost about $97,000.

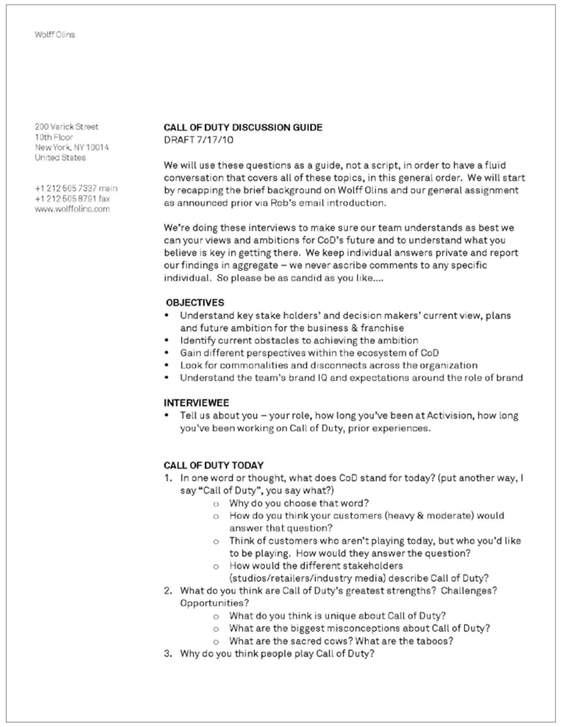
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
i.Internal in-depth interviews were used in conjunction with 16 focus groups and detailed trends research in order to identify what is special about the Call of Duty brand and how it compared to expectations of gamers.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
The elements of Call of Duty that made it a success were lost when the original game developers left Activision. Our job was to be treasure hunters searching for the secret recipe.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
–The internal interviews were the first time that so many stakeholders had given input on what Call of Duty means to them. There was extremely positive feedback from this process as each group and stakeholder felt they finally had a say in the future of the game.
–The client benefited overall by having all this knowledge collected and a system in place to optimize decision-making.

Write-up by Jacob Cohen

Discussion guide



Wolff Olins

200 Varick Street
10th Floor
New York, NY 10014
United States

+1 212 505 7337 main
+1 212 505 8791 fax
www.wolffolins.com

CALL OF DUTY DISCUSSION GUIDE
DRAFT 7/17/10

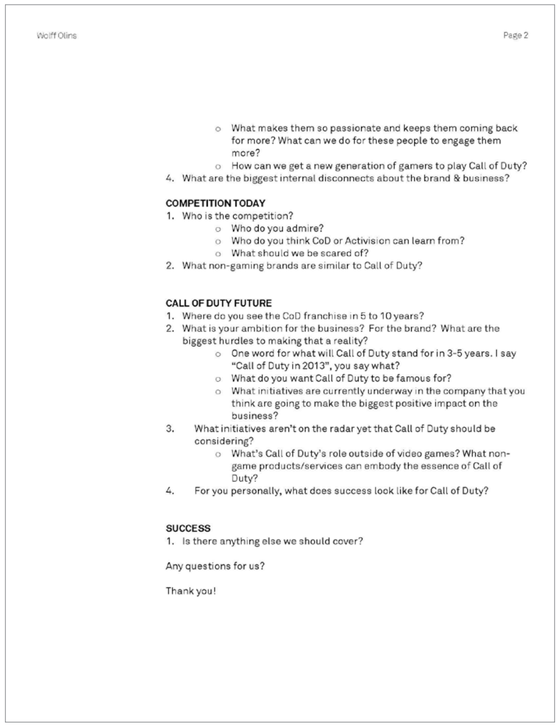
We will use these questions as a guide, not a script, in order to have a fluid conversation that covers all of these topics, in this general order. We will start by recapping the brief background on Wolff Olins and our general assignment as announced prior via Rob's email introduction.

We're doing these interviews to make sure our team understands as best we can your views and ambitions for CoD's future and to understand what you believe is key in getting there. We keep individual answers private and report our findings in aggregate – we never ascribe comments to any specific individual. So please be as candid as you like....

OBJECTIVES
- Understand key stake holders' and decision makers' current view, plans and future ambition for the business & franchise
- Identify current obstacles to achieving the ambition
- Gain different perspectives within the ecosystem of CoD
- Look for commonalities and disconnects across the organization
- Understand the team's brand IQ and expectations around the role of brand

INTERVIEWEE
- Tell us about you – your role, how long you've been at Activision, how long you've been working on Call of Duty, prior experiences.

CALL OF DUTY TODAY
1. In one word or thought, what does CoD stand for today? (put another way, I say "Call of Duty", you say what?)
    - Why do you choose that word?
    - How do you think your customers (heavy & moderate) would answer that question?
    - Think of customers who aren't playing today, but who you'd like to be playing. How would they answer the question?
    - How would the different stakeholders (studios/retailers/industry media) describe Call of Duty?
2. What do you think are Call of Duty's greatest strengths? Challenges? Opportunities?
    - What do you think is unique about Call of Duty?
    - What are the biggest misconceptions about Call of Duty?
    - What are the sacred cows? What are the taboos?
3. Why do you think people play Call of Duty?



Wolff Olins Page 2

    - What makes them so passionate and keeps them coming back for more? What can we do for these people to engage them more?
    - How can we get a new generation of gamers to play Call of Duty?
4. What are the biggest internal disconnects about the brand & business?

COMPETITION TODAY
1. Who is the competition?
    - Who do you admire?
    - Who do you think CoD or Activision can learn from?
    - What should we be scared of?
2. What non-gaming brands are similar to Call of Duty?

CALL OF DUTY FUTURE
1. Where do you see the CoD franchise in 5 to 10 years?
2. What is your ambition for the business? For the brand? What are the biggest hurdles to making that a reality?
    - One word for what will Call of Duty stand for in 3-5 years. I say "Call of Duty in 2013", you say what?
    - What do you want Call of Duty to be famous for?
    - What initiatives are currently underway in the company that you think are going to make the biggest positive impact on the business?
3. What initiatives aren't on the radar yet that Call of Duty should be considering?
    - What's Call of Duty's role outside of video games? What non-game products/services can embody the essence of Call of Duty?
4. For you personally, what does success look like for Call of Duty?

SUCCESS
1. Is there anything else we should cover?

Any questions for us?

Thank you!

IN-DEPTH INTERVIEWS
EXAMPLE: PG&E

Project Description
As one of the oldest utilities in the United States, Pacific Gas and Electric Company was struggling to find a balance between two increasingly conflicting priorities: focusing on the fundamentals providing reliable energy and service to customers, while also striving for innovation, leading the way in the fight against climate change.

PG&E enlisted Wolff Olins to create an on-purpose brand to unify their leadership around a powerful ambition, mobilize and inspire their employees and create a strong platform for growth the first since the company was founded 103 years ago.

Timing

3 WEEKS

Team

NICK O'FLAHERTY
AMARIS SINGER
ALICIANNE RAND

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We decided in-depth internal interviews were essential for this project given the breadth and complexity of PG&E's product and service portfolio. Additionally, because it is a regulated industry, it was important to understand the range of barriers and opportunities unique to the utility. The interviews were intended to help us understand the business in-depth as well as get an internal view of customer needs and how they are and are not being met currently. This information was crucial to forming our project hypotheses about how the portfolio should be reorganized.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We conducted our interviews over about 2.5 weeks, very early on in the project. Conducting interviews early on was essential for understanding the issues and forming our hypotheses.

How was it used?
We conducted our interviews in two parts. For the first part of the discussion, we just asked questions about the interviewee's area of expertise within the business, the products they work with, their view on customer needs and how well they're being met, etc. However, we used the second part of the interview for interactive exercises where the interviewees actually had to create their own structure of customer needs using laminated cards with potential needs listed on them. Both parts of the interview formed the basis of our insights presentation and initial hypotheses, along with the existing research we reviewed before the interviews began.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
We used background materials and existing research to inform the structure of our interviews and exercises. Then we simply wrote an interview guide and worked with production to create our interactive exercises.

How much time did it take?
~3 weeks to conduct all the interviews and synthesize our findings into an insights presentation.

What resources did you use?
2 strategists to conduct the interviews, take notes and create the insights presentation.

How much did it cost?
The cost for the In-Depth interviews was about $90,000.

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
The interviews were a foundational piece of our insight gathering, but they weren't used in conjunction with the other tools.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
None, really. Interviewees were quite candid and willing to participate fully in the interactive exercise.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The interviews, along with the background materials and existing research, formed the basis of the rest of the project, so it was extremely important to get those insights right. It was useful to the client to learn more about their own business and realize the appetite for the project as well as the potential versatility of it.

Write-up by Amaris Singer

CUSTOMER JOURNEY

UNDERSTAND HOW A BRAND
TOUCHES PEOPLE'S LIVES



STARTING A
CONVERSATION



UNDERSTANDING THE
CLIENT'S BUSINESS



GETTING TO CONSUMER/
CONTEXT INSIGHTS



BRINGING THE
CUSTOMER TO LIFE

WHAT
The Customer Journey is a visual map or diagram outlining the different steps customers typically go through when interacting with a brand and/or industry. The goal of the customer journey is to gain a more holistic understanding of the ways in which customers interact with the world and the opportunities therein.

WHY
The development of the customer journey helps define the key touch points and pain points, and explores the motivations behind customer engagement with a brand. This tool will show you how a brand interacts with people's lives. It serves to uncover areas of opportunity, offering suggestions on how to improve the customer experience. It can also facilitate discussion on how the client can potentially expand the offer.

HOW
To get an understanding of the customer's experience, we break down the different steps the customer goes through and then map the actions that they take during the process. This can be done in several different ways. The customer journey of an online experience might be based on digital audits and desk research, while a product or retail experience might require store visits, experiential audits or ethnographic research. After defining the different touch points, each step is analyzed separately to uncover areas of opportunity for a successful brand strategy.

WHO
Companies that are...
–Detached from their customers
–In need for in-depth insights for new product or service developments

WHEN
–At the beginning of a project to gain an immediate sense of the customers, their experiences and how they can be improved
–In a later phase to get a more detailed view on areas of opportunity

WITH
–Ethnographic Research
–Desk research
–Digital audits

"A GREAT WAY OF BRINGING THE CUSTOMER JOURNEY TO LIFE IS BY RETHINKING ITS VISUAL PRESENTATION. FOR OUR WEIGHT WATCHERS PROJECT WE CREATED A CIRCULAR JOURNEY, WHICH WAS AN INTERESTING CHANGE FROM THE MORE TYPICAL LINEAR VERSION."
Melissa Andrada

CUSTOMER JOURNEY
EXAMPLE: THE RITZ-CARLTON

Project Description
The Ritz-Carlton came to Wolff Olins in 2011 with the challenge of building out their rewards program. The original program (The Ritz-Carlton Rewards) had been launched rather quickly in the fall of 2010, and was based around the idea of Access to the Extraordinary. The Ritz-Carlton asked Wolff Olins to take that positioning and expound on it. The main ambition of the project was to create a rewards proposition that lived up to The Ritz-Carlton brand – one that was differentiated and truly extraordinary in the market, one that helped The Ritz-Carlton more deeply engage with their best customers, provided a clear filter for potential partnerships, and one that pushed The Ritz-Carlton to a more technologically-forward, more innovative space in the minds of their target audience.

Timing

3 DAYS

Team

MARISSA VOSPER
DAN ZUZUNAGA
JESSE DAVIS
KRIS PELLETIER

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The Ritz-Carlton had clear ambitions of moving beyond the traditional 'hospitality' space and we wanted to leverage this ambition for Rewards. We created a high-level customer journey to help explore the big picture in terms of travel (beyond just the hotel stay) – finding the biggest pain points and areas of opportunity for the Ritz.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used this tool during our kick-off meeting – so before we even began our first phase of work. Since this particular journey was very high-level, we brought it to our first meeting to begin the discussion around the ambition of The Ritz-Carlton to expand/extend their offer beyond the hotel, and to identify the best opportunities for them to do that.

How was it used?
We used our customer journey scroll at the kick-off meeting with our core team and to begin brainstorming areas of opportunity/impact for TRCR (The Ritz-Carlton Rewards) – both in and outside of the hotels.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
This was a fairly high-level customer journey map – we essentially brainstormed a typical travel journey, keeping in mind the more affluent Ritz-Carlton customer and sketched out a map with the key steps along the way. We then worked with production to visualize and print the journey on a big scroll for our kick-off. In terms of previous inputs we came in with a general understanding of the travel journey (having traveled ourselves and having worked on previous clients in the travel/hospitality space).

How much time did it take?
~3 days

What resources did you use?
1 strategist and 1 production manager

How much did it cost?
Approximately $8,500 – it is however hard to put an exact number on the price as part of the development happened in a workshop-setting with the client and was in part based on previous information.

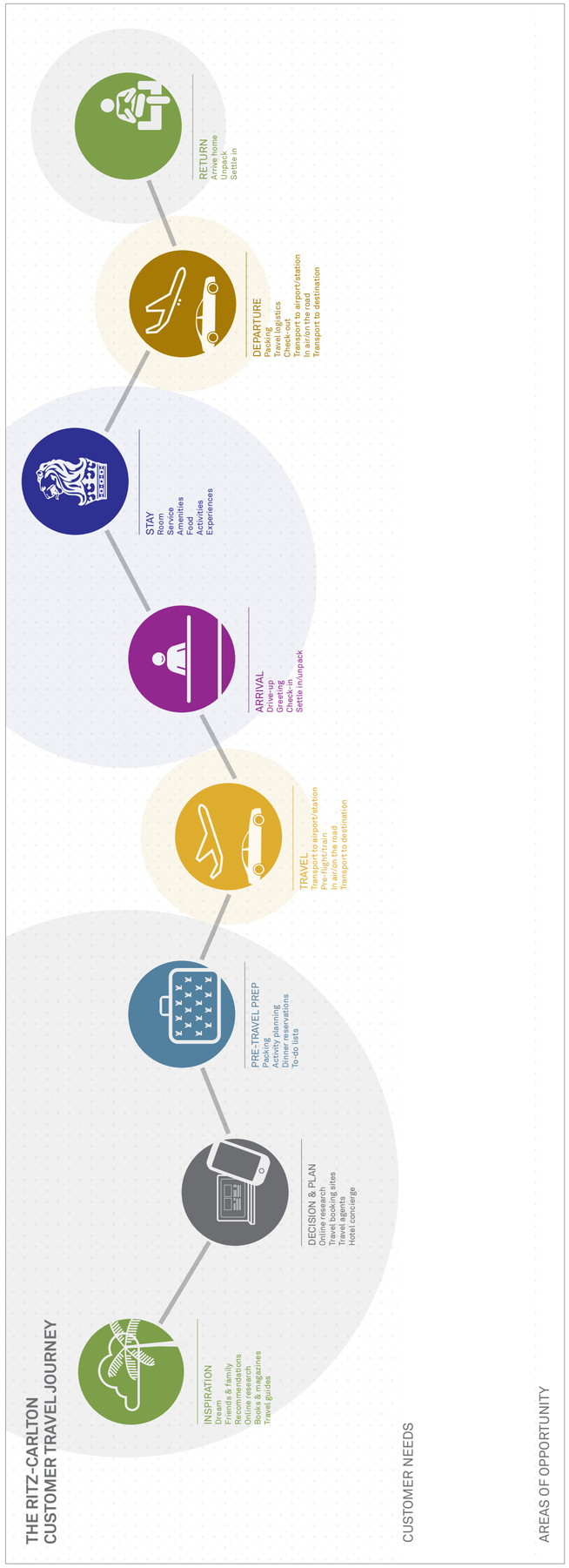
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
We also created high-level customer personas for the kick-off meeting – the goal was to use both tools to facilitate a conversation around ambition and target audience for The Ritz-Carlton Rewards program.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Nothing comes to mind.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The journey was helpful – it broke up the PPT presentation vibe and got people standing and talking about areas of opportunity.

Write-up by Marissa Vosper

Customer Journey used as part of kick-off meeting



CUSTOMER JOURNEY
EXAMPLE: HAWAIIAN AIRLINES

Project Description
For 80 years, Hawaiian Airlines has been one of the defining companies and brands of the Hawaiian Islands and the Pacific. It's integral to the life-blood of Hawaii's economy — bringing crucial tourism to and from the islands, serving as a critical transportation link connecting the different cities of the archipelago, and employing more Hawaiians than any other public or private company. More than just an airline, it's a microcosm of Hawaiian people, culture, custom, and hospitality that the people of Hawaii are proud of. Good management, good labor relations, and demand for travel to and from Hawaii helped the company weather the post-9/11 travel downturn. But the question for Hawaiian was how to drive growth in new markets in Asia, and protect its share from aggressive market entrants from the US mainland — and how brand could help them do it.

We realized that their identity as the only true Hawaiian airline — and the fact that they are an airline made up of Hawaiians — was their greatest asset. That the transformational qualities of Hawaii - beautiful places, renewing experiences, and the warmth and hospitality of the Hawaiian people were the things that always brought people the world over to Hawaii and that core truth hadn't changed over time. With a new service launch to Japan and Korea in mind, we helped identify principles of Hawaiian hospitality and care that the employees of the company were proud of, and wanted visitors to the islands to experience. We applied those principles to clear profiles of the discerning Japanese and Korean customer, and worked with labor, management, in-flight service, customer service, and ground agents in all-hands workshops to design a new experience end-to-end — from employee behaviors, to service scripts, to new menu items and onboard programming.

Timing

4–5 WEEKS

Team

KARL HEISELMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
JESSICA CHALIFOUX
CHRISTIAN BUTTE
BRITT BULLA

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
Hawaiian Airlines was exploring the idea of expanding their service into Japan and Korea and needed to better understand customer expectations and competitor standards in those markets. They were also questioning which elements of the domestic customer experience deserved further investment, which were 'tablestakes' and which were areas of opportunity for them to stand out as differentiated from their competitive set.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used this tool during the insights/discovery phase of our engagement. The Hawaiian Airlines job was different from most jobs, in that we really only had one phase of work where we shared all of our insights and presented our recommendations (all at once). So we used the journey as the analytic foundation for some of our insights/recommendations and shared work-in-progress examples of the journey with our client during weekly status calls leading up to the big presentation as a way to check-in and see if we were on the right track.

How was it used?
We used our customer journey audit during the insights phase – both as an interim/check-in deliverable (discussed via phone with our day-to-day client) and as an exhibit during our insights presentation in-person with our core team. Because there was so much information to cover in our final meeting, we only touched on our high-level insights from the audit versus presenting the entire thing.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
This audit was particularly comprehensive – we really wanted to document every step of the travel journey from ticket purchase through post-flight communications. Because of the goals of the project, we needed to audit the journey across a range of competitors – on the mainland, in Hawaii and internationally – as well as the Hawaiian Airlines customer experience today. The first step was to actually fly as passengers on all of these flights, so we flew on many different airlines around the country and the globe and took copious notes and photos along the way – we also collected any and all collateral we could (in-flight magazines, safety cards, eye masks, salt packets, you name it). We also audited a host of online and print communications from the same set of competitors.
Once we completed all of our audits, we organized all of the content by region and competitor into a massive customer journey with images, screen grabs, quotes and anecdotes to illustrate each step. From there we were able to analyze the material and come up with our key takeaways/areas of opportunity (the final result of the tool).

How much time did it take?
4-5 weeks (in concert with various other work streams during the insights/discovery phase)

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 1 designer, 1 production manager

How much did it cost?
N/A

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes, we used the takeaways from this process to inform our recommendations to the core team (essentially it informed what would have been a traditional Brand Butterfly, though we didn't actually create one in this instance).

Which challenges did you face along the process?
The massive amount of information and content was very hard to distill down to anything digestible. It was important to show our due diligence, but it was a huge amount of work. Also, I would not recommend flying from Hawaii to Tokyo to NYC in one consecutive period.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The process really helped ground our recommendations in a solid analytic foundation. Our client could tell we did our homework – and nothing beats the ability to say you literally walked a mile (or flew thousands of miles!) in the customers' shoes.

Write-up by Marissa Vosper



VISITOR JOURNEY

UNDERSTAND HOW YOUR BRAND INFORMS THE VISITOR EXPERIENCE



STARTING A CONVERSATION



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS



BRINGING THE CUSTOMER TO LIFE

WHAT
The Visitor Journey is a visual map or diagram outlining the different stages your visitors go through, providing a holistic view of the experience and uncovering opportunities for engagement, improvement and differentiation.

WHY
The visitor journey helps us define the touch, transition and pain points and clarify the motivation behind the visitor's engagement with an institution. Once the brand is developed the journey is used to prioritize investments, and ultimately, to ensure that the brand is delivered consistently through all touchpoints.

HOW
To gain an understanding of the visitor experience we map each step he or she goes through with the institution or museum – from information gathering online to wayfinding to exhibitions and programming to membership and fund raising. Each stage is analyzed separately assessing performance against best practice, competitive landscape and visitor needs – building the base for a successful brand strategy.

WHO
–An institution/museum detached from its visitors
–In need for in-depth insights for new experience development

WHEN
–At the beginning of a project to gain an immediate sense of who your visitors are, what their experience is like and how it can be improved
–The visitor journey informs the brand worlds in terms of the different applications used
–At the end to inform execution when defining the roll-out strategy

WITH
–Ethnographic Research
–Desk research
–Digital audits

"THE VISITOR JOURNEY IS A GREAT SALES TOOL TO RAISE DONOR FUNDS IN THE ROLL-OUT/EXECUTION PHASE OF A PROJECT. THE MORE YOU ARE ABLE TO SPECIFY WHAT COULD POTENTIALLY BE DONE WITH DONATIONS, THE BETTER. BY SHOWING ALL DIFFERENT PARTS OF THE EXPERIENCE DONORS CAN PICK A CERTAIN PART OF THE JOURNEY THEY WANT TO CONTRIBUTE TO."
Nick O'Flaherty

VISITOR JOURNEY
EXAMPLE: ASIAN ART MUSEUM

Project Description
The Asian Art Museum of San Francisco is one of the largest and most respected museums in the Western world devoted exclusively to Asian art – but for years it has remained one of San Francisco's best kept secrets. Despite being positioned as a geographic and cultural authority on Asian art and culture in the US, the museum still struggled to capture awareness and fully connect with visitors beyond their niche audience. In 2009, however, they appointed a new director with a ground-breaking vision and revitalized ambition to become the world's most dynamic Asian art and cultural museum.

Timing

3 WEEKS

Team

NICK O'FLAHERTY
ALICIANNE RAND
JORDAN CRANE

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
When we first started the project, the visitor was an afterthought for many staff at the AAM. By joining the dots and providing an holistic overview – the Visitor Journey forced the museum to see the experience through a visitor's eyes, and understand the cumulative effect of the pieces of the journey they normally viewed in isolation. It successfully brought about visitor empathy- and gave the visitor a seat at the table from that point on. We also used the Journey to compare the AAM's "touch points" with Best Practice from other museums around the world. This gave our clients – often accused of myopia – a wake up call, providing an impetus for change and excitement for what could be achieved.

At what point in the process did you use the tool and how was it used?
We first used the tool during our insights phase – to show the baseline – what was working and what wasn't. We then used the template to show brand worlds, the final chosen idea – the client still uses the boards that follow the visitor journey to elicit donations, and make decisions regarding the roll out of brand.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
We did multiple walk-throughs of the museum, and mapped the journey. We then photographed and filmed each key touch point along the journey, as well as taking notes of what was working and what was not. Around the same time we were doing audits of "competitor" museums/ attractions in San Francisco, DC, NYC and London, which we broke out along a generic visitor journey. Other best practice was collected online. After analysis of all this data – we laid out our findings on a scroll – focusing on the current AAM journey, with best practice comparisons below each journey segment.
How much time did it take?
2 weeks to collect data, 1 week to analyze and lay out

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 1 account manager, 1 production team member

How much did it cost?
Roughly $15,000

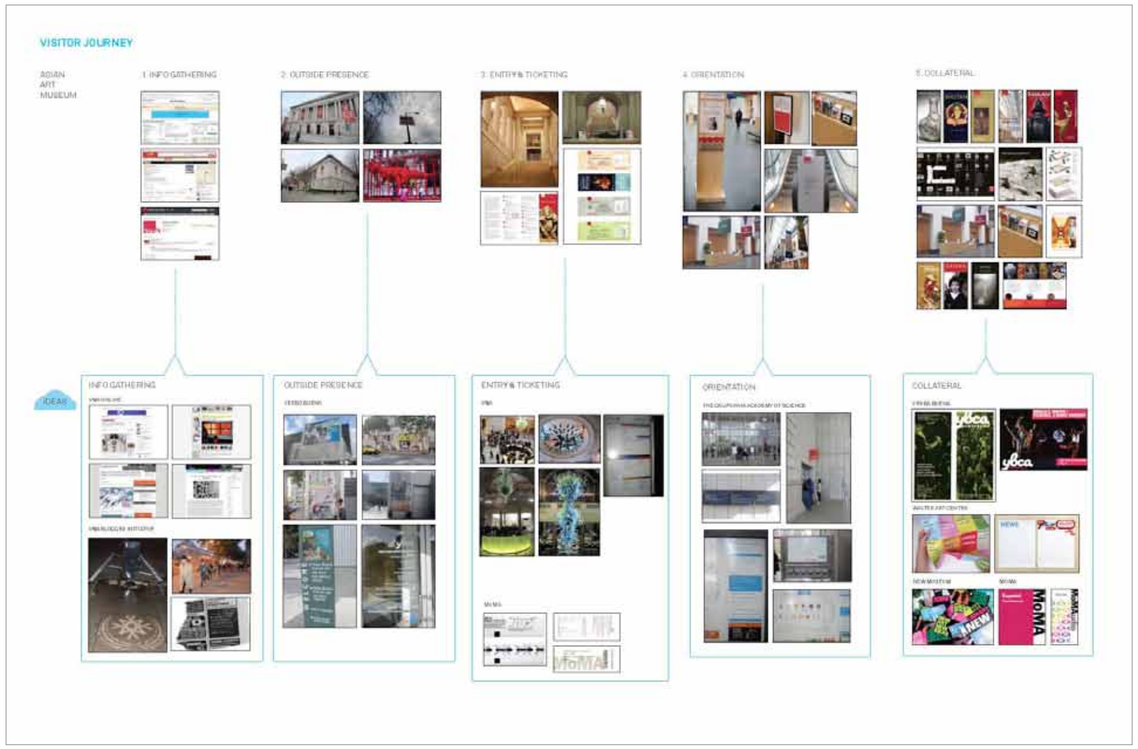
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Overall trend research, best practice museum research, competitor research, internal interviews

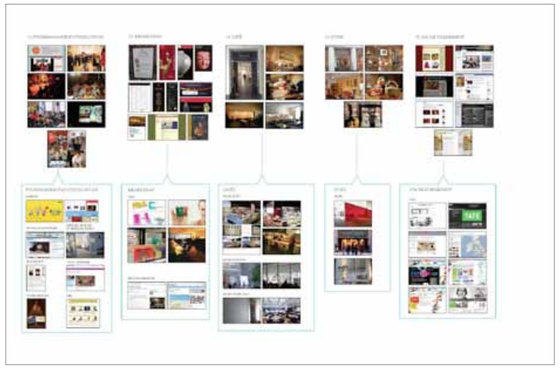
Which challenges did you face along the process?
Amount of data & security guards

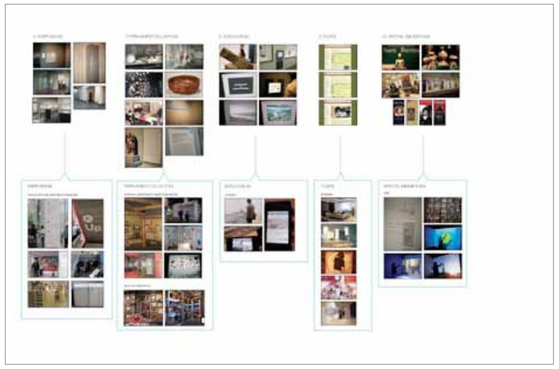
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
An almost immediate desire to change across the board – and inspiration of how to do so, and where to start!

Write-up by Nick O'Flaherty

Visitor Journey audit as part of insights presentation







CUSTOMER PERSONAS

SEE LIFE THROUGH THE EYES
OF THE CUSTOMER



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS



BRINGING THE CUSTOMER TO LIFE

WHAT
Customer Personas provide a snapshot into the everyday lives of target customers, and help you to understand their needs, values and behaviors in a very rich way.

WHY
By immersing ourselves into the everyday lives of the customers we are able to discover insights about their needs and wants otherwise hidden to us. The development of stories around the audience helps us to shape a brand strategy that directly speaks to them. Customer Personas provide you with an intimate understanding of what people really need and where a brand can make the biggest difference. It serves as a tool to visualize otherwise abstract ideas and puts the client into the shoes of its target audience.

HOW
Instead of reducing the customers to broad demographics we look at information beyond age and gender such as personalities, lifestyles, preferences, attitudes, goals, habits, tastes or favorite brands. We conduct in-depth interviews, use a broad representation of the audience and look for shared patterns in order to develop representative personas.

WHO
–Company detached from its customers
–In need for in-depth insights for new product or service developments

WHEN
At the beginning of a project to gain an immediate and intimate sense of who the customers are, what their lifestyles and needs are, and how you might make their lives easier

WITH
–Customer Journey
–Daily diaries

"THE GREAT THING ABOUT CUSTOMER PERSONAS IS THAT IT REALLY BRINGS THE HUMAN SIDE TO THE CUSTOMER. IT TELLS A STORY INSTEAD OF JUST BEING A SET OF NUMBERS AND STATISTICS."
Melissa Andrada

CUSTOMER PERSONAS
EXAMPLE: SMITHSONIAN

Project Description
The Smithsonian Institution was founded in 1846 with 'The increase and diffusion of knowledge' as their mission. After more than a century and a half of amazing success in America and the world, the Smithsonian realized it was time to think about the future. They began a strategic planning effort in 2009 and approached Wolff Olins in 2010 with the challenge of building a brand based on that strategic foundation. As our key client liked to say, the Smithsonian had become one of the world's most beloved brands 'by accident' and it was finally time to build a brand based on intent and ambition. The brief for Wolff Olins was to craft a brand strategy that would take the institution into the next decade: more modern, more relevant, more impactful, for more people, more often. With this brief we worked collaboratively with a large multi-disciplinary team from across the organization to define a powerful brand strategy and tagline that encapsulated their internal goals, but also pushed them to think outside of the box and live up to their potential as one of the world's greatest platforms for learning.

Timing

3–4 WEEKS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
ALICIANNE RAND
JACOB COHEN

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The Smithsonian was a very inward-facing organization, lots of navel-gazing and strategy based on a largely internal perspective. What they really needed was a view of the outside world – a deeper appreciation for their external audiences, beyond a generic understanding of "The Public."

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used this tool in between our insights/ discovery (Phase 1) and our brand worlds phase (Phase 3). We inserted an in-between phase all about the customer and held a customer activation workshop with our Smithsonian team to brainstorm ways in which we could reach out to these specific audiences with new offers and value propositions.

How was it used?
We used our customer personas to facilitate a workshop with the Smithsonian team that was focused around understanding our customers and ideating the best ways to target/ tailor the Smithsonian offer to those customers.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
Prior to our workshop, we conducted a piece of ethnographic research with The Future's Company to better understand and explore the way people view and approach knowledge and learning. Based on the themes and patterns that emerged from this research, we worked with our research partner to categorize all of our respondents into a series of representative 'learning types,' which we then used as the foundations for our customer personas. For each learning type, we created a fictional, but representative person. For each person, we brainstormed basic demographic information (name, age, occupation, residence, etc.), thought of brand affinities, crafted a typical 'day in the life' as well as a typical learning journey, and collected a series of items that would comprise a bag/backpack for each.

We then worked with our design and production team to visualize all of this information on big scrolls. We took these scrolls and the physical bags/backpacks to our workshop with the Smithsonian team to really bring these personas to life visually and verbally.

How much time did it take?
~3-4 weeks

What resources did you use?
To craft the personas and prepare for the workshop, our team consisted of 2 strategists (1 lead, 1 support), 1 account manager, 1 designer, 1 production manager

How much did it cost?
Incurred fees: $118,730
Incurred costs: Roughly $16,000

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes, our previous ethnographic research was used as the foundation for creating the customer personas (see 'What inputs were required')

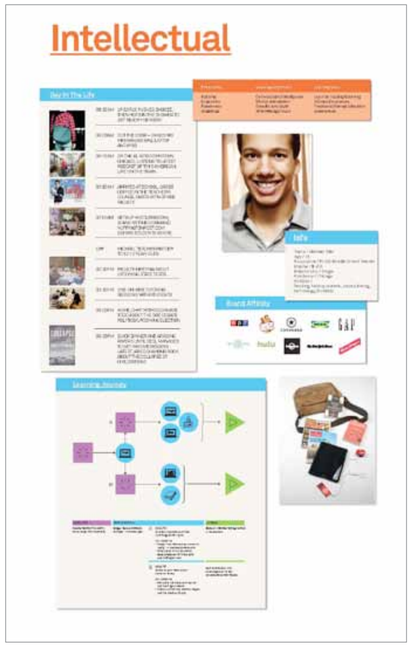
Which challenges did you face along the process?
It's always challenging to make personas representative but not overly stereotypical – it's a fine balance. We also tried to accomplish a lot of activities with our clients during the personas workshop – we probably could have used more time than we had planned for.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The client was thrilled. It was really novel for them to think about their customers in such detail – and for them to acknowledge that they have many audiences beyond the obvious academic community. It was also really powerful for them to think about how to target their offer for a range of customers with a variety of needs. The exercise helped them confront the fact that they needed to make some changes if they wanted to be at all relevant to this broader audience, but it also created an environment for them to proactively ideate around this realization versus shy away from it.

Write-up by Marissa Vosper

Scrolls as part of client presentation









CUSTOMER PERSONAS
EXAMPLE: CITIBANK

Project Description
Citibank Japan has had an active retail franchise for over 100 years, but in recent times was losing its edge. Finding itself dangerously “me too,” a partnership was formed between Citibank Japan and Citi Growth Ventures to jumpstart growth by radically changing the retail banking experience through technology. The challenge for the agency partnership that was assembled; architecture firm 8 Inc, advertising agency, SSF Tokyo, and brand consultancy, Wolff Olins, was to create a “smarter bank” using a ground up approach to architecture, technology, service propositions and marketing communications.

Wolff Olins focused on working with Citibank Japan to define and humanize the three high-value customer segments by developing distinct brand personas designed to create conversations about what people like “Takahashi San” might want, and the type of service they’d expect. Focusing on insights that would drive genuine customer needs. At the same time, we were also looking at the Citibank brand in Japan — what its unique equities were, and the types of experience that would not just be customer centric, but also uniquely Citi.

How were the personas developed and at what point in the process?
Personas were developed after the client had undertaken a significant piece of segmentation research, which identified the 3 segments they were most interested in and the fourth segment, which was interesting for the future.

What they lacked, however, was any real insights into the lives of these people. They were simply a set of statistics on a page. By creating personas, we were attempting to personalize and humanize the segments in ways the client could emotionally and intellectually relate to. Pretty important in terms of their desire to become customer centric and create compelling value propositions for each.

What were the challenges? What would you do differently the next time?
The primary challenges were that we weren’t Japanese, nor were we in Japan! Although to be honest we handled it quite well by sending a Japanese designer from London over to follow people around and photograph their typical day as a part of the process. In terms of doing differently next time, we worked pretty much exclusively from quantitative data used in the segmentation exercise. Ideally we’d have identified the segment and then dived deeper using qualitative methods like ethnography to create a more rounded view of the personas and their needs.

What was the outcome and how were they useful to the client?
We made life-size cutouts, which the clients put all over their offices. They were in every meeting room; you couldn’t get away from them. Whenever the client discussed value propositions, products, customer service etc. they always did it with the personas in mind. If for no other reason than they were quite literally looking over their shoulders!

We also created a “day in the life” for each persona/segment, which helped the client understand how different segments would use channels differently, and as such how they might need to tailor their channel approach.

Ultimately we did something right. Citi went from number 57 to number 1 in the annual Nikkei retail banking survey (a bit like JD Power buy broader than just service).

Write-up by Paul Worthington

Customer Personas as part of client presentation







ETHNO-GRAPHIC RESEARCH

DEEP-DIVE INTO CUSTOMERS' MINDS

UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS

GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS

BRINGING THE CUSTOMER TO LIFE

WHAT
Ethnographic research is a qualitative, anthropology-based research method, which is used to gain insights on the behaviors of a target customer or culture based on observation, conversation and immersion.

WHY
This tool is used to reveal unique perspectives on consumer behavior and uncover more implicit insights. Instead of looking at a smaller, concrete set of variables among a larger group of people, we use ethnographies to delve much deeper into a wider set of variables among fewer people. What's more, instead of a controlled, 3rd party setting, ethnographies allow us to go 'in-field' and observe people in their natural environments, which further helps to uncover insights beyond a direct question/ answer format.

HOW
Ethnographic research can entail numerous different methods, depending on the needs of the project. Common practices include: shop-along's, daily diaries, collages or home visits. After securing the right individuals based on previously defined recruiting criteria, the ethnographies can be conducted. With the goal of making the respondents as comfortable/natural as possible, it's always best to keep the number of moderators/observers low (ideally 1-2 people max). To capture our insights, we will document our findings with notes, diagrams, action timelines and/or videos.

WHO
Companies that are...
–Detached from their customers
–In need for in-depth insights for new product or service developments

*Note: Ethnographies tend to be most effective with clients that are open to qualitative methods and not exclusively quantitative/numbers/data-focused

WHEN
Most effective at the insights-phase of a project

WITH
–Customer Personas
–Customer Journey

"IT IS IMPORTANT TO FIND THE RIGHT BALANCE BETWEEN OBSERVING AND ASKING QUESTIONS. WHEN ETHNOGRAPHIC RESEARCH WORKS WELL, IT DOESN'T FEEL LIKE 'RESEARCH' TO THE RESPONDENTS."
FOCUS GROUPS
Dan Zuzunaga

ETHNOGRAPHIC RESEARCH
EXAMPLE: SMITHSONIAN

Project Description
The Smithsonian Institution was founded in 1846 with 'The increase and diffusion of knowledge' as their mission. After more than a century and a half of amazing success in America and the world, the Smithsonian realized it was time to think about the future. They began a strategic planning effort in 2009 and approached Wolff Olins in 2010 with the challenge of building a brand based on that strategic foundation. As our key client liked to say, the Smithsonian had become one of the world's most beloved brands 'by accident' and it was finally time to build a brand based on intent and ambition. The brief for Wolff Olins was to craft a brand strategy that would take the institution into the next decade: more modern, more relevant, more impactful, for more people, more often. With this brief we worked collaboratively with a large multi-disciplinary team from across the organization to define a powerful brand strategy and tagline that encapsulated their internal goals, but also pushed them to think outside of the box and live up to their potential as one of the world's greatest platforms for learning.

Timing

4 WEEKS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
ALICIANNE RAND
MELISSA ANDRADA

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The Smithsonian was a very inward-facing organization, lots of navel-gazing and strategy based on a largely internal perspective. What they really needed was a view of the outside world – a deeper appreciation for their external audiences, beyond a generic understanding of "The Public." Wolff Olins also wanted a better understanding of audience needs in relation to the Smithsonian.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We fielded a piece of ethnographic research during the insights/discovery phase of the project, but also used our findings in a subsequent 'customer personas' workshop.

How was it used?
We used our ethnographic research in two ways – first in our insights/discovery phase to share the customer perspective with the Smithsonian (and as input to our "What the world needs" section of the brand butterfly), and then as input for our customer personas workshop, in which we used our research as the foundation to create personas to help the Smithsonian ideate around customer-centric offers.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
We worked with a research partner – the Futures Company – to field the research. We helped develop a screener to find the right kind of people that would give us the most valuable feedback. The Futures Company then performed a series of in-depth interviews in the homes of our interviewees based on a batter of questions that we developed together. We made sure to recruit a demographically diverse population. Team members from WO attended a handful of the interviews. At the end, The Futures Company presented their findings to us in the form of a final report + videos that demonstrated key themes, which emerged from the ethnographies.

How much time did it take?
~4 weeks from recruit through to the final research findings presentation.

What resources did you use?
2-3 strategists, 1 account manager, external research partners

How much did it cost?
$99,000 (The Future's Company)

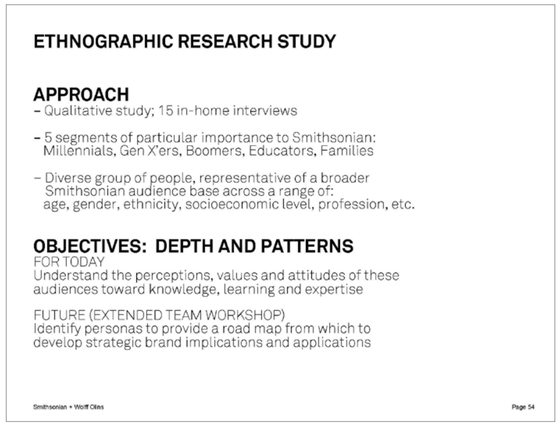
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes, we used the ethnographic research in combination with our macro trends research to build out the "What the world needs" piece of the brand butterfly. We also used the research as the foundation for customer personas.

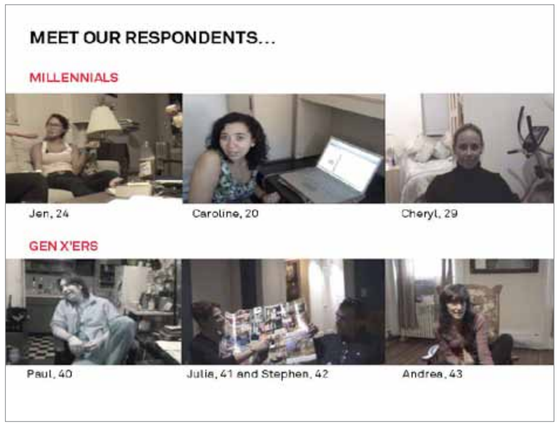
Which challenges did you face along the process?
Working with The Futures Company was good and bad – they're good partners, but sometimes it took a while for us all to get on the same page in terms of our (WO) needs, needs from them (TFC) and our (WO) style of work. It was sometimes difficult for them (TFC) to think of us (WO) as partners versus clients.

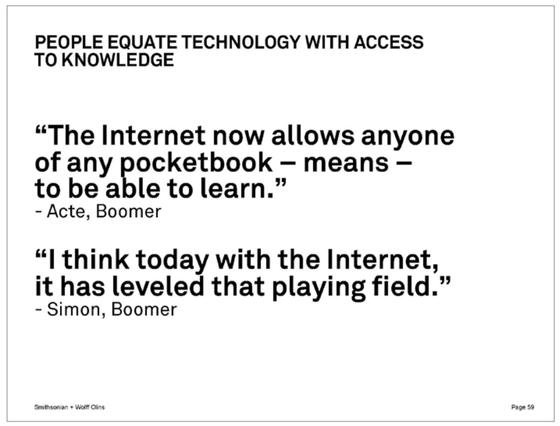
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
This research was very valuable to the Smithsonian – hearing and seeing real people talk about the Smithsonian was a reality check. It helped them broaden their minds and 'de-genericize' their view of 'The Public.'

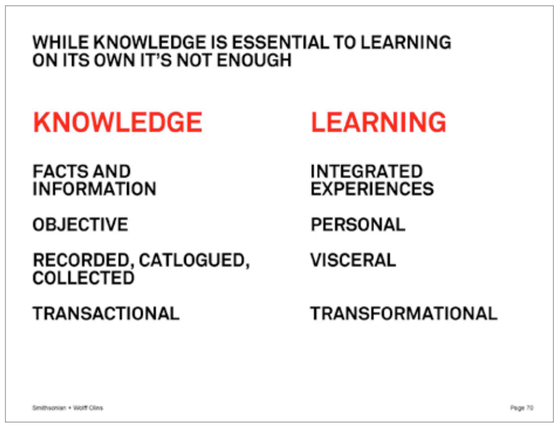
Write-up by Marissa Vosper

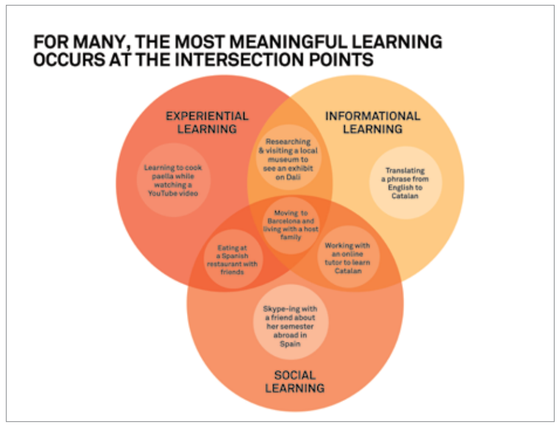
Ethnographic Research analysis as part of insights presentation

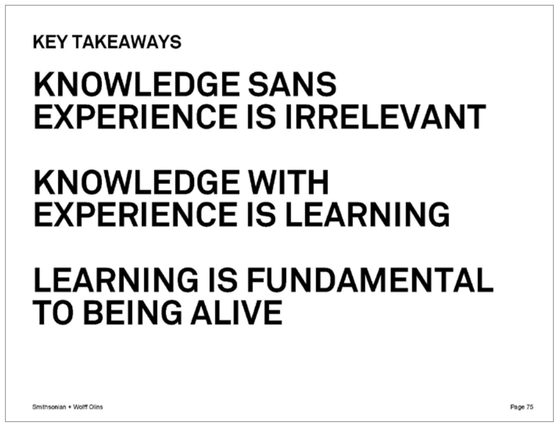












ETHNOGRAPHIC RESEARCH
EXAMPLE: PG&E

Project Description
As one of the oldest utilities in the United States, Pacific Gas and Electric Company was struggling to find a balance between two increasingly conflicting priorities: focusing on the fundamentals providing reliable energy and service to customers, while also striving for innovation, leading the way in the fight against climate change.

PG&E enlisted Wolff Olins to create an on-purpose brand to unify their leadership around a powerful ambition, mobilize and inspire their employees and create a strong platform for growth the first since the company was founded 103 years ago.

Timing

12 WEEKS

Team

SAM WILSON
NICK O'FLAHERTY
BILL DARLING
ALICIANNE RAND
JESS CHALIFOUX

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We had originally scoped customer ethnographic research as part of the insight gathering phase of the project. After a few weeks of talking to management we realized that it was a bigger priority to better understand their employee base. Their was a massive disconnect and mutual distrust between leadership and the troops. We wanted to find out why, and what brand could do to align the organization

At what point in the process did you use the tool? And how was it used?
We worked with In:Site early on in the project – their findings helped us define the brand idea for PG&E, as well as how to approach the roll out of the brand

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
After management interviews and analysis of employee research and "culture study" work, we briefed In:Site and worked with them to design the research

How much time did it take?
2 weeks to analyze existing research, 2 weeks to design the research, 8 weeks for In:Site

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 1 account manager, In:Site

How much did it cost?
$196,000 for In:Site and estimated $50,000 - $100,000 in Wolff Olins fees.

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Management interviews, research analysis

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Management of an external agency can be a little unwieldy so early on in a client relationship

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
1) Cut through insights and understanding of the employees and culture 2) helped the CEO and other leaders appreciate and understand employees
3) Helped us design the rest of the job
4) Defined the internal role for brand
5) Helped us understand what was special about PG&E people and what they were capable of

Write-up by Nick O'Flaherty

Examples of Ethnographic Research documentation



FOCUS GROUPS

SEE THE WORLD FROM
THE CUSTOMER'S PERSPECTIVE



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS



GETTING TO CONSUMER/ CONTEXT INSIGHTS



BRINGING THE CUSTOMER TO LIFE

WHAT
A focus group is a moderated discussion among a representative slice of a brand's current or potential target audiences that helps to uncover what and how people think and talk about a certain topic.

WHY
Focus groups are structured to quickly reveal a target audience's desires, reactions, experiences and priorities in relation to any point of inquiry. In the comfort of a casual group setting, participants are encouraged to talk about their thoughts and feelings in relation to a certain product, idea or topic. These discussions provide our clients with insights straight 'from the mouths of their customers' and give us the opportunity to explore initial ideas and/or audience needs efficiently.

HOW
After defining clear recruitment criteria, we generally work together with a partner research agency to help us find the right participants. We then develop a discussion guide depending on the needs of the project, making sure to consider questions that are fixed and those that are more flexible. Instead of commissioning an outside source, we often moderate the focus group sessions ourselves to ensure that we will get the most out of the experience. Once all focus groups are complete, we distil our findings into key insights.

WHO
Companies that have...
–A clear, existing target and want to learn more about them
–A specific new target group in mind and need more insights

WHEN
–Most valuable at the insights phase of a project
–Can be revisited later on in the process to explore/ build on already developed ideas

WITH
–Customer personas
–Customer journey
–Ethnographic research

"I FIND IT IMPORTANT TO HAVE A DETAILED DISCUSSION GUIDE WHEN MODERATING FOCUS GROUPS. IF EVERYTHING GOES WELL AND THE CHEMISTRY OF THE GROUP IS RIGHT THE CONVERSATION CARRIES ON BY ITSELF. BUT IF IT DOESN'T IT'S GREAT TO HAVE A GUIDE TO FOLLOW."
Dan Zuzunga

FOCUS GROUPS
EXAMPLE: THE RITZ-CARLTON

Project Description
The Ritz-Carlton came to Wolff Olins in 2011 with the challenge of building out their rewards program. The original program (The Ritz-Carlton Rewards) had been launched rather quickly in the fall of 2010, and was based around the idea of Access to the Extraordinary. The Ritz-Carlton asked Wolff Olins to take that positioning and expound on it. The main ambition of the project was to create a rewards proposition that lived up to The Ritz-Carlton brand – one that was differentiated and truly extraordinary in the market, one that helped The Ritz-Carlton more deeply engage with their best customers, provided a clear filter for potential partnerships, and one that pushed The Ritz-Carlton to a more technologically-forward, more innovative space in the minds of their target audience.

Timing

2– DAYS

Team

MARISSA VOSPER
DAN ZUZUNAGA
JESSE DAVIS
EMILY SEGAL

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The Ritz-Carlton is very customer focused, anticipating customer preferences, desires and needs is core to their brand so we decided to begin our research and insights phase by getting to know the customer, hearing their perceptions of the brand, of loyalty and of the world.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
Research and Insights, Phase 1

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
We developed a customer profile with the client in order to target the type of customer we were most interested in hearing from. The client then worked with an outside firm to secure the participants. In addition, we developed a discussion guide for the groups. When it came time to engage the customers we led the discussions and video tapped them for use later.

How much time did it take?
Coming up with the discussion guide and customer profiles took about a day. The focus groups themselves lasted 2 hours each; we ran 6 of them for this project.

What resources did you use?
2 Strategists, 1 Project Manager

How much did it cost?
The three groups (held in San Francisco, China and Dubai), recruitment done by a third party (managed by client) and the WO moderation (with the exception of China) combined cost about $50,000.

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes we used it with In-Depth Interviews from key client stakeholders and staff to get a balanced picture of how The Ritz-Carlton Rewards program was working and to understand the ambitions for the program, both from a customer side, i.e. what the world needs, and from the client side, i.e. what is special about you.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
In China we were not allowed to guide the discussions and had to rely on a moderator that was supplied by the agency that secured the participants. We saw this as a challenge but in the end felt that the focus group may have been equally hindered by having to conduct it in English or through a translator.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
We were able to discover things about the customer that we didn't expect and ended up using the videotape to re-enforce these ideas at the client meeting. In retrospect we would have been more proactive in filming the sessions because with this client hearing the customer articulate their desires resonated strongly.

Who worked on the project?
Marissa Vosper (strategist, project head)
Dan Zuzunaga (strategist)
Jesse Davis (account manager)
Emily Segal (intern)

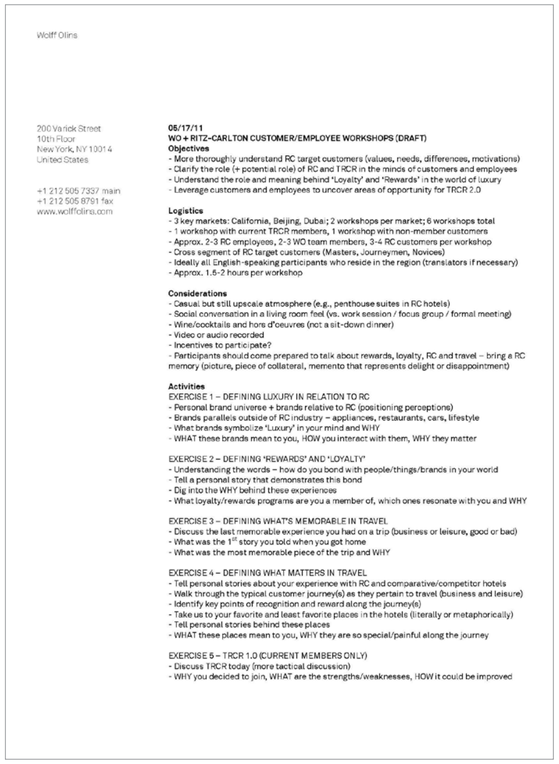
Write-up by Dan Zuzunga

Workshop overview + Examples of Focus Group documentation









Wolff Olins

200 Varick Street
10th Floor
New York, NY 10014
United States

+1 212 505 7337 main
+1 212 505 6791 fax
www.wolffolins.com

05/17/11
WO + RITZ-CARLTON CUSTOMER/EMPLOYEE WORKSHOPS (DRAFT)
Objectives
- More thoroughly understand RC target customers (values, needs, differences, motivations)
- Clarify the role (+ potential role) of RC and TRCR in the minds of customers and employees
- Understand the role and meaning behind 'Loyalty' and 'Rewards' in the world of luxury
- Leverage customers and employees to uncover areas of opportunity for TRCR 2.0

Logistics
- 3 key markets: California, Beijing, Dubai; 2 workshops per market; 6 workshops total
- 1 workshop with current TRCR members, 1 workshop with non-member customers
- Approx. 2-3 RC employees, 2-3 WO team members, 3-4 RC customers per workshop
- Cross segment of RC target customers (Masters, Journeymen, Novices)
- Ideally all English-speaking participants who reside in the region (translators if necessary)
- Approx. 1.5-2 hours per workshop

Considerations
- Casual but still upscale atmosphere (e.g., penthouse suites in RC hotels)
- Social conversation in a living room feel (vs. work session / focus group / formal meeting)
- Wine/cocktails and hors d'oeuvres (not a sit-down dinner)
- Video or audio recorded
- Incentives to participate?
- Participants should come prepared to talk about rewards, loyalty, RC and travel – bring a RC memory (picture, piece of collateral, memento that represents delight or disappointment)

Activities
EXERCISE 1 – DEFINING LUXURY IN RELATION TO RC
- Personal brand universe + brands relative to RC (positioning perceptions)
- Brands parallels outside of RC industry – appliances, restaurants, cars, lifestyle
- What brands symbolize "Luxury" in your mind and WHY
- WHAT these brands mean to you, HOW you interact with them, WHY they matter

EXERCISE 2 – DEFINING "REWARDS" AND "LOYALTY"
- Understanding the words – how do you bond with people/things/brands in your world
- Tell a personal story that demonstrates this bond
- Dig into the WHY behind these experiences
- What loyalty/rewards programs are you a member of, which ones resonate with you and WHY

EXERCISE 3 – DEFINING WHAT'S MEMORABLE IN TRAVEL
- Discuss the last memorable experience you had on a trip (business or leisure, good or bad)
- What was the 1st story you told when you got home
- What was the most memorable piece of the trip and WHY

EXERCISE 4 – DEFINING WHAT MATTERS IN TRAVEL
- Tell personal stories about your experience with RC and comparative/competitor hotels
- Walk through the typical customer journey(s) as they pertain to travel (business and leisure)
- Identify key points of recognition and reward along the journey(s)
- Take us to your favorite and least favorite places in the hotels (literally or metaphorically)
- Tell personal stories behind these places
- WHAT these places mean to you, WHY they are so special/painful along the journey

EXERCISE 5 – TRCR 1.0 (CURRENT MEMBERS ONLY)
- Discuss TRCR today (more tactical discussion)
- WHY you decided to join, WHAT are the strengths/weaknesses, HOW it could be improved

FOCUS GROUPS
EXAMPLE: ACTIVISION

Project Description
We were approached by Activision to help define the future of the highly successful Call of Duty franchise. As the single most successful entertainment property in history, Activision is highly invested in ongoing success of Call of Duty. The challenge that Activision faced was ensuring consistency and improving the decision making process. The Call of Duty brand needed to provide both flexibility to evolve each year and the rigidity to remain true to its roots. We were initially tasked with revising a set of brand equities that were created in-house to reverse engineer the Call of Duty magic. Our deliverable became a set of decision-making tools to help define the brand from development through advertising.

Timing

4 WEEKS

Team

FRANK STRIEFLER
JESSE DAVIS
PAUL WORTHINGTON,
JACOB COHEN

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
As part of helping Activision to better understand what makes a great Call of Duty game we reviewed the existing audience research they had conducted. While highly detailed, the information was focused on quantitative audience data. In order to better understand what the gamer world needs we suggested a qualitative research program to understand emotional states of the gamers.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We conducted the interviews at the beginning of the project during the Insights Phase.

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
i.We began by determining the key markets in which the game will grow in the next two-three years.
ii.We then prioritized the audience based on the quantitative research Activision currently had. We segmented the focus group audience by both age and average time spent gaming (self-assigned by the individual).
iii.We settled on males 18-22 and males 23-34 and then groups based +/- of 20hrs/m of play.

How much time did it take?
i.Because the groups were done in four major cities research happened over the course of about four weeks
ii.After the research was conducted there was another two weeks during which The Future's Company gathered highlights from the research and developed the presentation of their insights.

What resources did you use?
i.The Future's Company was our primary resource during this time. They drafted the initial questions for the gamers, coordinated the focus groups and synthesized the results into a clear, direct document.

How much did it cost?
The Focus Groups overall cost about $117,000. The synthesis of the insights presentation (including all other types of research conducted) cost about $97,000.

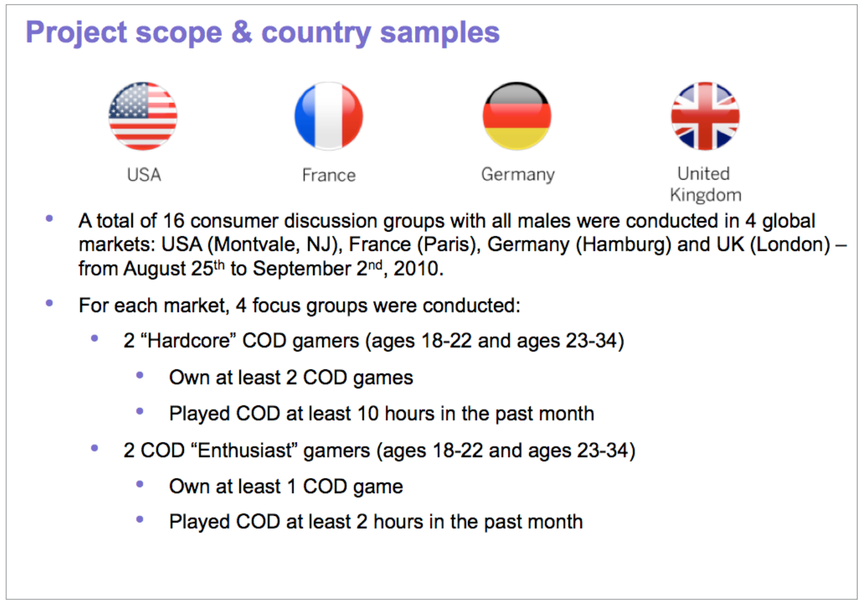
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
i.The focus groups were used in conjunction with the in-depth interviews to gather insights both about Call of Duty and about the needs of the gamer world. The information from this was then used along with the trend report to understand future needs.

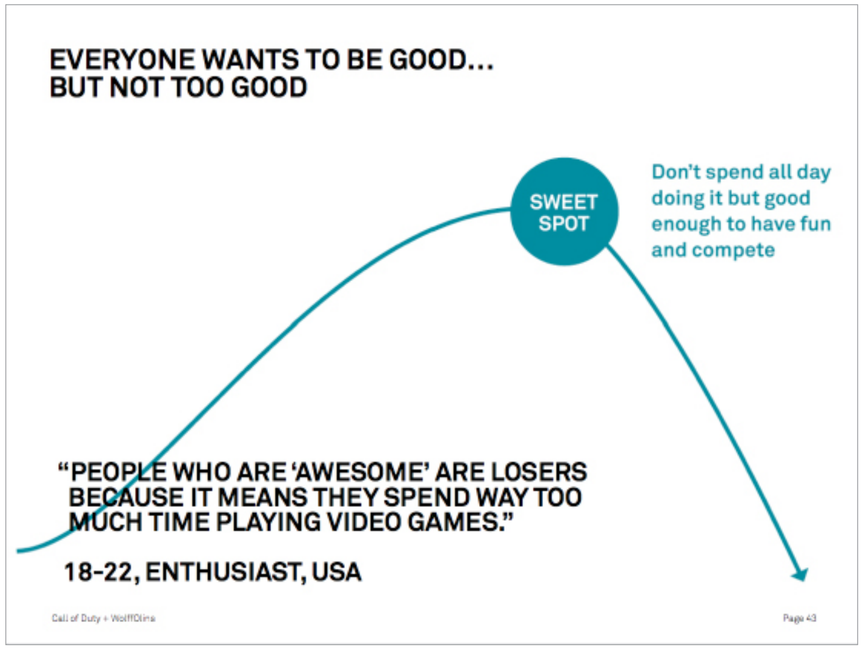
Which challenges did you face along the process?
Most challenges with this process entailed managing the shear amount of information from the focus groups. I attended all four of the NY focus groups and we, as a group, watched nearly all the European ones. This was a total of about 32 hours of content to sift through.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The client had focused all their previous research on quantitative studies of large audiences of gamers. This was the first time they had invested in an international focus group study. Much of the output was influential in Call of Duty Black Ops, which launched only a few months later.

Write-up by Jacob Cohen

Examples of insights presentations (both from Futures Company and Wolff Olins)





EXPERT PANEL

TAKE ADVANTAGE OF OUTSIDE EXPERTISE

GETTING TO CONSUMER/
CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
Industry experts are a carefully selected group of people that have the specialized knowledge and credibility to provide useful, outsider insights on a client's business, brand and future ambition.

WHY
Industry experts provide us with specific knowledge based on personal experience and challenge us to think about an issue from a broader perspective. Speaking to this group of people can help facilitate multi-disciplinary discussions and add to our knowledge base for brand strategy development. These conversations also provide clients with access to unbiased, often thought-provoking points of view, which can facilitate new, and different conversations and ways of thinking.

HOW
A select group of people is identified based on the needs of the project to help provide any gaps in knowledge or perspective. We tend think more broadly about 'relevant' expertise, recruiting people with an array of backgrounds and experiences from tangential or less direct industries in order to generate more creative, unexpected results. After inviting the group to partake in a discussion or interview, conversations will be facilitated by us, either in a group-setting, in-person or over the phone.

WHO
Companies that are considering big changes to products, services or the overall brand

WHEN
–Most effective at the insights phase of a project
–Can be revisited later on to evaluate/build-on potential solutions

WITH
Best Practices

"DON'T EXPECT TO FIND EXACTLY WHAT YOU ARE LOOKING FOR WITH DIRECT QUESTIONS. TRY TO TACKLE BIGGER ISSUES BY ASKING QUESTIONS IN A MORE INDIRECT WAY. THIS APPROACH CAN LEAD TO MUCH GREATER, MORE UNEXPECTED INSIGHTS."
Marissa Vosper

EXPERT PANEL
EXAMPLE: SMITHSONIAN

Project Description
The Smithsonian Institution was founded in 1846 with 'The increase and diffusion of knowledge' as their mission. After more than a century and a half of amazing success in America and the world, the Smithsonian realized it was time to think about the future. They began a strategic planning effort in 2009 and approached Wolff Olins in 2010 with the challenge of building a brand based on that strategic foundation. As our key client liked to say, the Smithsonian had become one of the world's most beloved brands 'by accident' and it was finally time to build a brand based on intent and ambition. The brief for Wolff Olins was to craft a brand strategy that would take the institution into the next decade: more modern, more relevant, more impactful, for more people, more often. With this brief we worked collaboratively with a large multi-disciplinary team from across the organization to define a powerful brand strategy and tagline that encapsulated their internal goals, but also pushed them to think outside of the box and live up to their potential as one of the world's greatest platforms for learning.

Timing

7 WEEKS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
ALICIANNE RAND
JACOB COHEN

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The Smithsonian is the world's largest museum and research complex – with 19 museums, 9 research centers, 168 affiliate museums and represented in 90 different countries – they are unlike any other cultural institution in the world. Because their collection and knowledge base covers art, culture, history and science, we needed to understand the world of education and learning at large (rather than the world of "museums") and gain a multitude of really different, really radical and forward-thinking perspectives. Expert industry interviews were a perfect match for the Smithsonian to help them gain a unique outside perspective, and push them to understand that other companies and peers are already "doing" and thinking in new and different ways. And, we knew the industry interviews would help support our macro-trends findings and help validate our over all insights and desk research.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used the tool during the insights phase of the project process, although we started talking to the client and planning for the interviews as soon as we kicked off the project. Getting to an agreement on which experts we should tap into (and why) was an important first step. And, we needed to reach out to different contacts (Wolff Olins contacts and Smithsonian connections) to get in touch with the interviewees and schedule meeting dates.

How was it used?
We conducted 8 external interviews during the insights phase in order to gain an objective view of people's perceptions of the Smithsonian today, what it will take for the Smithsonian to make a difference in the future and how they could deliver on this.

We started by brainstorming companies that we would love to interview in relation to the Smithsonian (and our macro trends). What companies are doing amazing things in the world of education and learning? Who is making a difference in terms of the "increase and diffusion" of knowledge (the Smithsonian mission statement) and how are they using technology and social media to deliver this? What companies deliver a consistent branded experience across all touch points (particularly when the touch points and engagement channels are wide/diverse)? Who takes really big ideas and makes them actionable, accessible, relevant and friendly?

We delivered an initial presentation of our interview recommendations to the Smithsonian, which included objectives of the process, interview suggestions, and the reasons for recommending each. The rationale behind why we chose the interviews was important as it helped us make sure we were not focusing too strongly on any one category (i.e. technology) and helped our client understand who the companies were and why they were relevant (not everyone is familiar with "Blackboard"). We developed the rationale in tandem with the macro trends – although we didn't necessarily need one for the other, having a big picture perspective did help us articulate what kind of companies we wanted to reach out to and why. An important note: it was extremely important that we only select companies that we had contacts at or previous relationships with so that it wouldn't be a far stretch to set up an interview. Moreover, we included back up options for the interviews in case we were unable to reach our first choice.

Our final list of external industry experts included: NASA, Blackboard, National Geographic, Disney, Science Museum of Minnesota, Mayo Clinic, Clay Shirkey (technology expert), Wikimedia, Greg Trefry (gaming expert), Henry Jenkins (New Media), NSF (National Science Foundation)

Example questions (for Blackboard) included:
–How do you see technology shaping or changing today?
–Do you think the shift in technology is in the way time is spent? Is that a result of outside players looking in or did that start from the inside?
–How is technology changing the way students are learning?
–What do you think Smithsonian's role in the world could be?
–How can you take the experience of seeing the real thing and aligning it to the digital world?
–What do you think of the Smithsonian today?

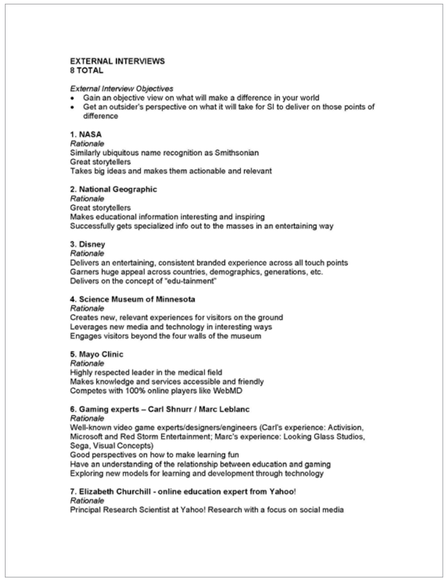
How much time did it take?
The entire process took about 7 weeks –
–1 week to brainstorm the interview ideas and develop the rationale for each
–2 weeks to present interview recommendations, refine and agree on the final list
–2 weeks to email potential interviewees and schedule meeting dates
–2 weeks to conduct interviews and develop/deliver a packet of detailed meeting notes to our client

How much did it cost?
–$16,000 (Senior Acct Manager 1.5weeks to prep, schedule interviews, and sit through interviews)
–$35,200 (Strategists 1.5 weeks
–develop interview list rationale, prepare for interviews, sit through interviews and read through notes/assess)
–$16,000 (5 days Strategy Director to prep and sit through interviews)
Overall the industry expert interviews cost roughly $67,200.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
We faced two major challenges – the first was getting buy-in and agreement to our recommended list of interviews. Our core team was large (about 12 people) and everyone had a different opinion on who we should talk to and why. Moreover, our scope specified a limited amount of external interviews so we needed to keep the final number realistic. The second challenge was scheduling. Do not underestimate the time it takes to reach out to interviewees, get a response and get on people's schedules. We split the work up between the Smithsonian and Wolff Olins (whoever had the contact/relationship was the person in charge of outreach), but this part of the process still took a solid 2 weeks to complete.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The industry expert interviews were really helpful – they helped support our macro trends and validated/gave credibility to a lot of our findings in our insights presentation. And, they were incredibly inspiring! They got our team thinking outside of the box, opened up our perspective (and our client's) and gave us access to fresh and exciting points of view.

Write-up by Alicianne Rand



EXTERNAL INTERVIEWS
8 TOTAL

External Interview Objectives
- Gain an objective view on what will make a difference in your world
- Get an outsider's perspective on what it will take for SI to deliver on those points of difference

1. NASA
Rationale
Similarly ubiquitous name recognition as Smithsonian
Great storytellers
Takes big ideas and makes them actionable and relevant

2. National Geographic
Rationale
Great storytellers
Makes educational information interesting and inspiring
Successfully gets specialized info out to the masses in an entertaining way

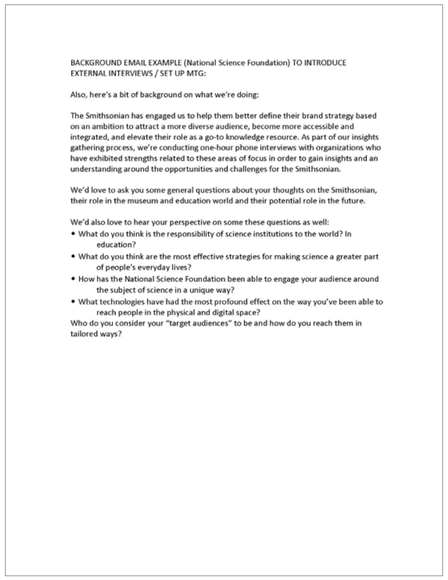
3. Disney
Rationale
Delivers an entertaining, consistent branded experience across all touch points
Garners huge appeal across countries, demographics, generations, etc.
Delivers on the concept of "edu-tainment"

4. Science Museum of Minnesota
Rationale
Creates new, relevant experiences for visitors on the ground
Leverages new media and technology in interesting ways
Engages visitors beyond the four walls of the museum

5. Mayo Clinic
Rationale
Highly respected leader in the medical field
Makes knowledge and services accessible and friendly
Competes with 100% online players like WebMD

6. Gaming experts – Carl Shnurr / Marc Leblanc
Rationale
Well-known video game experts/designers/engineers (Carl's experience: Activision, Microsoft and Red Storm Entertainment; Marc's experience: Looking Glass Studios, Sega, Visual Concepts)
Good perspectives on how to make learning fun
Have an understanding of the relationship between education and gaming
Exploring new models for learning and development through technology

7. Elizabeth Churchill - online education expert from Yahoo!
Rationale
Principal Research Scientist at Yahoo! Research with a focus on social media



BACKGROUND EMAIL EXAMPLE (National Science Foundation) TO INTRODUCE EXTERNAL INTERVIEWS / SET UP MTG:

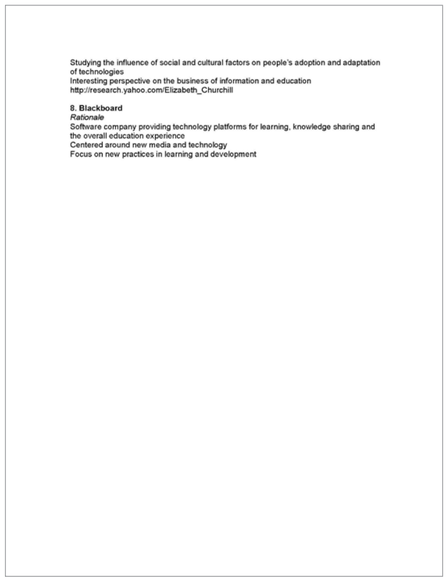
Also, here's a bit of background on what we're doing:

The Smithsonian has engaged us to help them better define their brand strategy based on an ambition to attract a more diverse audience, become more accessible and integrated, and elevate their role as a go-to knowledge resource. As part of our insights gathering process, we're conducting one-hour phone interviews with organizations who have exhibited strengths related to these areas of focus in order to gain insights and an understanding around the opportunities and challenges for the Smithsonian.

We'd love to ask you some general questions about your thoughts on the Smithsonian, their role in the museum and education world and their potential role in the future.

We'd also love to hear your perspective on some these questions as well:
- What do you think is the responsibility of science institutions to the world? In education?
- What do you think are the most effective strategies for making science a greater part of people's everyday lives?
- How has the National Science Foundation been able to engage your audience around the subject of science in a unique way?
- What technologies have had the most profound effect on the way you've been able to reach people in the physical and digital space?

Who do you consider your "target audiences" to be and how do you reach them in tailored ways?



Studying the influence of social and cultural factors on people's adoption and adaptation of technologies
Interesting perspective on the business of information and education
http://research.yahoo.com/Elizabeth_Churchill

8. Blackboard
Rationale
Software company providing technology platforms for learning, knowledge sharing and the overall education experience
Centered around new media and technology
Focus on new practices in learning and development

SUPER PANEL

GENERATE UNEXPECTED CREATIVE INSIGHTS

GETTING TO CONSUMER/
CONTEXT INSIGHTS

WHAT
A Super Panel is a short creative workshop that is custom designed to generate breakthrough insights particularly in crowded, competitive market segments.

WHY
Super Panels can provide interesting, unexpected and deep insights into a category, consumer mind-set, or psychographic perspective. Running a Super Panel can provide rich stimuli to our insight pool for brand strategy development. A Super Panel can also provide innovative concepts to kick off a creative generation process, or provide clients with refreshing, unbiased, and thought-provoking insights that can stimulate new ways of thinking.

HOW
The participants in a Super Panel are Super Panelists - a carefully selected group of people that can provide unexpected, tangential insights on a client's business, brand and future ambition. Super Panelists may be industry specialists, or more often relevant consumers, but also bring a second skill set to the Super Panel such as high creativity verbally or visually, acting skills, or any other unexpected talent. We tend to think more laterally about 'relevant' expertise, recruiting people with backgrounds in creative fields, maybe alternative fields, who have an interesting link or perspective to the client's business or industry in order to generate penetrating insights. The Super Panel will be a custom designed workshop, facilitated by us in-person in a group setting; the Super Panelists will be doing the work.

WHO
–Clients looking to reposition or launch into highly competitive markets.

WHEN
–Ideal for the insights phase of a project, especially when breakthrough insights are needed. Can also be used to provide ideas for creative stimulus.

WITH
–Other qualitative research methodologies

"THIS METHODOLOGY CAN PROVIDE THE MOST SURPRISING INSIGHTS. IT TAKES WORK TO RECRUIT AND DESIGN A SUPER PANEL, BUT ALWAYS PROVIDES UNIQUE OUTPUTS."
Angie Riley

SUPER PANEL
EXAMPLE: MCNEIL SPECIALTY PHARMACEUTICALS

Project Description
McNeil had developed a new medication that it wanted to launch into a very over-crowded and competitive segment – the over-the-counter allergy-control sector. This sector was chock-full of brands that all competed on rational proof-points, and consequently all looked the same. Additionally the client had already conducted a large amount of quantitative and qualitative market research, without generating any informative insights.

Timing

5 WEEKS

Team

ANGIE RILEY

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We developed a differentiated brand for a new OTC allergy medication and needed to find a break-through consumer insight to help us develop a game changing position for this new brand. A Super Panel was the ideal insight-generating tool to use.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used the tool during the insights phase of the project process, although we started talking to the client and planning for the Super Panel as soon as we reviewed the client's research in the kick-off process. Deciding on which Super Panelists we should invite to participate was an important first step, although it is typically not done in collaboration with the client, as they are unlikely to have the kind of alternative, creatively talented participants we would need to recruit. We needed to reach out to different contacts to get in touch with the potential participants to check availability for one date when they could all convene to take part in the Super Panel.

How was it used?
We recruited a group of 8 Super Panelists who were available to meet for 2.5 hours one evening after working hours. (You can also work with 6 or so Super Panelists.) Snacks and beverages were made available, and the environment for the Super Panel should be creative and inspiring.

The criteria for recruitment of the Super Panelists for this particular Super Panel was that they must be a professional visual artist i.e. not a poet, writer etc., and must also be a heavy allergy sufferer.

We provided a wide variety of visualization tools including paints, crayons, fabrics, foam, sticky-bobs, wood and foil items etc., and developed two exercises for the Super Panelists to complete:

1. We asked them to visually depict their experience of having an allergy attack.
2. We asked them to visually depict the ideal relief for an allergy attack.

Interestingly, each artist in the Super Panel chose a collage of mixed materials to depict both their allergy attack and the ideal relief. And even more interesting was the connective themes between many of their visualizations, both for the allergy attack and for the ideal solution.

How much time did it take?
The entire process took about 5 weeks –
– 2 weeks to develop the initial concept for the Super Panel, present to client and agree to proceed.
– 2 weeks to recruit the Super Panelists
– 1 day to gather materials and set-up for the Super Panel
– 1 evening to execute the Super Panel
– 1 week to capture the outputs, synthesize and report back to the client.

How much did it cost?
– $9,800 (Junior Acct Manager 7 days to prep, schedule interviews, and attend Super Panel)
– $10,800 (Strategy Director 3 days to design and facilitate process and Super Panel)
– $2,800 ($350 participation fee per Super Panelists)
– $2,000(Food, beverages, materials, hard costs)
Overall a Super Panel costs roughly $25,400

Which challenges did you face along the process?
Care needs to be taken in the initial stages to communicate the benefits and goals of a Super panel to the client. It is an innovative insight-generating methodology, which is unfamiliar to most clients. Additionally the recruitment of the Super Panelists is critical to the success of generating useful insights. In this case the profile of artists who also suffered from severe allergies was the right profile, but would not be relevant for a pain medication for example.
The style of communication used to recruit Super Panelist is also important. Usually the type of person we want to recruit is highly creative, talented and highly desirable, so care needs to be taken to attract them to take part. They are usually not doing it for the small incentive fee; they are usually attracted to take part, as it is a creative process that they will enjoy.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The outcome was extremely helpful as the Super Panelists gave us very illuminating visual insights into both allergy and relief, which informed both the name and the visual brand expression for the medication.

Write-up by Angie Riley

Super Panel documentation examples



CHARACTERIZING THE CONDITION

An invisible spider's web

Enveloping, ensnaring, encircling cyclone

You can't see the assailant

An impersonal, environmental energy force

SEMIOTICS

DECODE YOUR COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

UNDERSTANDING THE
CLIENT'S BUSINESS

WHAT
Semiotics is a way of visually and verbally decoding a company's direct competitors and adjacent categories to better understand the market and identify opportunities to differentiate.

WHY
Semiotics is useful to obtain insight and confirm gut instinct about opportunities within a market and to determine how differentiated a brand is from its competitors. It is a way of collecting data to identify shifts and trends that exist in the attributes competitors and adjacent categories are communicating to the customer. By decoding these components, we gain an alternate perspective that brings objectivity to the visual identity development process. This is a great decision-making tool for clients to be pointed toward a direction supported by the data. The scientific aspect of the tool can provide the confidence needed to help the client make a bolder leap.

HOW
After studying the market as a whole, subjects are selected and analyzed using in-depth audits that look at visual and verbal cues such as font, color, photography and language. The data is broken into different groups to find opportunities and can be used in combination with the Competitor Audit Map's communication analysis (see tool description).

WHO
–Clients who tend to be more rational, data-driven decision makers that need factual support to make a bold decision
–Companies that have a lot of stakeholders and need clarification to come to consensus

WHEN
–Very useful in the insights-empathy phase
–Can be revisited later in the process when discussing identity options

WITH
Competitor Audit Map

"ONE THING I LOVE ABOUT SEMIOTICS IS THAT IT ENGAGES DESIGNERS AT A VERY EARLY STAGE OF THE PROJECT. HAVING STRATEGISTS AND DESIGNERS WORK TOGETHER FROM THE VERY BEGINNING MAKES THE PROJECT THAT MUCH STRONGER."
Nick O'Flaherty

VALUE PROPOSITION WORKSHOP

GAIN CLARITY ON THE VALUE
YOU DELIVER TO THE WORLD



UNDERSTANDING THE
CLIENT'S BUSINESS



DEVELOPING
A STRATEGIC SOLUTION

WHAT
The Value Proposition Workshop helps us to define a brand's purpose and the value it brings to the world.

WHY
The workshop is used to help the client get crystal clear on the value they want to bring to customers. It facilitates discussion on how the company should shape its business to successfully deliver that value. It also helps the client gain focus and internal alignment on what they are working towards. The interactive setting encourages discussion and co-creation of the value proposition.

HOW
We present value propositions directions based on findings from the insights phase. Instead of using power point presentations, we present our ideas and insights on big boards, making the workshop experience interactive and engaging. We do not spend much time talking at clients, but focus on facilitating a conversation. We tailor the experience to the client, creating exercises and stimuli specific to their business and industry.

WHO
–Companies that are changing their business model drastically
–Clients that need focus and alignment to come to consensus

WHEN
–The Value Proposition is based on the insights-phase of the project and informs brand worlds

WITH
–Business Model Canvas
–All tools used in the insights-phase (i.e. Best Practices, Competitive Audit, Background Research)

"I FOUND CHECK-INS WITH THE CLIENT BEFORE THE VALUE PROPOSITION WORKSHOP REALLY HELPFUL. IT HELPED US TO CHOOSE THE APPROPRIATE ACTIVITIES AND STIMULI FOR THE MEETING, BUT ALSO TO CHOOSE DIRECTIONS WE KNEW THE CLIENT WOULD BE COMFORTABLE WITH."
Melissa Andrada

VALUE PROPOSITION WORKSHOP
EXAMPLE: ASA

Project Description
American Student Assistance (ASA) is a nonprofit organization whose business model was based on guaranteeing federal loans. Their business model effectively ended with the termination of the Federally Funded Education Loan Program. They asked us to help them develop a brand for their new product, a student membership organization, which would resonate with schools, sponsors and most importantly students. We developed a brand around the idea of Money Coach — incenting young people to be financially savvy. We also convinced them to create a new name for their product — Salt.

Because they were so pleased with our process and team, this has led to new streams of work – so far, a campus campaign and architecture workshop, and potentially a brand refresh and employee engagement strategy.

Timing

2 WEEKS

Team

SAM WILSON
MELISSA ANDRADA
JACOB COHEN
CHRISTIAN BUTTE
DANIELLE HORANIEH
MIRIAM MEISCHBERGER

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
With ASA's need to refocus and create a new direction for their core business it was important for us to frame up the brand purpose from a unified value proposition. In our research and internal interviews it was clear that the value proposition for the new business was not clear across senior staff. For our work to be successful we needed to ensure all stakeholders were in agreement on their future direction. With agreement we were able to reach a brand purpose and create brand worlds much more effectively.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
After the insights phase the value proposition workshop was our first recommendation to the client. We combined the presentation of our insights and used them to frame up the workshop goals and guardrails.

How was it used?
What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
i.The preparation for the value proposition workshop focused on synthesizing our findings in the insights phase and integrating our thinking around the business model canvas.
ii.We then created the workshop materials that we used in the team section of the workshop from the framework of the business model canvas.
iii.Because we combined the workshop with our insights presentation we were able to frame up a point of view and work factors of decision making into the workshop and have the material handy for reference.

.The workshop took two days and was conducted both off-site and at the ASA headquarters. The first part of the off-site day was spent presenting our insights and point of view on ASA, their audience's needs and intents and presenting a competitive analysis of best practices.
v.The majority of day one was spent broken into three teams and using a series of business model canvas-influenced, pre-printed 20x30 boards to gather each teams feedback. Each team was given one of three value propositions and tasked with proving the value of their assigned proposition. They were told that they would be presenting their point of view back to the group at the end of the day to then vote on the most compelling idea. ASA team members were given a set of pens and post-it notes and the Wolff Olins' facilitator inspired and managed the flow. Our goal was to keep each team focused on the task at hand while getting to the meat of the teams' ideas within the time available, once the teams had formulated a perspective.
vi.Day two was a presentation of the synthesis of day one, a recap of the vote and series of exercises to further refine the output of the day. The goals for day two were to refine the brand idea, identify challenges to their business idea and clarify skillsets they will need to get where they want to be.

How much time did it take?
i.Preparation for the workshop took about a week.
ii.The workshop was a two-day workshop with another couple of days to synthesize the outputs and deliver a PDF to ASA of the workshop.

What resources did you use?
i.Competitive Analysis
ii.Trends research
iii.Internal Interviews
iv.External Interviews
v.Business Model Canvas
vi.Whiteboards and more whiteboards
vii.Workshop materials: scrolls, 20x30 boards, post-its

How much did it cost?
Approximately $70,000

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
i.The tool was a synthesis of our insights phase and helped us get to a direction on brand purpose and brand worlds.

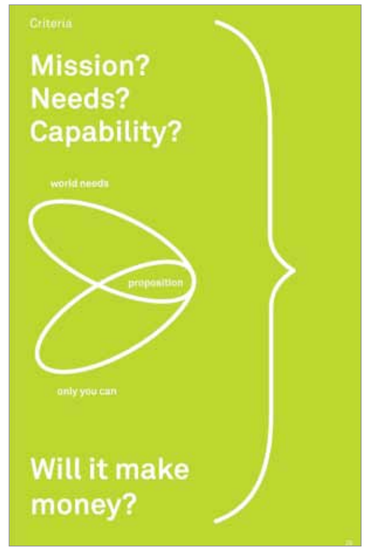
Which challenges did you face along the process?
Aside from the previously identified challenges around the business model canvas, the preparation for the workshop was fairly smooth. The main challenge was editing and simplifying the language of our insights.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The output of the workshop was a clear and actionable value proposition: Money Coach. This allowed us enough room to create two unique brand purposes and develop unique brand worlds around each direction. But the workshop's primarily benefit was to get ASA's senior staff on the same path. It resolved confusion on what they hoped to achieve with their new business and gave them permission to push themselves.

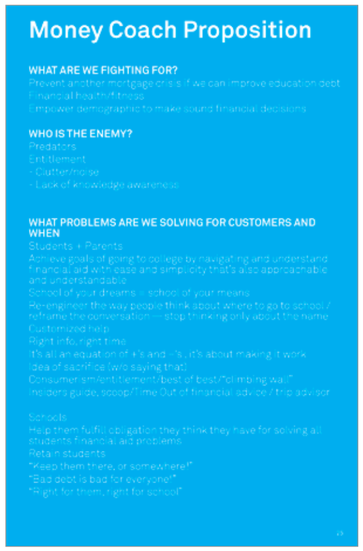
Write-up by Jacob Cohen

Boards used for Value Proposition Workshop







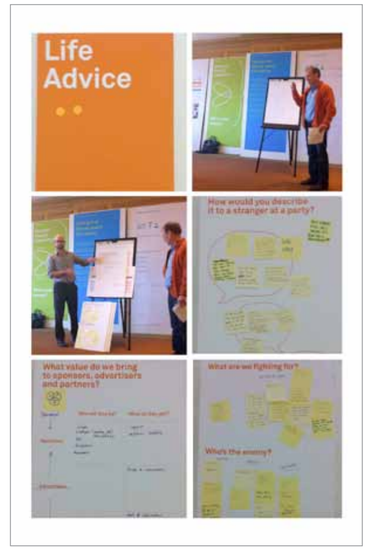












VALUE CURVE

ZAG WHERE OTHERS ARE ZIGGING

UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS

DEVELOPING A STRATEGIC SOLUTION

WHAT
The Value Curve is a qualitative, visual tool that we use to map where a brand stands within its industry. It helps identify areas of differentiation or overlap based on predefined factors of competition in a market.

WHY
The Value Curve provides insight on competitive standing and opportunities, informing brand strategy and positioning. It can be used for both current state and future aspirations, helping to define which existing factors the client wants to change and which new ones they would like to introduce. It does not prescribe which set of choices to make but it highlights potential white spaces, forming a starting point for discussion and additional research.

HOW
Though it depends on the type of project, we usually start out by brainstorming factors of competition in a workshop setting with the client or based on desk research. These factors will be listed on the Value Curve's horizontal axis. The vertical axis represents "relative level" from low to high. We then plot the client and its current and emerging competitors based on their relative standing on those factors of competition. By plotting the brand against its main competitors, its current state and future aspirations can be defined.

WHO
–Companies that need to make a big change to their business model and/or brand
–Clients who need clarity and a "bigger picture" view of their competitive landscape

WHEN
–At the beginning stage of the project to start discussion with the client and understand their ambition
–At a later stage to present the potential "future-state" of the brand, seeing if desired differentiation exists

WITH
–Spectrum
–Can be done in a workshop setting
–Or through desk research

"I LIKE DOING THE VALUE CURVE WITH THE CLIENT IN A WORKSHOP SETTING AS IT GIVES THEM A GREAT PERSPECTIVE AND MAKES THEM THINK ABOUT THEIR COMPANY IN A NEW WAY, AND THAT CAN BE VERY ENLIGHTENING FOR THEM."
Amaris Singer

VALUE CURVE
EXAMPLE: EXPEDIA

Project Description
Expedia, the category creator of online travel aggregation and trip buying, had once led the industry but in recent years, had been eclipsed by start-ups and more nimble players. Wolff Olins was brought in by the new CEO of Expedia to help him articulate his new vision for the business and facilitate the participation and buy-in of his senior team.

Timing

30 MINUTES

Team

IJE NWOKORIE
KARL HEISELMAN
NATHAN WILLIAMS
AMARIS SINGER
YELENA FORD
TOM WASON

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The Value Curve had already been used in the first workshop to help the client see where they mapped out against their competitors on the main factors of competition in the category's current state. We used it again in the second workshop to see how much more differentiation would be achieved mapping their future state (assuming the new business model).

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
The Value Curve was used in the first and second workshops with the client, both of which happened in the beginning phase of the project.

How was it used?
During the first session, the factors of competition were brainstormed in the workshop and then plotted together by the group. During the second workshop, the intention was to build upon that map and see Expedia's potential future state to understand where the new business model would differentiate.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
All the inputs came from the workshop, but were informed by everyone's knowledge with and experience in the category/ project.

How much time did it take?
It can be a short exercise within the workshop, maybe 30 minutes.

What resources did you use?
The strategists and clients presence at the workshop.

How much did it cost?
Depending on the research scope that goes into the development of the value curve it can cost between $5,000 - $50,000.

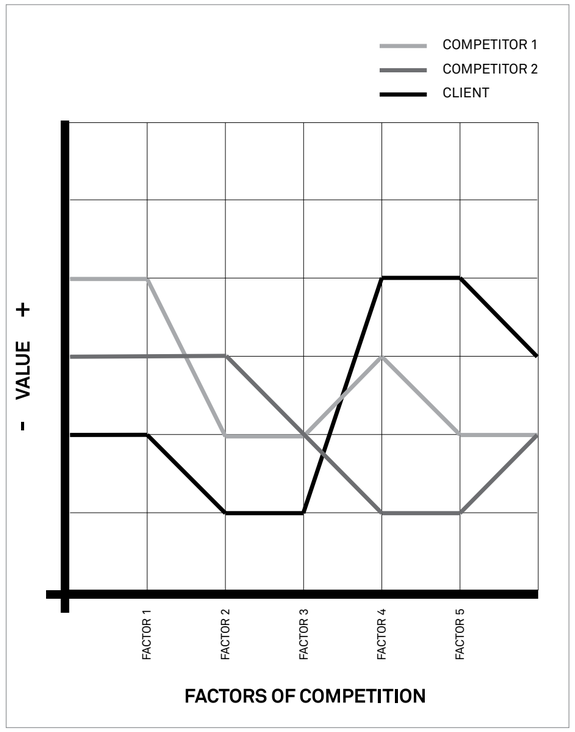
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
The workshops used several tools, including the business model canvas and spectrum. All of these tools helped the clients make choices about their future business model and consider some potential impacts of their choices.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
None, really. The workshop was a great setting to work through this tool and benefit from the clear competitive picture it presents.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The outcome was really based on the entire workshop, which was useful to the client in fleshing out and further aligning the specifics of their new business model. The value curve, however presents a view of the category that shaped conversations about where the client stands currently and where they want to go.

Write-up by Amaris Singer

Value Curve diagram template



CHOICE SPECTRUM

CLARIFY FUNDAMENTAL QUESTIONS ABOUT A BRAND OR BUSINESS MODEL



UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS



DEVELOPING A STRATEGIC SOLUTION

WHAT
The spectrum is a visual tool that forces choice, gauges ambition and facilitates lively discussion about the future of a brand and industry.

WHY
This exercise can help answer fundamental questions about the brand and/or business model, serving as a critical foundation for brand world explorations. By having the brand's stakeholders discuss their choices together, a final solution can be co-created with the client. The spectrum's biggest value lies in the clarity it delivers to the stakeholders about their needs and wants, and areas of disagreement that must be addressed to realize them.

HOW
The exercise is usually done in a workshop, on a scroll with a series of binaries that represent potential choices clients could make about their brand. Between each binary is a spectrum, with boxes representing incremental points between the two extremes. We help the different stakeholders to plot their perspective on each binary and then work towards achieving consensus through a final combined plot. The number and types of the binaries used depend on the project and are derived from all existing knowledge, research and selective assumptions.

WHO
Companies that need to...
–Make a big change to their business model and/or brand
–Overcome internal disagreement

WHEN
–In the beginning stages of a project to provide critical alignment and clarity on foundational aspects of the brand and/or business model

WITH
–Value Curve
–In a workshop setting with the client

"IT IS IMPORTANT TO GET REALLY SPECIFIC WHEN CHOOSING THE BINARIES, SO THE CLIENT CAN REALLY FIND OUT WHAT IT IS THEY WANT. IF THEY ARE UNSURE ABOUT CERTAIN POINTS YOU KNOW THAT YOU NEED TO HELP THEM IN THOSE AREAS AND NARROW IN ON THINGS THAT NEED MORE ATTENTION."
Amaris Singer

CHOICE SPECTRUM
EXAMPLE: EXPEDIA

Project Description
Expedia, the category creator of online travel aggregation and trip buying, had once led the industry but in recent years, had been eclipsed by start-ups and more nimble players. Wolff Olins was brought in by the new CEO of Expedia to help him articulate his new vision for the business and facilitate the participation and buy-in of his senior team.

Timing

1–2 HOURS

Team

IJE NWOKORIE
KARL HEISELMAN
NATHAN WILLIAMS
AMARIS SINGER
YELENA FORD
TOM WASON

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We decided to use the tool because it was a concrete way to force choice and create discussion around very detailed elements of the client's potential future business model. We were trying to create a degree of alignment that could help establish the business model foundation for us and for the client going forward. We were also trying to highlight the areas of consensus as well as remaining disagreement.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used the tool early on in the project during the second workshop with the client.

How was it used?
It was used during the second workshop to force specific choices around a range of business model elements that would shape their future. We split the client workshop group into two smaller groups and had them complete the exercise together on a worksheet. Then we plotted the two groups' responses on the big scroll and discussed and reconciled where possible to form an aggregated plot.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
During the workshop prep beforehand, we kept a running list of major elements that would need to be decided upon and framed these as binaries, based on everything we knew from the client and were learning on our own. This running tally was eventually edited down and organized by different categories to become the spectrum tool used in the workshop.

How much time did it take?
The time to actually do the exercise took probably an hour to an hour and a half, due to robust discussion. The exercise was intended to take less time, however, and depends a lot on how much content is included and how controversial that content is!

What resources did you use?
The whole workshop team really helped develop and deploy this tool. The important thing is that the workshop subgroups each need a facilitator to guide them through the exercise.

How much did it cost?
Including preparation time, administration and the workshop the Spectrum can cost between $40,000 - $120,000.

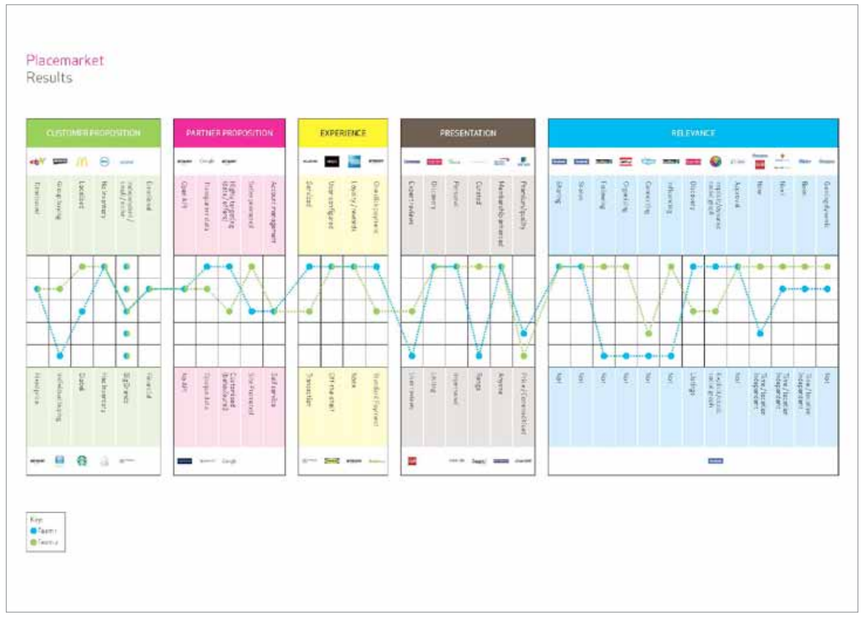
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
The workshops used several tools, including the business model canvas and value curve. All of these tools helped the clients make choices about their future business model and see/ponder some potential impacts of their choices.

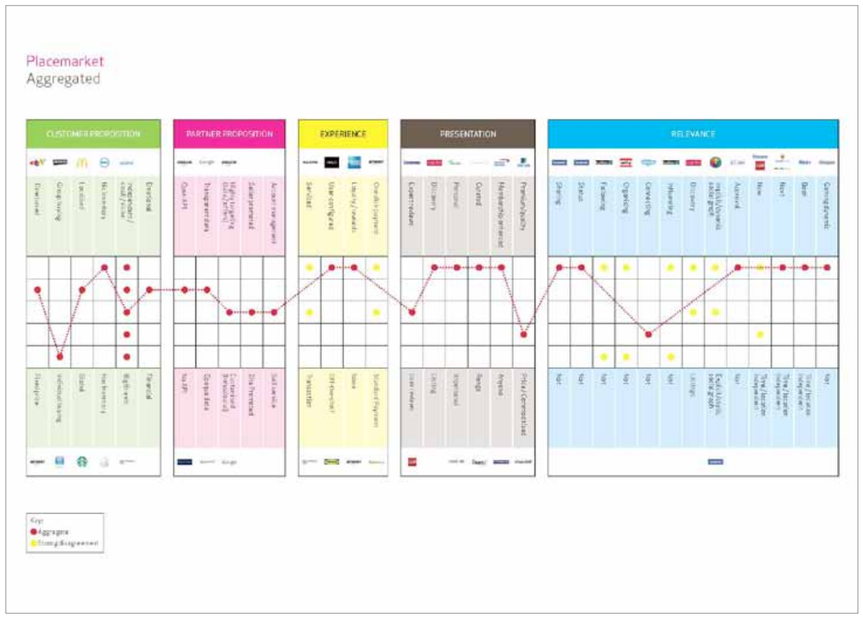
Which challenges did you face along the process?
None, really. The workshop group was eager to participate and found the exercise quite clarifying.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The outcome was useful to the client in fleshing out and further aligning on the specifics of their new business model, while also pinpointing where they still needed agreement. They found the whole exercise to be clarifying for them and a tool that they could show to the extended members of their team when explaining the company's new direction and the thinking that informed it.

Write-up by Amaris Singer

Part of workshop results





BUSINESS MODEL WORKSHOP

GET CRYSTAL CLEAR ON YOUR BUSINESS STRATEGY

UNDERSTANDING THE CLIENT'S BUSINESS

DEVELOPING A STRATEGIC SOLUTION

WHAT
The Business Model Canvas is a hands-on tool that facilitates development and discussion around a new or existing business model. We use it to analyze how an organization currently creates, delivers and captures value in order to set the stage for future brand strategy development.

WHY
This tool facilitates holistic conversations about brand and business ambitions by contextualizing them in big picture thinking and visualizing them in an interactive way. It also allows an organization to tweak elements of the canvas and see the impact on the rest of the model, highlighting future opportunities for the business. In a nutshell: the business model canvas is an engaging, visual way of capturing strategic, high-level thinking that clarifies the business vision.

HOW
We evaluate a business model based on a combination of nine building blocks, which generally make up the canvas – Customer Segments, Value Propositions, Channels, Customer Relationships, Revenue Streams, Key Resources, Key Activities, Key Partnerships and Cost Structure. These building blocks cover the four main areas of any business – customers, offer, infrastructure and financial viability. We tend to work together with our clients, to build out the canvas and discuss implications/opportunities in a participatory workshop. Given the breadth and complexity of the canvas, it can be used more discretely to focus on specific areas of the business.

"WHEN USING THE BUSINESS MODEL CANVAS IT IS REALLY IMPORTANT TO GET THE VALUE PROPOSITION RIGHT. IF THAT PART OF THE CANVAS IS RIGHT EVERYTHING ELSE WILL FALL INTO PLACE."
Richard Houston

WHO
–Clients that need to rethink their existing business model
–Companies that need to invent/innovate a new business model

WHEN
Very useful "kick-off meeting" tool to establish a common language and framework to think about the business

WITH
–Itself - can be used as "present" and "future" versions to highlight gaps and analyze shifts necessary to move the business from present state to future state

BUSINESS MODEL WORKSHOP
EXAMPLE: ASA

Project Description
American Student Assistance (ASA) is a nonprofit organization whose business model was based on guaranteeing federal loans. Their business model effectively ended with the termination of the Federally Funded Education Loan Program. They asked us to help them develop a brand for their new product, a student membership organization, which would resonate with schools, sponsors and most importantly students. We developed a brand around the idea of Money Coach — incenting young people to be financially savvy. We also convinced them to create a new name for their product — Salt.

Because they were so pleased with our process and team, this has led to new streams of work – so far, a campus campaign and architecture workshop, and potentially a brand refresh and employee engagement strategy.

Timing

2+ WEEKS

Team

SAM WILSON
MELISSA ANDRADA
JACOB COHEN
CHRISTIAN BUTTE
DANIELLE HORANIEH
MIRIAM MEISCHBERGER

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
Because ASA was going to a significant transformation in their business as well as their brand, we integrated elements of the Business Model Canvas as part of a workshop to nail down a brand direction.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used the targets of the Business Model Canvas in a brand purpose workshop to help structure the goals of senior staff for the business moving into the future.

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
i.We reviewed the insights from our internal and external interviews and desk research to formulate three brand directions for ASA. These were created in line with the client's identified needs.
ii.We then used the Business Model Canvas to look at how these three brand directions affected the business from each business factor. This allowed us to edit and optimize the directions based on how they affected each side of the business.
iii.For the workshop we sought the input from senior management around each brand direction. To match up with the analysis that helped define those directions we framed each workshop question around a section of the Business Model Canvas. This allowed us to gather comparative information without forcing the client to fill out each element of the Business Model Canvas.

How much time did it take?
i.In the review of the brand directions against the factors in the Business Model Canvas we spent about one week reviewing and editing the brand directions.
ii.The workshop took one day and another week was spent on synthesizing the output from the workshop to examine implications of the direction and how to divide it into two, unique Brand Worlds.
iii.Next time we could spend more time and be more comparative with the results of the workshop against the Business Model Canvas. We could then use this as a brainstorming tool for expressions and engagement options in Brand Worlds.

What resources did you use?
i.Business Model Canvas
ii.Whiteboards and more whiteboards
iii.Workshop materials: scrolls, 20x30 boards, post-its

How much did it cost?
The Business Model Canvas was used very loosely as part of the workshop, and can therefore not separated from the cost of the whole workshop, which was about $70,000.

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
i.Used during the development of brand directions and in the process of transitioning into Brand Worlds.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
None of us had used the Business Model Canvas before. There was some back and forth on what some sections meant for the business and customer.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
It helped us to have a framework that could define consistency. The Business Model Canvas has more specific sections than the quadrant, making it easier to gather comparative data from the client and research.

Write-up by Jacob Cohen

Workshop documentation example



BRAND BUTTERFLY

DISCOVER A BRAND'S POTENTIAL



STARTING A
CONVERSATION



DEVELOPING
A STRATEGIC SOLUTION

WHAT
The Brand Butterfly is a tool designed to help create a brand idea and inform the brand positioning based on the intersection of what the world needs and what is special about a company.

WHY
We discover the special sauce at the core of a brand by looking at a company from the inside out and the outside in. The output of this process is the brand idea - a succinct, clear statement of purpose that is meaningful to the client's internal team, inspires the creation of better realities for their audience and stakeholders, and supports the organization's business vision.

HOW
Insights gained through consumer, competitor, industry and company interviews, primary and secondary research, category expertise and gut instinct inform the development of the brand idea. The specific research and analysis ingredients necessary for each project will be determined in collaboration with the client. At the beginning of our process, we generally identify 2-3 distinct brand idea options, which we use to explore different possibilities for the client's future. We then work together to narrow in on the one idea that best supports the company's potential.

WHO
Companies in need of a new brand idea/purpose/focus/positioning

*Note: this tool is used on most projects

WHEN
–At the beginning of a project used in a simplified version, i.e. in pitches to communicate our understanding of the problem and to start a conversation
–As the outcome of the insights phase of a project

WITH
–Macro Trends
–In-Depth Interviews
–Ethnographic Research
–Social Media Audits
–Customer Journey
–Legacy information

"I THINK IT IS IMPORTANT TO REFRAME THE MAIN QUESTIONS OF THE BUTTERFLY TO BE SPECIFIC TO EACH PROJECT. ROBERT JONES FOR EXAMPLE PRESENTED THE BUTTERFLY IN AN INTERESTING WAY – HE TURNED 'WHAT THE WORLD NEEDS' INTO 'WHAT IS WRONG WITH THE WORLD'. BY CHANGING THE QUESTION YOU ARE ASKING YOU MIGHT GET TO A VERY DIFFERENT PLACE IN TERMS OF YOUR ANSWERS."
Melissa Andrada

BRAND BUTTERFLY
EXAMPLE: THE RITZ-CARLTON

Project Description
The Ritz-Carlton came to Wolff Olins in 2011 with the challenge of building out their rewards program. The original program (The Ritz-Carlton Rewards) had been launched rather quickly in the fall of 2010, and was based around the idea of Access to the Extraordinary. The Ritz-Carlton asked Wolff Olins to take that positioning and expound on it. The main ambition of the project was to create a rewards proposition that lived up to The Ritz-Carlton brand – one that was differentiated and truly extraordinary in the market, one that helped The Ritz-Carlton more deeply engage with their best customers, provided a clear filter for potential partnerships, and one that pushed The Ritz-Carlton to a more technologically-forward, more innovative space in the minds of their target audience.

Timing

3–4 WEEKS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
DAN ZUZUNAGA
JESSE DAVIS
EMILY SEGAL

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The core client stakeholders had very different opinions with regards to what success looked like for the project. We used the butterfly as a means to get them to agree on what was special about their company and what the world (their customer) needed.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
The assignment started with a deep dive into the culture of the Ritz-Carlton, we travelled around the world to visit different properties, talk to customers as well as staff and pulled together insights from the world of loyalty in general. We used the butterfly as a way to distill this information into a digestible one page brief that would guide the second stage of our work.

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
First we distilled the information we gathered into key insights, we then took these and applied them to the different sides of the butterfly. We presented the butterfly first to our main client and then to the bigger client group. It was clear after that meeting that we needed to rework the butterfly to reflect ideas/language that the client wanted addressed. We then presented a revised version to key client stakeholders and received approval to move forward.

How much time did it take?
Gathering the insights took roughly 3 weeks, applying them to the butterfly for the first round took about 2 days, presentation to the client and revisions took another week.

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 1 account manager, and 1 strategy intern

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes the tool was used as a culmination of the research and insights phase.

How much did it cost?
The insights phase leading up to the butterfly (including interviews of RC executives, focus groups, kick off meeting with client, desk research and the creation of the insights presentation) cost roughly $155,000 and $11,000 in out of pocket costs such as printing, travel, accommodations, etc.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
I think our biggest challenge was getting the client to understand how the butterfly is used. We would have benefitted greatly by explaining our process and then showing them their butterfly – we ended up showing them a case study after the first round after which they had a much better perspective on how to use this tool and where their input would be the most helpful.

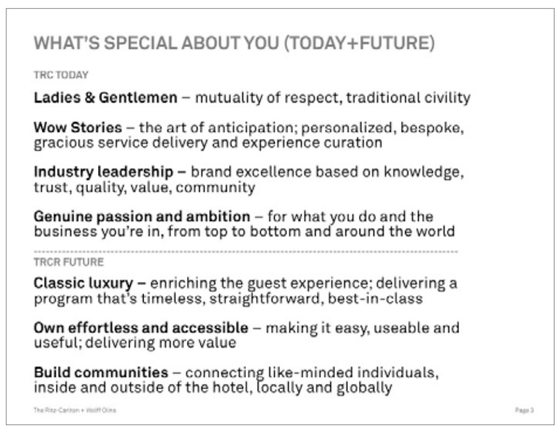
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The project is still in progress

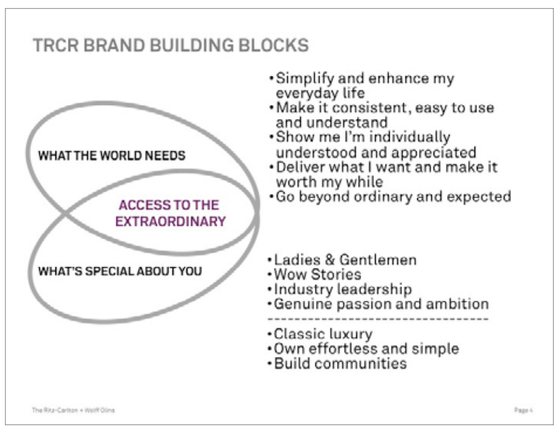
Write-up by Dan Zuzunga

Brand Butterfly as part of insights presentation









MODIFIED BRAND BUTTERFLY
EXAMPLE: PG&E

Project Description
As one of the oldest utilities in the United States, Pacific Gas and Electric Company was struggling to find a balance between two increasingly conflicting priorities: focusing on the fundamentals providing reliable energy and service to customers, while also striving for innovation, leading the way in the fight against climate change.

PG&E enlisted Wolff Olins to create an on-purpose brand to unify their leadership around a powerful ambition, mobilize and inspire their employees and create a strong platform for growth the first since the company was founded 103 years ago.

Timing

A FEW HOURS

Team

SAM WILSON
NICK O'FLAHERTY
BILL DARLING
ALICIANNE RAND
JESS CHALIFOUX

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We modified the original butterfly in the roll out of the brand idea to garner better understanding of where the idea came from, and what it was designed to do. Including "our business need"/ strategy helped show the link between corporate strategy and brand. The vision at PG&E was a platitude (leading utility in the US) –and brand needed to work extra hard to give color to the vision and strategy of PG&E.

At what point in the process did you use the tool? And how was it used?
During the roll out (PPT and workshops)

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
After shopping the idea around with employees – we realized the modification was necessary

How much time did it take?
A few hours of discussion with our client!

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 1 account manager

How much did it cost?
Approximately $5,000 - $10,000

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Launch planning and workshops

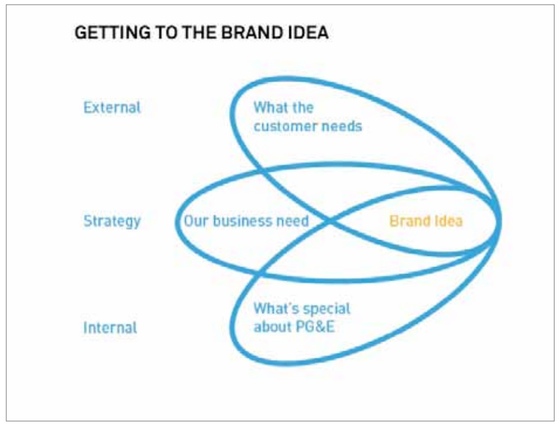
Which challenges did you face along the process?
The extra wing compromises the simplicity of the butterfly somewhat – but we felt it necessary for employee buy in and understanding

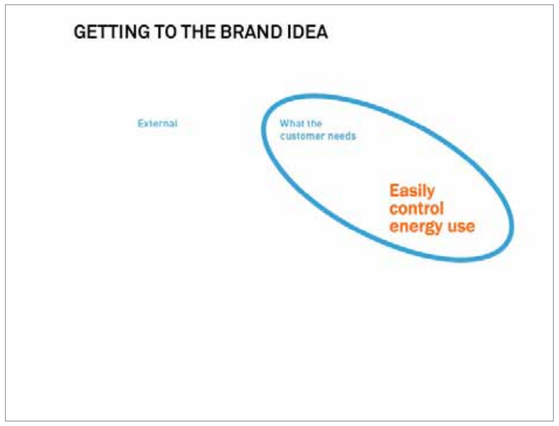
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
Greater employee buy in and understanding of the brand. More color and specificity around PG&E's business strategy

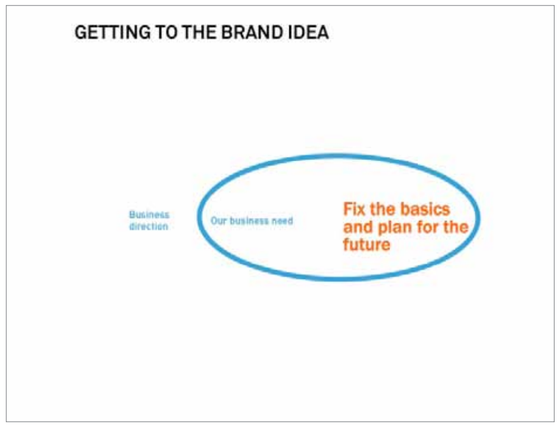
---

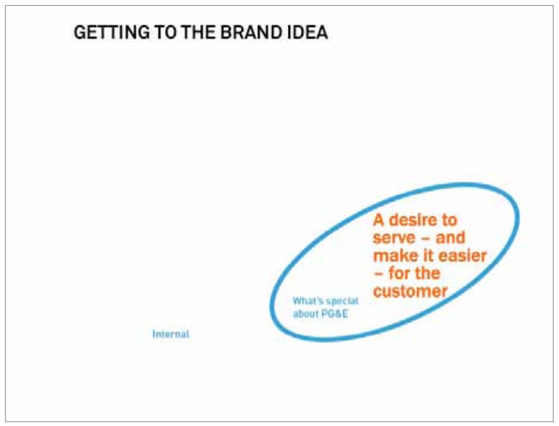
Write-up by Nick O'Flaherty

Brand Butterfly modified as part of the rollout presentation









BRAND IMPACT QUADRANT

EXPLORE HOW A BRAND IDEA CAN IMPACT A BUSINESS

DEVELOPING
A STRATEGIC SOLUTION

WHAT
The Brand Impact Quadrant helps you explore the different ways a brand positioning can be interpreted and applied across the business.

WHY
The Brand Impact Quadrant shows how a brand is articulated across key touch points. Externally it ensures that the company is serving up the right image and communications, backed up by the right offerings and actions. Inside the organization, the brand system helps to guarantee that the client not only has the right capabilities and skills to do what the strategy and brand demand, but that they also provide for the right behaviors and cultural environment that bring about the changes we want to see and that the brand will need to succeed.

HOW
We usually use the Brand Impact Quadrant as an exercise with the clients in a workshop setting and fill out its different areas based on conversation and discussion. This exercise is great to test different brand ideas by putting them in the center of the tool and seeing how the quadrants transform according to the content. Working together with the client is important to get a better understanding of internal biases, future expectations and helps us to clarify the overall client vision and define the brand idea, which further informs the brand world development.

WHO
–Company in need for a new or refreshed brand purpose
–Company looking for a big, overall direction

WHEN
Tool is usually used after the insights-phase and before the brand worlds (see tool description) and helps to define the brand purpose

WITH
–Brand Butterfly
–Brand Worlds

“WHEN DEFINING THE BRAND IMPACT QUADRANT, IT IS IMPORTANT TO KEEP THE BALANCE BETWEEN ENCOMPASSING EVERY PART OF THE BUSINESS AND NOT MAKING THE LIST UNNECESSARILY LONG.”
Jacob Cohen

BRAND IMPACT QUADRANT
EXAMPLE: ASA

Project Description
American Student Assistance (ASA) is a nonprofit organization whose business model was based on guaranteeing federal loans. Their business model effectively ended with the termination of the Federally Funded Education Loan Program. They asked us to help them develop a brand for their new product, a student membership organization, which would resonate with schools, sponsors and most importantly students. We developed a brand around the idea of Money Coach — incenting young people to be financially savvy. We also convinced them to create a new name for their product — Salt.

Because they were so pleased with our process and team, this has led to new streams of work – so far, a campus campaign and architecture workshop, and potentially a brand refresh and employee engagement strategy.

Timing

1 DAY

Team

SAM WILSON
JACOB COHEN
MELISSA ANDRADA
CHRISTIAN BUTTE
DANIELLE HORANIEH

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We used this tool to help us explore the different ways our brand positionings "Can-Do Finance" and "Incenting Financial Savviness" would affect ASA's internal culture, capabilities, image, communications, and offering.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
The middle – in preparation for brand worlds

How was it used? What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
After the value proposition workshop, we began working on brand worlds (see brand worlds for more info). To figure out the implications of each brand world on ASA, we used the brand impact quadrant. We sat down together and brainstormed ideas for each area of the quadrant. We then used the quadrant to concept tools and experiences for the brand worlds. The quadrant was placed on the descriptor board for each brand world.

How much time did it take?
One day

What resources did you use?
To craft the brand impact quadrant, our team consisted of 3 strategists (1 lead, 2 support), 2 designers, 1 account manager, and 1 production manager. The brand impact quadrant was placed on the descriptor board for each brand world.

How much did it cost?
Roughly $10,000 – $12,000

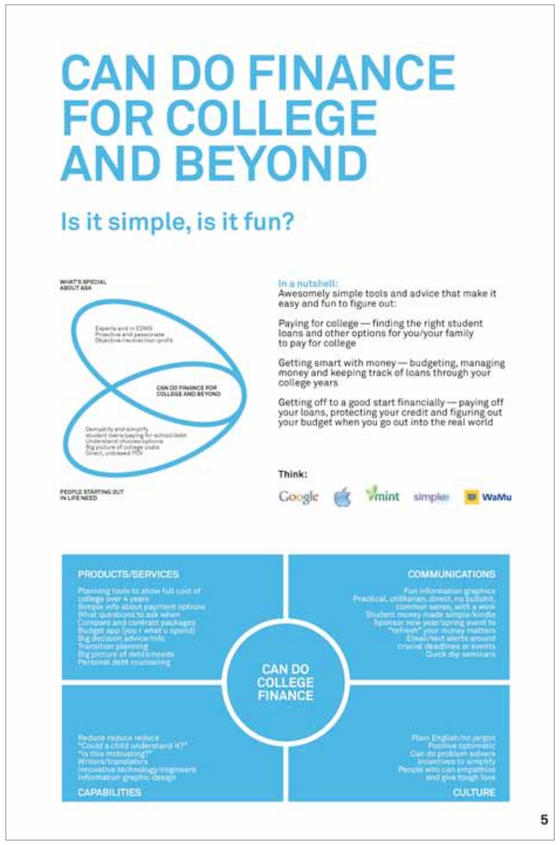
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
We used this tool in combination with the Brand Butterfly, Student Journey, and Brand Worlds for the Brand Worlds Workshop. This tool was useful for laying out the foundation for the Brand Worlds workshop and thinking about the implications of each brand world for ASA.

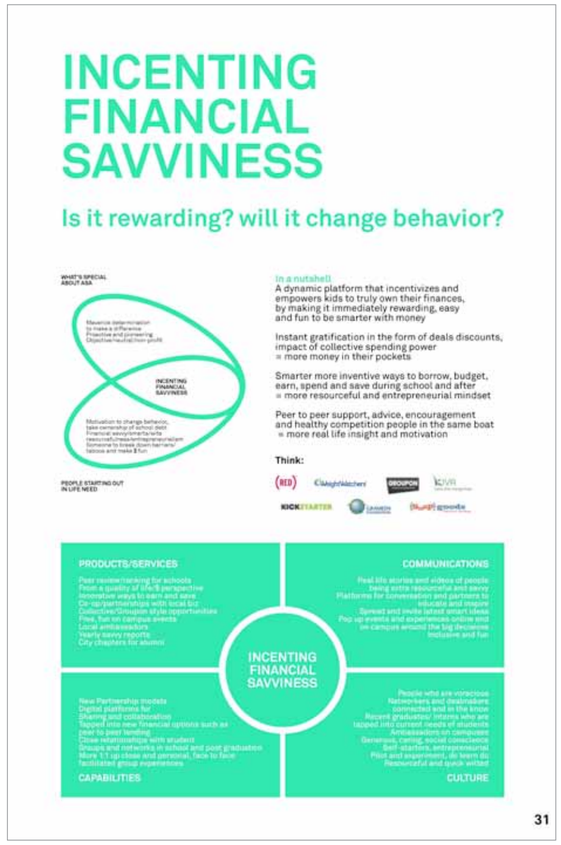
Which challenges did you face along the process?
None that come to mind.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
As a supporting tool for brand worlds, the final outcome was hugely successful. Brand worlds really helped the directions come life, and the client picked the direction that was truly game changing.

Write-up by Melissa Andrada

Brand Impact Quadrant as part of the Brand Worlds presentation





BRAND IMPACT QUADRANT
EXAMPLE: SMITHSONIAN

Project Description
The Smithsonian Institution was founded in 1846 with 'The increase and diffusion of knowledge' as their mission. After more than a century and a half of amazing success in America and the world, the Smithsonian realized it was time to think about the future. They began a strategic planning effort in 2009 and approached Wolff Olins in 2010 with the challenge of building a brand based on that strategic foundation. As our key client liked to say, the Smithsonian had become one of the world's most beloved brands 'by accident' and it was finally time to build a brand based on intent and ambition. The brief for Wolff Olins was to craft a brand strategy that would take the institution into the next decade: more modern, more relevant, more impactful, for more people, more often. With this brief we worked collaboratively with a large multi-disciplinary team from across the organization to define a powerful brand strategy and tagline that encapsulated their internal goals, but also pushed them to think outside of the box and live up to their potential as one of the world's greatest platforms for learning.

Timing

A FEW WEEKS

Team

MARY ELLEN MUCKERMAN
MARISSA VOSPER
ALICIANNE RAND
JORDAN CRANE

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
The brand quadrant is a helpful structure for organizing thoughts around how a brand might come to life throughout an organization – it's also a great way of reinforcing the point that when brands are successful, they impact the entire organization – not just the marketing/communications efforts of that organization. For the Smithsonian, it was very important to bring the high-level 'brand theory' (brand idea/purpose) down to the more tactical, everyday level. Because we had such a broad audience of stakeholders with largely no marketing/branding experience, we had to show them how our strategy would start to rollout in ways they could understand.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?
We used the brand quadrant throughout the process. We used it early on in our initial meetings as part of our 'Brand 101' tutorial – to help provide the Smithsonian team with a foundation for understanding and evaluating our work later on. We then used the quadrants during our brand worlds phases to help demonstrate how our high-level ideas translated into real world implications. As we honed in on the final strategy, we also honed in on the resulting brand quadrant – one of our final deliverables to the Smithsonian. Additionally, with each brand idea + brand quadrant, the strategic thought included in these tools was used as the creative brief for our visual applications – it helped guide our thinking in terms of which applications we should visualize and it helped our design team understand how our applications should look and feel.

Finally, as the Smithsonian team began with the implementation of the new brand strategy, they continued to use the brand quadrant internally to help people throughout the organization understand the strategy and brainstorm ways in which the strategy could be applied to their particular unit or job.

How was it used?
See above answer.

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
Each time we brainstormed a potential brand idea or territory (using the brand butterfly / distiller tool), we used the brand quadrants to further develop and play out our thinking. The quadrants were essentially used as structure for brainstorming and honing thinking.

How much time did it take?
Hard to assign a concrete time because we used the quadrants throughout our engagement... They could take a few hours to brainstorm and then refine over the course of a few weeks or it could be longer or shorter...

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 1 designer, 1 account manager

How much did it cost?
It is hard to put a budget on the brand impact quadrant as it was used throughout the project, almost from beginning to end.

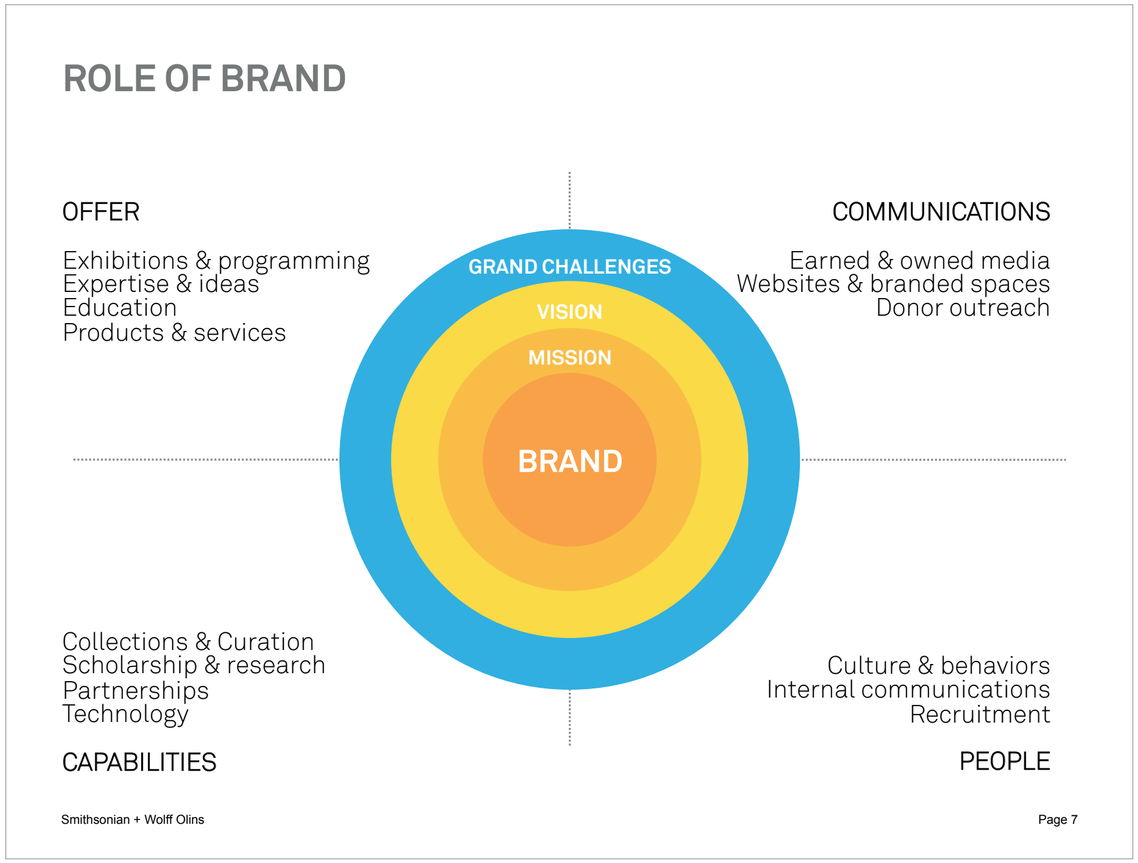
Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Yes, the quadrants are a direct output of the brand idea, which comes from the brand butterfly / distiller tool.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
It's challenging to craft the right words for the brand quadrants that are descriptive enough to make the implications actionable and understandable, but not so specific that they're not useful as a broad, directional tool.

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The quadrants were really useful for the Smithsonian. It really helped them understand that a new brand meant changes throughout the organization. It also helped them guide rollout, since they are such a large organization, because the tool was flexible enough to be used up and down and across the organization.

Write-up by Marissa Vosper

Brand Impact Quadrant as part of the insights presentation



BRAND WORLDS

“TEST DRIVE” A COMPANY’S FUTURE

DEVELOPING
A STRATEGIC SOLUTION

WHAT
Brand Worlds are used to express brand ideas verbally and visually to explore what a company’s future could look like.

WHY
By defining distinctively different ideas and territories, we create distinctively different visions of the future across key touch points. We show notional examples such as product and services, customer experience, environments and marketing communications. We use a rich combination of words, images, and video, to give the client the opportunity to “test drive” these different versions of the future, understand its implications and make bold choices based on high-level exploration.

HOW
We present brand worlds in a workshop setting with key stakeholders. We use the workshop to understand and discuss the implications of potential brand ideas on all the major touch points of the business. By the end of the workshop, you will have a clearer sense of the center of gravity for the brand.

WHO
–Company in need for a full brand refresh
–Company with the desire to own a brand that is game changing

WHEN
–Usually used after all the insights are gathered and brand purposes are defined
–Brand Worlds inform the brand promise

WITH
–Brand Butterfly
–Brand Impact Quadrant

“IT IS IMPORTANT TO BUILD UP THE INTERNAL RELATIONSHIP WITH THE MAIN STAKEHOLDERS AND GET THEM EXCITED ABOUT THE BRAND WORLD OPTIONS. WE NEED TO CREATE CHEERLEADERS THAT GET THE REST OF THE COMPANY EXCITED AND READY TO PICK AN OPTION.”
Jacob Cohen

BRAND WORLDS
EXAMPLE: ASA

Project Description
American Student Assistance (ASA) is a nonprofit organization whose business model was based on guaranteeing federal loans. Their business model effectively ended with the termination of the Federally Funded Education Loan Program. They asked us to help them develop a brand for their new product, a student membership organization, which would resonate with schools, sponsors and most importantly students. We developed a brand around the idea of Money Coach — incenting young people to be financially savvy. We also convinced them to create a new name for their product — Salt.

Because they were so pleased with our process and team, this has led to new streams of work – so far, a campus campaign and architecture workshop, and potentially a brand refresh and employee engagement strategy.

Timing

2–3 WEEKS

Team

SAM WILSON
JACOB COHEN
MELISSA ANDRADA
CHRISTIAN BUTTE

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
We used this tool to help ASA gain a better understanding of the implications of potential brand directions and make a decision on one final direction.

At what point in the process did you use the tool?

How was it used?

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
After the value proposition workshop, we brainstormed two brand directions. One of our challenges was to ensure that the two directions felt legitimately different. Traditionally, the three divergent directions (Loan Guru, Money Coach, Life Advice) we came up with for the value proposition workshop would be used for the brand worlds workshop. The idea we landed on in the value proposition workshop was “Money Coach” and we had to figure out how to polarize this idea. We ultimately landed on “Can Do Finance for College and Beyond” (Simple tools) and “Incenting Financial Savviness” (Peer-to-Peer movement). Once we had the two directions defined, we used the brand impact quadrants to see how each direction would impact their brand. We then used the student journey to identify the pain points and prioritize areas of importance for each direction. Strategists and designers worked together simultaneously to concept, write and design the tools, applications and experiences for each direction. The brand worlds ultimately took the form of big scrolls, which we then mounted onto big boards.

Before our big meeting in Boston, we had a smaller, work-in-progress meeting with our day-to-day clients in NYC. This provided us with the time and feedback to improve the scrolls and amp up the direction (“Incenting Financial Savviness”) we wanted them to choose for our big meeting. This work-in-progress session also made our day-to-day clients feel more ownership over the brand worlds. I highly suggest making the experience feel as collaborative as possible.

How much time did it take?
Design and strategy were working on parallel tracks. It took about two and a half weeks to concept, write and design the applications for each brand world. The process was very fast and furious.

What resources did you use?
To craft the brand worlds and prepare for the workshop, our team consisted of 3 strategists (1 lead, 2 support), 2 designers, 1 account manager, and 1 production manager. The brand worlds took the form of scrolls on big boards and a pdf.

How much did it cost?
The cost of the brand world development ranged between $160,000 – $170,000 ($180,000 including the naming process).

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
The brand butterfly and brand impact quadrant helped inform the kinds of tools, products and services they would have to develop to pull off each direction. The student journey helped us identify the pain points and prioritize the areas of importance for each direction.

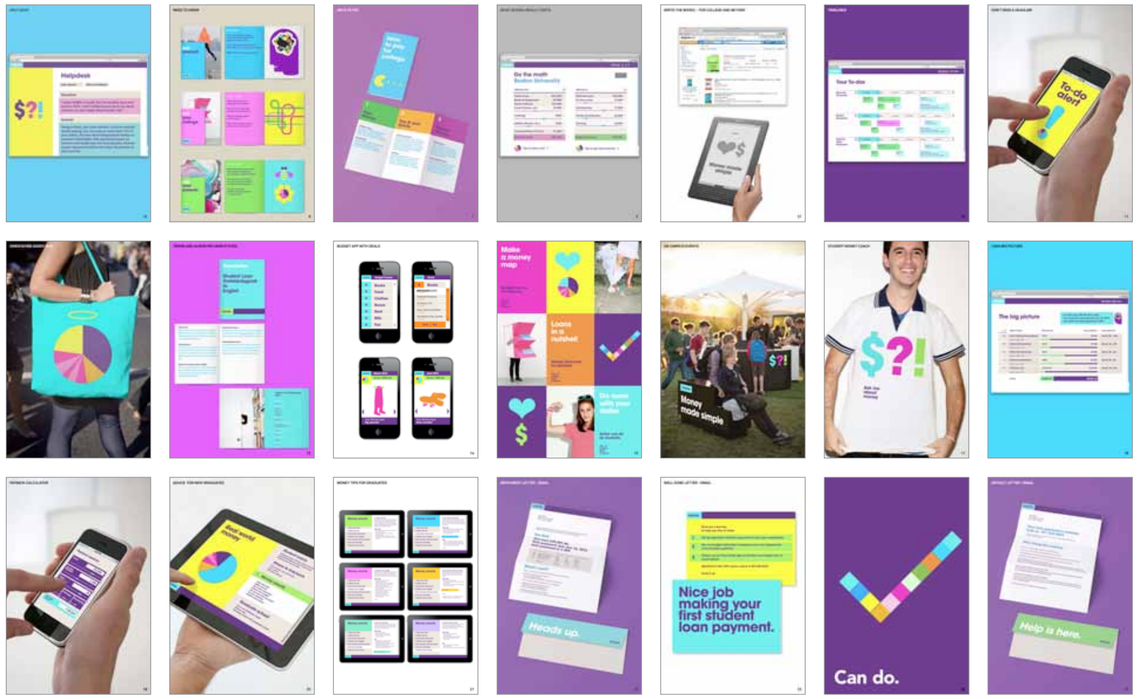
We also conducted a naming exercise during the brand worlds workshop.

Which challenges did you face along the process?
The digital agency partner, HUGE was concerned that ASA might take some of the tools and applications – particularly the digital ones – literally, and would ask HUGE to build them. We worked through their concerns by emphasizing the work was notional and intended to illustrate the implications of the brand world.
See question 4. for more challenges.

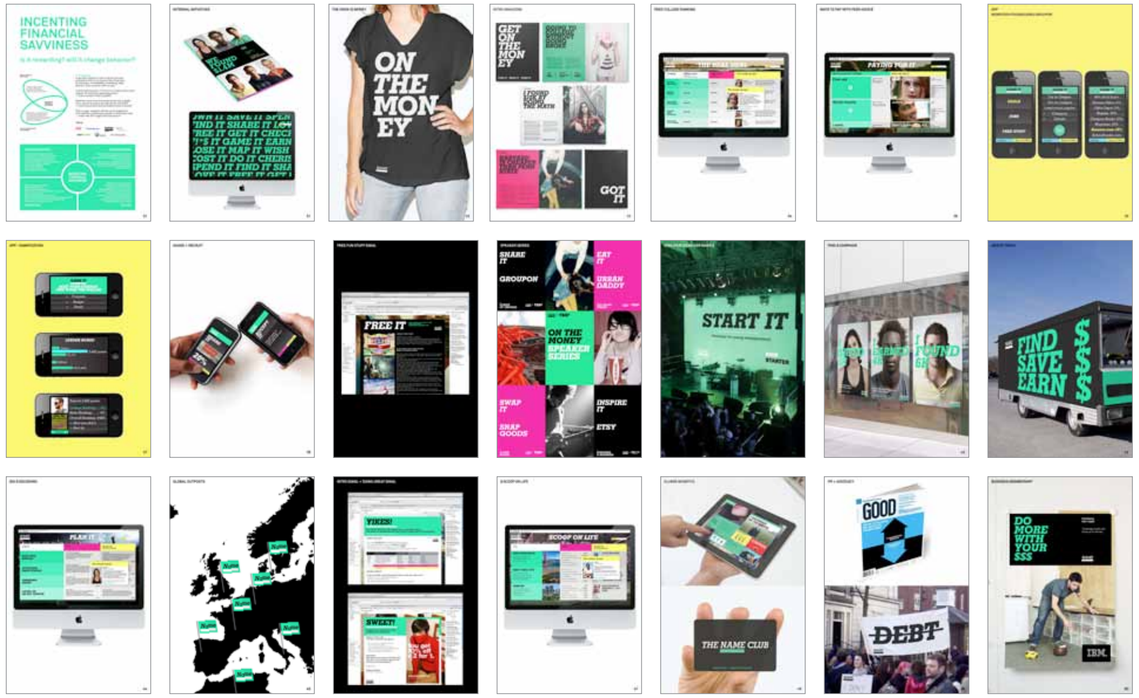
What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
The final outcome was hugely successful. Brand worlds really helped the directions come life, and the client picked the direction that was truly game changing.

Write-up by Melissa Andrada

Brand world 1



Brand world 2



BRAND WORLDS
EXAMPLE: PG&E

Project Description
As one of the oldest utilities in the United States, Pacific Gas and Electric Company was struggling to find a balance between two increasingly conflicting priorities: focusing on the fundamentals providing reliable energy and service to customers, while also striving for innovation, leading the way in the fight against climate change.

PG&E enlisted Wolff Olins to create an on-purpose brand to unify their leadership around a powerful ambition, mobilize and inspire their employees and create a strong platform for growth the first since the company was founded 103 years ago.

Timing

4–5 WEEKS

Team

SAM WILSON
NICK O'FLAHERTY
BILL DARLING
ALICIANNE RAND
JESS CHALIFOUX

Why did you decide to use the tool and what were you trying to accomplish by using it?
Help leadership understand the implications of different directions for the PG&E brand. Build alignment amongst a polarized group of officers

At what point in the process did you use the tool? And how was it used?
Post the insights phase

What steps did you take? Were any previous inputs required?
Management interviews, trend and desk research, ethnographic research

How much time did it take?
4-5 weeks

What resources did you use?
2 strategists, 2 designers, 1 account manager

How much did it cost?
The price ranged between $100,000 – $200,000.

Did you use the tool in combination with others? Why?
Brand butterfly – showing how each of the four ideas were based in what the world needed, and what was unique about PG&E and its people

Which challenges did you face along the process?
An extremely polarized group of leaders – it became a highly consultative process

What was the outcome and how was it useful to the client?
By talking through the implications, pros and cons of each idea, the brand world exercise brought healthy dialogue amongst a very divided leadership group. It led to consensus among the group for the first time regarding the direction of the company

Write-up by Nick O'Flaherty

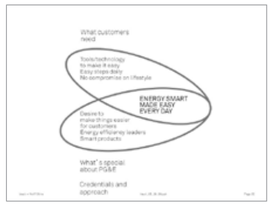
















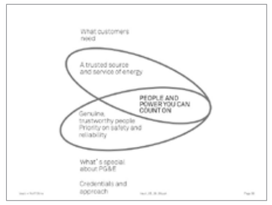
























KEEP IT COMING

THIS TOOLKIT DEPENDS ON YOU TO STAY RELEVANT. SHARE YOUR KNOWLEDGE WITH FELLOW STRATEGISTS BY ADDING PROJECT EXAMPLES TO EXISTING TOOLS AND ENRICHING THE CONTENT WITH NEW TOOLS YOU FOUND HELPFUL.

HAVE YOU USED A TOOL AND HAD A VERY DIFFERENT EXPERIENCE FROM WHAT YOU'VE READ? PLEASE LET US KNOW SO WE CAN REFINE OUR APPROACH AND GET EVEN BETTER AT WHAT WE DO BEST – CREATING THE SPECIAL SAUCE TO BUILD SUCCESSFUL BRAND STRATEGIES.